

THE SHARP QUANTITATIVE FABER–KRAHN INEQUALITY VIA THE LEVEL-SET MOVING-BALL ROUTE (EXPLORATORY VERSION: THE CONSTRUCTIVE SERRIN–GRADIENT STRONG FORM)

ABSTRACT. We prove the sharp quantitative Faber–Krahn inequality: there is a dimensional constant $c_{\text{FK}}(n) > 0$ such that every open set $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ with $0 < |\Omega| < \infty$ satisfies

$$\left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n}\right)^{2/n} (\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*)) \geq c_{\text{FK}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2,$$

where λ_1 is the first Dirichlet eigenvalue, B^* the ball of the same volume, and $\mathcal{A}$ the Fraenkel asymmetry; the exponent 2 is sharp. The proof is organised around the torsion function and the unscaled moving-ball distance $q(\rho) = \inf_z |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|$ on its superlevel sets E_ρ . On reduced boundaries and for almost every level we establish an exact level-set deficit identity expressing the Saint–Venant deficit as a weighted integral of a Cauchy–Schwarz defect D_H and an isoperimetric defect D_I ; nestedness gives a perimeter-free Lipschitz bound for q ; a finite-perimeter affine first variation for q , a positive kinetic estimate, and an endpoint trace yield bounded sharp Saint–Venant stability $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C(n, R) \delta_T(\Omega)$ for $\Omega \subset B_R$. A constructive De Giorgi truncation removes the confinement, and the Kohler–Jobin rearrangement transfers the Saint–Venant estimate to the eigenvalue. This is the *exploratory* version of the manuscript: in place of the Fusco–Julin strong form it isolates a single *constructive* (compactness-free) Serrin strong-form estimate for torsion level sets (Assumption 5.2) and attempts to discharge it through a weighted Reilly–Weinberger identity on the level sets. That input remains open for general domains; it is discussed, with the precise obstruction and concrete further directions, in Remark 5.3. Apart from it and standard tools for sets of finite perimeter, the argument – including the bounded reduction and the Kohler–Jobin inequality – is self-contained.

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1. INTRODUCTION

For an open set $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ ($n \geq 2$) with $0 < |\Omega| < \infty$, let $\lambda_1(\Omega)$ denote its first Dirichlet eigenvalue and B^* the ball with $|B^*| = |\Omega|$. The Faber–Krahn inequality asserts $\lambda_1(\Omega) \geq \lambda_1(B^*)$, with equality only for balls. This paper proves its sharp quantitative form.

Theorem 1.1 (Sharp quantitative Faber–Krahn). *There is a constant $c_{\text{FK}}(n) > 0$, depending only on n , such that every open set $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ with $0 < |\Omega| < \infty$ satisfies*

$$\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) := \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n} \right)^{2/n} (\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*)) \geq c_{\text{FK}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2,$$

where $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) := \inf_{x_0} |\Omega \Delta (x_0 + B^*)|/|B^*|$ is the Fraenkel asymmetry. The exponent 2 is sharp.

This is the theorem of Brasco–De Philippis–Velichkov [3]; the present draft gives a structurally different proof, conditional only on the constructive Serrin strong-form input isolated in Assumption 5.2 and on standard tools for sets of finite perimeter.

Strategy. The eigenvalue is reached only at the very end, through the torsion function $u = u_\Omega$ ($-\Delta u = 1$ in Ω , $u \in H_0^1(\Omega)$) and its Saint–Venant deficit $\delta_T(\Omega) = E(\Omega) - E(B^*)$, $E = -\frac{1}{2} \int u$. The heart of the paper is the *sharp Saint–Venant stability* estimate $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$, obtained by working directly with the torsion superlevel sets $E_\rho = \{u > t(\rho)\}$ of volume $\omega_n \rho^n$ and the *unscaled* moving-ball distance

$$q(\rho) := \inf_{z \in \mathbb{R}^n} |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|.$$

Because the family $\{E_\rho\}$ is nested, q is uniformly Lipschitz (Lemma 7.3); this is what lets the sparse set of bad-density radii be charged by Lebesgue measure rather than by the deficit.

Outline. The proof proceeds in three blocks.

(I) *Bounded Saint–Venant stability (§§3–9)*. Section 3 proves, on reduced boundaries and for a.e. level, the exact deficit identity $2\delta_T(\Omega) = \int_0^{\|u\|^\infty} (D_H + D_I)/(n^2 \omega_n^{2/n} m^{1-2/n}) dt$, where D_H is the Cauchy–Schwarz defect of $|\nabla u|$ on $\partial^* E_t$ and D_I the squared-perimeter isoperimetric defect;

Section 4 derives its profile-gap and bad-density consequences. Section 5 isolates the constructive Serrin strong-form input and converts it into same-centre control of the homothetic trace. Sections 6–8 prove a finite-perimeter affine first variation for q and the positive kinetic estimate, and Section 9 closes the bounded estimate $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C(n, R) \delta_T(\Omega)$ for $\Omega \subset B_R$ (Theorem 9.2).

(II) *Bounded reduction (§10)*. A constructive De Giorgi L^∞ truncation produces, from any Ω of small deficit, a bounded surrogate inside a dimensional ball with controlled loss of deficit and asymmetry; gluing the resulting bounded estimate to a trivial far-deficit branch removes the confinement and yields the global sharp Saint–Venant inequality $\delta_T(\Omega) \geq c_{SV}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$.

(III) *Kohler–Jobin transfer (§11)*. The Kohler–Jobin rearrangement, proved here from scratch, gives the scale-invariant comparison $T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^{(n+2)/2} \geq T_n \lambda_1(B_1)^{(n+2)/2}$; combined with the global Saint–Venant inequality and an elementary one-variable estimate it yields Theorem 1.1.

The one nonstandard missing input is Assumption 5.2; all other ingredients are either proved here or are classical tools for sets of finite perimeter, collected in Appendix A, and the dependency certificate of Appendix B.

2. STANDING NOTATION AND SCOPE

Fix $n \geq 2$, $R \geq 1$, and $0 < \rho_* < 1$. Let $\Omega \subset B_R$ be bounded and open with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, and let $u = u_\Omega \in H_0^1(\Omega)$ be the torsion function,

$$-\Delta u = 1 \quad \text{in } \Omega, \quad u = 0 \quad \text{on } \partial\Omega \quad (H_0^1 \text{ sense}).$$

We write the torsional rigidity $T(\Omega) := \int_\Omega u \, dx$, the Saint–Venant energy $E(\Omega) := -\frac{1}{2}T(\Omega)$, and the Saint–Venant deficit

$$\delta_T(\Omega) := E(\Omega) - E(B_1) = -\frac{1}{2} \int_\Omega u + \frac{1}{2} \int_{B_1} u_{B_1} \geq 0.$$

We write $\lambda_1(\Omega)$ for the first Dirichlet eigenvalue, B^* for the ball with $|B^*| = |\Omega|$, $L_n := \lambda_1(B_1)$, and $T_n := T(B_1) = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$; these enter only in the bounded reduction (§10) and the Kohler–Jobin transfer (§11).

Scope of the bounded core. Blocks (I) of the introduction – Sections 3–9 – are carried out under the standing normalisation $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and the confinement $\Omega \subset B_R$, with parameters $n \geq 2$, $R \geq 1$, $0 < \rho_* < 1$ fixed throughout. The confinement and the volume normalisation are both removed in §10 by scaling and a constructive truncation, so the final theorem holds for arbitrary open sets of finite measure.

Let $t(\rho)$ be the volume-radius parametrisation of the superlevels:

$$E_\rho := \{u > t(\rho)\}, \quad |E_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n, \quad 0 < \rho < 1.$$

Set

$$w(\rho) := -t'(\rho), \quad d\mu(\rho) = w(\rho) \, d\rho.$$

For a.e. ρ , E_ρ has finite perimeter, $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E_\rho \cap \{|\nabla u| = 0\}) = 0$, and the De Giorgi outer normal satisfies

$$\nu_\rho = -\frac{\nabla u}{|\nabla u|} \quad \mathcal{H}^{n-1}\text{-a.e. on } \partial^* E_\rho$$

(these level conventions are established in Lemma 3.1). On those levels define

$$V_\rho := \frac{w(\rho)}{|\nabla u|}, \quad H_{z,\rho}(x) := \frac{(x-z) \cdot \nu_\rho(x)}{\rho}, \quad \bar{V}_\rho := \frac{P(B_\rho)}{P(E_\rho)}.$$

The coarea relation of §3 (Lemma 3.2, with $w(\rho) \alpha(t(\rho)) = P(B_\rho)$) gives

$$(1) \quad \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} V_\rho d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P(B_\rho), \quad \bar{V}_\rho = \frac{1}{P(E_\rho)} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} V_\rho d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

The two level-set defects are

$$D_H(t(\rho)) := \left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) \left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) - P(E_\rho)^2, \\ D_I(t(\rho)) := P(E_\rho)^2 - P(B_\rho)^2.$$

Remark 2.1 (Scope). The bounded Saint-Venant estimate is deduced from the exact level-set identity (Theorem 3.11), proved in §3, and its profile-gap and bad-density consequences (Proposition 4.1). The same-centre good-level package (Theorem 5.11) rests on the constructive Serrin strong-form input of Assumption 5.2; the radial trace conversion from same-centre volume and normal control to the homothetic trace is Lemma 5.10. Every other step, including the first variation and the bad-density bookkeeping, is proved here.

3. FINITE-PERIMETER LEVEL-SET IDENTITIES

All integrals in this section are taken on De Giorgi reduced boundaries and all statements hold for almost every level; no smoothness of $\partial\Omega$, no graph parametrisation of the level sets, and no pointwise lower bound on $|\nabla u|$ are used. We keep the normalisation $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, so the ball of the same volume is B_1 ; the general case follows by scaling. Write

$$M := \|u\|_\infty, \quad L := |\Omega| = \omega_n, \quad m(t) := |\{u > t\}|, \\ \alpha(t) := \int_{\partial^* E_t} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}, \quad \beta(t) := \int_{\partial^* E_t} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}, \quad c_n := n^2 \omega_n^{2/n}.$$

By the Talenti pointwise comparison [17], $u^*(s) \leq u_{B_1}^*(s) = (1 - (s/\omega_n)^{2/n})/(2n)$, so $M \leq 1/(2n) < \infty$; here u^* is the decreasing rearrangement of u .

Regularity and level conventions.

Lemma 3.1 (Critical set and level conventions). *Let u be extended by 0 to $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then:*

- (a) $|\{u = 0\} \cap \Omega| = 0$ and $|\{\nabla u = 0\} \cap \Omega| = 0$;
- (b) for every $t \in (0, M)$, $|\{u = t\}| = 0$; hence m is continuous and strictly decreasing on $(0, M)$;
- (c) for a.e. $t \in (0, M)$: E_t has finite perimeter, $\partial^* E_t \subset \Omega$ up to $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -null sets, $\nu_{E_t} = -\nabla u/|\nabla u|$ $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -a.e. on $\partial^* E_t$, and $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E_t \cap \{\nabla u = 0\}) = 0$.

Proof. (a) Testing $-\Delta u = 1$ against $u^- \in H_0^1(\Omega)$ gives $\int |\nabla u^-|^2 = -\int u^- \leq 0$, so $u \geq 0$ a.e.; the weak strong maximum principle on each connected component yields $u > 0$ a.e. in Ω [13], i.e. $|\{u = 0\} \cap \Omega| = 0$. Interior elliptic regularity gives $u \in W_{\text{loc}}^{2,p}(\Omega)$ for all $p < \infty$; applying Stampacchia's theorem [16] to the weak derivatives $\partial_i u$ gives $D^2 u = 0$ a.e. on $\{\nabla u = 0\}$, while $\Delta u = -1$ a.e. Hence $|\{\nabla u = 0\} \cap \Omega| = 0$.

(b) For $t \in (0, M)$ the Sobolev chain rule applied to $(u - t)^+$ gives $\nabla u = 0$ a.e. on $\{u = t\}$; since $\{u = t\} \subset \{u > 0\} \subset \Omega$ up to a null set, part (a) gives $|\{u = t\}| = 0$. A jump of m at t would have size $|\{u = t\}| = 0$, so m is continuous on $(0, M)$. For $0 < a < b < M$, some component of Ω has essential supremum of u exceeding b ; on it $\{a < u < b\}$ is a nonempty open set of positive measure, so $m(a) - m(b) = |\{a < u \leq b\}| > 0$.

(c) By the BV coarea formula [14, Thm. 13.1], [1, Thm. 3.40], for every Borel $\varphi \geq 0$,

$$(2) \quad \int_{\Omega} |\nabla u| \varphi \, dx = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \left(\int_{\partial^* E_t} \varphi \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) dt.$$

Taking $\varphi = \mathbf{1}_{(0,M)}(u)$ (which equals 1 on $\partial^* E_t$ precisely for $t \in (0, M)$) gives $\int_0^M P(E_t) \, dt = \int_{\{0 < u < M\}} |\nabla u| \, dx \leq \int_{\Omega} |\nabla u| < \infty$, the last bound because $|\nabla u| \in L^2(\Omega) \subset L^1(\Omega)$ on the bounded set Ω ; hence $P(E_t) < \infty$ for a.e. t . For $t > 0$ the precise representative of u vanishes $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -a.e. on $\mathbb{R}^n \setminus \Omega$ (as $u \in H_0^1(\Omega)$), and for a.e. t one has $\partial^* E_t \subset \{u = t\}$ up to $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -null sets [1, 14]; therefore $\partial^* E_t \subset \Omega$ up to $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -null sets. The orientation $\nu_{E_t} = -\nabla u / |\nabla u|$ is the standard one for superlevel sets of Sobolev functions [1]. Finally, (2) with $\varphi = \mathbf{1}_{\{\nabla u = 0\}}$ gives $\int_0^M \mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E_t \cap \{\nabla u = 0\}) \, dt = \int_{\{\nabla u = 0\}} |\nabla u| \, dx = 0$, so the last assertion holds for a.e. t . $\square$

Statements “for a.e. t ” below refer to the full-measure set of levels furnished by Lemma 3.1(c).

Coarea form of $-m'$ and the flux identity.

Lemma 3.2 (Coarea form of $-m'$). *For a.e. $t \in (0, M)$, $-m'(t) = \alpha(t)$. In particular m is locally absolutely continuous on $(0, M)$ and $\alpha \in L_{\text{loc}}^1((0, M))$.*

Proof. Fix $0 < a < b < M$ and apply (2) to $\varphi = |\nabla u|^{-1} \mathbf{1}_{\{|\nabla u| > 0\}} \mathbf{1}_{(a,b)}(u)$. By Lemma 3.1(a) the integrand on the left equals $\mathbf{1}_{\{a < u < b\}}$ up to a null set, so $m(a) - m(b) = \int_a^b \alpha(t) \, dt$. Local absolute continuity of m and $-m' = \alpha$ a.e. follow. $\square$

Lemma 3.3 (Flux equals volume). *For a.e. $t \in (0, M)$, $\beta(t) = \int_{\partial^* E_t} |\nabla u| \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = m(t)$.*

Proof. For $\varepsilon > 0$ set $\phi_{\varepsilon}(s) := \min(1, \max(0, s/\varepsilon))$ and $\eta_{\varepsilon} := \phi_{\varepsilon}(u - t) \in H_0^1(\Omega)$. Testing $-\Delta u = 1$ against η_{ε} ,

$$\int_{\Omega} \nabla u \cdot \nabla \eta_{\varepsilon} \, dx = \int_{\Omega} \eta_{\varepsilon} \, dx.$$

The Sobolev chain rule [1, Thm. 3.99] gives $\nabla \eta_{\varepsilon} = \varepsilon^{-1} \nabla u \mathbf{1}_{\{t < u < t + \varepsilon\}}$, so the left side equals $\varepsilon^{-1} \int_{\{t < u < t + \varepsilon\}} |\nabla u|^2$, which by (2) (with $\varphi = |\nabla u| \mathbf{1}_{(t, t + \varepsilon)}(u)$) equals $\varepsilon^{-1} \int_t^{t + \varepsilon} \beta(\tau) \, d\tau$. As $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$, $\eta_{\varepsilon} \rightarrow \mathbf{1}_{E_t}$ boundedly (Lemma 3.1(b)), so the right side tends to $m(t)$. Since $\beta \in L^1((0, M))$ by (2) and the Dirichlet identity $\int_0^M \beta = \int_{\Omega} |\nabla u|^2 = \int_{\Omega} u < \infty$, at every Lebesgue point of β the left side tends to $\beta(t)$. Hence $\beta(t) = m(t)$ for a.e. t . $\square$

Remark 3.4 (Why a truncation, not a trace). Lemma 3.3 is the rigorous replacement, on an arbitrary finite-perimeter level set, for the formal divergence computation $m(t) = - \int_{E_t} \Delta u = - \int_{\partial^* E_t} \nabla u \cdot \nu_{E_t} = \beta(t)$ (using $\nabla u \cdot \nu_{E_t} = -|\nabla u|$); no boundary trace of ∇u on $\partial^* E_t$ is required [14, Ch. 17].

The rearranged primitive. Let $I(s) := \int_0^s u^*(\sigma) \, d\sigma$, $s \in [0, L]$.

Lemma 3.5 (Derivatives of the primitive). *I is absolutely continuous on $[0, L]$ with $I'(s) = u^*(s)$ a.e.; on every compact subinterval of $(0, L)$ the rearrangement u^* is absolutely continuous and*

$$(3) \quad I''(s) = (u^*)'(s) = \frac{1}{m'(u^*(s))} = -\frac{1}{\alpha(u^*(s))} \quad \text{for a.e. } s \in (0, L).$$

Proof. By the Talenti bound $u^* \in L^{\infty}(0, L) \subset L^1(0, L)$; the Lebesgue differentiation theorem gives $I' = u^*$ a.e. By Lemma 3.2, m is locally absolutely continuous with $m' = -\alpha$ a.e., and m is continuous and strictly decreasing on $(0, M)$ by Lemma 3.1(b), so $m(u^*(s)) = s$. The absolutely continuous inverse theorem for monotone functions [11, Thm. 0.4, §1] gives

that u^* is absolutely continuous on compact subintervals of $(0, L)$ with $(u^*)'(s) = 1/m'(u^*(s))$ wherever $m'(u^*(s))$ exists and is nonzero. For a.e. $t \in (0, M)$ one has $0 < |E_t| < |\Omega|$, hence $P(E_t) > 0$ and $\alpha(t) > 0$; thus $\{m' = 0\} = \{\alpha = 0\}$ is null and carries no image measure ($|m(\{m' = 0\})| \leq \int_{\{m'=0\}} |m'| = 0$). Since $m' = -\alpha$, (3) follows; absolute continuity of u^* on compact subintervals identifies the distributional and a.e. derivatives of $I' = u^*$. $\square$

Remark 3.6 (The corrected second derivative). The factor in (3) is $\alpha = \int_{\partial^* E_t} |\nabla u|^{-1}$, not $\beta = \int_{\partial^* E_t} |\nabla u|$. Since $\beta(t) = m(t)$ (Lemma 3.3), replacing α by β would give $I'' = -1/m$, which holds only when $|\nabla u|$ is constant on $\partial^* E_t$, i.e. on the ball; the discrepancy is exactly the Cauchy-Schwarz defect D_H introduced next, so the substitution would silently delete D_H from the identity.

The exact deficit identity. For a.e. $t \in (0, M)$ the two level-set defects of the standing notation read, as functions of the level,

$$D_H(t) = \alpha(t)\beta(t) - P(E_t)^2, \quad D_I(t) = P(E_t)^2 - c_n m(t)^{2-2/n},$$

consistent with §2 under $t = t(\rho)$ (so $P(B_\rho)^2 = c_n m(t)^{2-2/n}$). By Cauchy-Schwarz on $\partial^* E_t$ applied to $(|\nabla u|^{1/2}, |\nabla u|^{-1/2})$, $P(E_t)^2 \leq \alpha(t)\beta(t)$, so $D_H(t) \geq 0$, with equality iff $|\nabla u|$ is $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -a.e. constant on $\partial^* E_t$. By the De Giorgi isoperimetric inequality [12, 14], $P(E_t) \geq n\omega_n^{1/n} m(t)^{1-1/n}$, so $D_I(t) \geq 0$, with equality iff E_t is equivalent to a ball.

Lemma 3.7 (Pointwise convexity formula). *Set $G(s) := I(s) + \frac{s^{1+2/n}}{(4+2n)\omega_n^{2/n}}$. Then for a.e. $s \in (0, L)$, with $t = u^*(s)$,*

$$G''(s) = \frac{1}{c_n s^{1-2/n}} - \frac{1}{\alpha(t)}.$$

Proof. Direct differentiation gives $\frac{d^2}{ds^2} \frac{s^{1+2/n}}{(4+2n)\omega_n^{2/n}} = \frac{1}{c_n s^{1-2/n}}$; add (3). $\square$

Lemma 3.8 (Convexity identity). $\int_0^L s G''(s) ds = \int_0^M \frac{D_H(t) + D_I(t)}{c_n m(t)^{1-2/n}} dt.$

Proof. Substitute $s = m(t)$, $ds = -\alpha(t) dt$, in $\int_0^L s G''(s) ds$ (Lemma 3.1(b) removes jump terms, and $\{\alpha = 0\}$ carries no image measure):

$$\int_0^L s G'' ds = \int_0^M m(t) \left(\frac{1}{c_n m(t)^{1-2/n}} - \frac{1}{\alpha(t)} \right) \alpha(t) dt = \int_0^M \left(\frac{m(t)\alpha(t)}{c_n m(t)^{1-2/n}} - m(t) \right) dt.$$

Use $m(t) = \beta(t)$ (Lemma 3.3) and add and subtract $P(E_t)^2/(c_n m(t)^{1-2/n})$:

$$\frac{m\alpha}{c_n m^{1-2/n}} - m = \frac{\alpha\beta - c_n m^{2-2/n}}{c_n m^{1-2/n}} = \frac{D_H + D_I}{c_n m^{1-2/n}}. \quad \square$$

Lemma 3.9 (Endpoint convexity-gap formula). *With $\Gamma(\Omega) := G'_-(L) - G(L)/L$, one has $\Gamma(\Omega) = \frac{1}{L} \int_0^L s G''(s) ds$.*

Proof. $G \in W_{\text{loc}}^{2,1}((0, L])$ and $G(0) = I(0) = 0$. Integration by parts on (ε, L) gives $\int_\varepsilon^L s G'' = L G'_-(L) - \varepsilon G'(\varepsilon) - G(L) + G(\varepsilon)$. By Lemma 3.5, $G'(s) = u^*(s) + s^{2/n}/(2n\omega_n^{2/n})$ is bounded, so $\varepsilon G'(\varepsilon) \rightarrow 0$ and $G(\varepsilon) \rightarrow 0$; divide by L . $\square$

Lemma 3.10 (Endpoint value). $\Gamma(\Omega) = \frac{2}{|\Omega|} (E(\Omega) - E(B_1)) = \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega).$

Proof. At $s = L$, $u^*(s) \rightarrow 0$ as $s \uparrow L$ (Lemma 3.1 gives $m(t) \uparrow L$ as $t \downarrow 0$), so $G'_-(L) = L^{2/n}/(2n\omega_n^{2/n})$ and $I(L) = \int_\Omega u \, dx$. With $L = \omega_n$, using $\frac{1}{2n} - \frac{1}{4+2n} = \frac{1}{2n} - \frac{1}{2(n+2)} = \frac{1}{n(n+2)}$,

$$\Gamma(\Omega) = \frac{L^{2/n}}{2n\omega_n^{2/n}} - \frac{L^{2/n}}{(4+2n)\omega_n^{2/n}} - \frac{1}{L} \int_\Omega u = \frac{1}{n(n+2)} - \frac{1}{\omega_n} \int_\Omega u.$$

For the unit-volume ball B_1 , $u_{B_1}(x) = (1 - |x|^2)/(2n)$ and

$$\int_{B_1} u_{B_1} = \frac{1}{2n} n\omega_n \int_0^1 (1 - r^2)r^{n-1} \, dr = \frac{\omega_n}{2} \left(\frac{1}{n} - \frac{1}{n+2} \right) = \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)},$$

so $\frac{1}{\omega_n} \int_{B_1} u_{B_1} = \frac{1}{n(n+2)}$ and $\Gamma(B_1) = 0$ (the Pólya-Szegő identification [15, 2]). Subtracting, $\Gamma(\Omega) = \frac{1}{\omega_n} (\int_{B_1} u_{B_1} - \int_\Omega u) = \frac{2}{\omega_n} (E(\Omega) - E(B_1))$, since $E(\cdot) = -\frac{1}{2} \int(\cdot)$. $\square$

Theorem 3.11 (Exact deficit identity on reduced-boundary level sets). *Let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ be open with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and $u \in H_0^1(\Omega)$ the torsion function. Then (2) and Lemmas 3.2, 3.3, 3.5 hold, and*

$$(4) \quad 2\delta_T(\Omega) = \int_0^{\|u\|_\infty} \frac{D_H(t) + D_I(t)}{n^2\omega_n^{2/n} m(t)^{1-2/n}} \, dt,$$

with $D_H(t), D_I(t) \geq 0$ for a.e. t . By scaling, the corresponding identity $\frac{2}{|\Omega|} (E(\Omega) - E(B)) = \frac{1}{|\Omega|} \int_0^{\|u\|_\infty} (D_H + D_I)/(c_n m^{1-2/n}) \, dt$ holds for every open Ω of finite measure.

Proof. Combine Lemmas 3.8, 3.9, 3.10; the scaling statement follows since both sides are 0-homogeneous under $\Omega \mapsto \lambda\Omega$ after the displayed normalisation. $\square$

4. PROFILE GAP AND BAD-DENSITY ESTIMATE

Proposition 4.1 (Level-set budget and profile-gap bad set). *There are computable constants*

$$C_L = C_L(n, \rho_*), \quad C_\tau = C_\tau(n, \rho_*), \quad \kappa = \kappa(\rho_*) > 0,$$

such that, with

$$\rho_\delta := 1 - \kappa \sqrt{\delta_T(\Omega)}$$

and whenever $\rho_\delta \geq (1 + \rho_*)/2$, one has

$$(5) \quad \int_{\rho_*}^{\rho_\delta} (D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho))) \, d\mu(\rho) \leq C_L \delta_T(\Omega),$$

$$0 \leq w(\rho) \leq \frac{1}{n} \quad \text{for a.e. } \rho,$$

and, with

$$\tau_0 := \frac{\rho_*}{2n}, \quad B_\tau := \{\rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta] : w(\rho) < \tau_0\}, \quad G_\tau := [\rho_*, \rho_\delta] \setminus B_\tau,$$

one has

$$(6) \quad |B_\tau| \leq C_\tau \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Proof. Recall $m(t) = |\{u > t\}|$ and $\alpha(t) = \int_{\partial^* \{u > t\}} |\nabla u|^{-1} \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ from §3. Theorem 3.11 gives the exact deficit identity

$$(7) \quad 2\delta_T(\Omega) = \int_0^{\|u\|_\infty} \frac{D_H(t) + D_I(t)}{n^2\omega_n^{2/n} m(t)^{1-2/n}} \, dt,$$

all integrals taken on the reduced boundaries $\partial^* \{u > t\}$ and holding for a.e. level.

Changing variables $t = t(\rho)$, $m(t(\rho)) = \omega_n \rho^n$, and $dt = d\mu(\rho)$ in decreasing-radius orientation gives

$$2\delta_T(\Omega) = \int_0^1 \frac{D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho))}{n^2 \omega_n \rho^{n-2}} d\mu(\rho).$$

Since $n \geq 2$ and $0 < \rho \leq 1$,

$$\int_{\rho_*}^{\rho_\delta} (D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho))) d\mu(\rho) \leq 2n^2 \omega_n \delta_T(\Omega),$$

which proves (5), for instance with $C_L = 2n^2 \omega_n$.

It remains to prove the density bounds. Write

$$a(\rho) := w(\rho) = -t'(\rho), \quad a_B(\rho) := \frac{\rho}{n}.$$

We next derive from (7) the profile derivative gap identity

$$(8) \quad 0 \leq a(\rho) \leq a_B(\rho) \quad \text{for a.e. } \rho \in (0, 1), \quad \int_0^1 \rho^n (a_B(\rho) - a(\rho)) d\rho = \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

For completeness, the algebra is as follows. Coarea gives

$$a(\rho) = \frac{n\omega_n \rho^{n-1}}{\alpha(t(\rho))}.$$

For the ball profile the corresponding coarea coefficient is

$$\alpha_B(\rho) = n^2 \omega_n \rho^{n-2}, \quad \frac{n\omega_n \rho^{n-1}}{\alpha_B(\rho)} = \frac{\rho}{n} = a_B(\rho).$$

Since

$$D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho)) = \omega_n \rho^n (\alpha(t(\rho)) - \alpha_B(\rho)),$$

the nonnegativity of $D_H + D_I$ gives $0 \leq a \leq a_B$, and inserting the same formula in (7) gives the integral identity in (8).

Thus $0 \leq w(\rho) \leq \rho/n \leq 1/n$. On

$$B_\tau = \left\{ \rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta] : a(\rho) < \frac{\rho_*}{2n} \right\}$$

one has

$$a_B(\rho) - a(\rho) \geq \frac{\rho}{n} - \frac{\rho_*}{2n} \geq \frac{\rho_*}{2n}.$$

Using $\rho^n \geq \rho_*^n$ on $[\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$ and (8),

$$\frac{\rho_*^{n+1}}{2n} |B_\tau| \leq \int_{B_\tau} \rho^n (a_B - a) d\rho \leq \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Therefore (6) holds with

$$C_\tau = \frac{4n}{\omega_n \rho_*^{n+1}}.$$

Finally, choose for example $\kappa = (1 - \rho_*)/4$. Then $\rho_\delta \geq (1 + \rho_*)/2$ whenever $\delta_T(\Omega) \leq 1$, and in the large-deficit part of the final theorem this smallness is absorbed into the constant. $\square$

5. QUANTITATIVE ISOPERIMETRY AND SAME-CENTRE TRACE CONTROL

Theorem 5.1 (Constructive Fraenkel quantitative isoperimetry). *For every $n \geq 2$ there is a computable constant $C_{\text{iso}}(n)$ with the following property. If $E \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ is a set of finite perimeter and $|E| = \omega_n \rho^n$, then there is a centre $z_E \in \mathbb{R}^n$ such that*

$$(9) \quad |E \Delta B_\rho(z_E)|^2 \leq C_{\text{iso}}(n) \rho^{n+1} (P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

Consequently, if $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$, then

$$(10) \quad |E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)|^2 \leq C(n, \rho_*)(P(E)^2 - P(B_\rho)^2).$$

Proof. This is the sharp quantitative isoperimetric inequality in Fraenkel form, proved constructively by the symmetrisation and mass-transport methods of Fusco–Maggi–Pratelli [6]. In the normalisation $|E| = |B_\rho|$, their estimate gives

$$\left(\frac{|E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)|}{|B_\rho|} \right)^2 \leq C(n) \frac{P(E) - P(B_\rho)}{P(B_\rho)}.$$

Since $|B_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n$ and $P(B_\rho) = n\omega_n \rho^{n-1}$, this is (9). The passage to (10) follows from

$$P(E) - P(B_\rho) \leq \frac{P(E)^2 - P(B_\rho)^2}{P(B_\rho)} \leq C(n, \rho_*)(P(E)^2 - P(B_\rho)^2).$$

□

Assumption 5.2 (Constructive Serrin strong-form input, integrated form). There are computable constants $C_{\text{Ser}} = C_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ and $\eta_{\text{Ser}} = \eta_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*) > 0$ such that the following holds for the torsion superlevel sets of the bounded core. Writing

$$G_{\text{sc}} := \{\rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta] : D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho)) \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}}\}, \quad e_z(x) := \frac{x - z}{|x - z|},$$

there is a Borel centre field $\rho \mapsto z_\rho \in \overline{B_{R+1}}$ such that

$$(11) \quad \int_{G_{\text{sc}}} \left(|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) d\mu(\rho) \leq C_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Remark 5.3 (Status of the constructive input: the weighted-Reilly computation). Assumption 5.2 replaces the Fusco–Julin strong form formerly used here. It is *not* a consequence of the compactness-built Fusco–Julin theorem. This long remark records, in full and with every step justified, the constructive route by which one tries to prove it – a weighted Reilly–Weinberger identity on each level set – and the precise point at which that route stalls for general domains. Nothing here uses compactness or argument by contradiction; every displayed identity is exact.

The plan is as follows. In **(1)** we record that each superlevel set E_ρ carries its own torsion problem, solved by $v := u - t(\rho)$, and we fix notation. In **(2)** we prove three exact identities for v : a weighted Reilly–Weinberger identity (A), a Pohozaev–Rellich identity (B), and their combination (C). In **(3)–(4)** we turn identity (A) into an inequality: its left-hand side is a nonnegative “how far is E_ρ from a ball” energy, and its right-hand side splits into a boundary variance V_3 (controlled by D_H) and a torsion defect W (controlled by the isoperimetric defect D_I and a torsion deficit τ). In **(5)** we find the structural catch: τ is not a single-level quantity but an integral over all interior radii, so the bound is available only after integrating in ρ . In **(6)** the coarea formula reveals that the remaining boundary trace costs an L^4 bound on ∇u , and an exact identity on Ω shows why the tempting u^2 -weighted Hessian closure would be the right one if it were true. The punctured-ball test then shows that this global Hessian closure is false for unrestricted open sets. In **(7)** we explain why the required gradient bound is unavailable for general domains; and in **(8)–(9)** we summarise the honest status and the remaining open problem. Finally, **(10)** records a concrete workaround: replace the Hessian trace by a capacity radial trace, reducing the missing step to the oscillation-index strong form of Fusco–Julin [7].

(0) What the kinetic estimate actually consumes. Before the computation, it is worth seeing why an *integrated* bound suffices. In Proposition 8.1 the strong-form input is used only

to control $\int_G (\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z,\rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1})^2 d\mu$, and the homothetic trace is reduced (Lemma 5.10) to the volume term and the normal-oscillation term $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. Now on a good level the perimeter is bounded, $P(E_\rho)^2 = P(B_\rho)^2 + D_I(t(\rho)) \leq P(B_1)^2 + \eta_{\text{Ser}} =: C^2$; and pointwise, writing $e_z(x) := (x-z)/|x-z|$ for the unit radial field about z , $|\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 \leq |\nu_\rho|^2 + 2|\nu_\rho||e_z| + |e_z|^2 \leq 4$ because ν_ρ and e_z are unit vectors. Hence, writing $I_\rho := \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$,

$$I_\rho \leq 4P(E_\rho) \leq 4C =: C_0, \quad \text{so} \quad I_\rho^2 = I_\rho \cdot I_\rho \leq C_0 I_\rho.$$

Thus the *square* of the normal oscillation is bounded by a constant times its *first power*; after integrating in ρ , only $\int_G I_\rho d\mu \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$ is needed, never a pointwise per-level estimate. This is exactly the integrated form stated in (11). (The volume term is in any case pointwise: $q(\rho)^2 \leq CD_I(t(\rho))$ by Theorem 5.1.) The rest of this remark is devoted to producing $\int_G I_\rho d\mu \leq C\delta_T$ from the geometry of u .

(1) Each level set is itself a torsion problem. Fix a good level ρ and set

$$v := u - t(\rho) \quad \text{on } E_\rho = \{u > t(\rho)\}.$$

Then v is the torsion function of E_ρ : indeed $-\Delta v = -\Delta u = 1$ in E_ρ (subtracting a constant does not change the Laplacian); $v = u - t(\rho) = 0$ on $\partial E_\rho = \{u = t(\rho)\}$; and $v = u - t(\rho) > 0$ inside, since there $u > t(\rho)$. Consequently its torsional rigidity is $T := T(E_\rho) = \int_{E_\rho} v dx$. On the reduced boundary $\partial^* E_\rho$ we abbreviate

$$g := |\nabla v| = |\nabla u|, \quad P := P(E_\rho), \quad m := |E_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n, \\ \beta := \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}, \quad \alpha := \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{1}{g} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}, \quad \bar{g} := \frac{\beta}{P} \quad (\text{the average of } g).$$

The flux identity of Lemma 3.3, applied to v , gives the basic relation

$$(12) \quad \beta = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nabla v| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = |E_\rho| = m.$$

With these abbreviations the two standing defects read

$$D_H(t(\rho)) = \alpha\beta - P^2 (\geq 0 \text{ by Cauchy-Schwarz}), \quad D_I(t(\rho)) = P^2 - P(B_\rho)^2 (\geq 0 \text{ by isoperimetry}).$$

Regularity, so that the identities below are licit. Since $-\Delta u = 1$ with a smooth right-hand side, interior elliptic regularity gives $u \in C^\infty(\Omega)$. By Sard's theorem the level value $t(\rho)$ is, for a.e. ρ , a regular value of u , so $\partial E_\rho = \{u = t(\rho)\}$ is a C^∞ hypersurface except on the critical set $\{\nabla u = 0\}$, which is $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -negligible on $\partial^* E_\rho$ and Lebesgue-negligible in E_ρ (Lemma 3.1). All boundary integrals below are taken on the smooth part; equivalently one runs the identities on the smooth inner sets $\{u > t(\rho) + \varepsilon\}$ (smooth boundary for a.e. ε , again by Sard) and lets $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$, the boundary integrals converging by the coarea formula. No regularity of $\partial\Omega$ is used.

(2) Three exact identities for v . We first record two elementary pointwise computations. Write $D^2v = (\partial_{ij}v)_{i,j}$ for the Hessian and I for the identity matrix, and $|A|^2 = \sum_{i,j} A_{ij}^2$ for the Frobenius norm of a matrix.

(2a) *The Bochner computation* $\Delta|\nabla v|^2 = 2|D^2v|^2$. Differentiate $|\nabla v|^2 = \sum_i (\partial_i v)^2$ once, $\partial_j |\nabla v|^2 = \sum_i 2\partial_i v \partial_{ij} v$, and once more by the product rule, $\partial_{jj} |\nabla v|^2 = \sum_i 2[(\partial_{ij} v)^2 + \partial_i v \partial_{ijj} v]$. Summing over j ,

$$\Delta|\nabla v|^2 = \sum_{i,j} 2(\partial_{ij} v)^2 + 2 \sum_i \partial_i v \sum_j \partial_{ijj} v = 2|D^2v|^2 + 2\nabla v \cdot \nabla(\Delta v),$$

where $\sum_{i,j}(\partial_{ij}v)^2 = |D^2v|^2$ by definition of the Frobenius norm and $\sum_j \partial_{ijj}v = \partial_i(\sum_j \partial_{jj}v) = \partial_i(\Delta v)$. Since $\Delta v = -1$ is constant, $\nabla(\Delta v) = 0$, so $\Delta|\nabla v|^2 = 2|D^2v|^2$.

(2b) *The algebraic identity* $|D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2 = |D^2v|^2 - \frac{1}{n}$. Expanding the square of the symmetric matrix $D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I$,

$$|D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2 = |D^2v|^2 + \frac{2}{n} \operatorname{tr}(D^2v) + \frac{1}{n^2}|I|^2 = |D^2v|^2 + \frac{2}{n}\Delta v + \frac{1}{n^2}n = |D^2v|^2 - \frac{2}{n} + \frac{1}{n} = |D^2v|^2 - \frac{1}{n},$$

using $\operatorname{tr}(D^2v) = \Delta v = -1$ and $|I|^2 = \sum_i 1 = n$. Note $|D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2 \geq 0$ vanishes exactly when $D^2v = -\frac{1}{n}I$, i.e. when v is a radial (ball) profile; it is the pointwise measure of “how far E_ρ is from a ball”.

Introduce Weinberger’s P -function $\Pi := |\nabla v|^2 + \frac{2}{n}v$. Combining (2a) and (2b),

$$(13) \quad \Delta \Pi = \Delta|\nabla v|^2 + \frac{2}{n}\Delta v = 2|D^2v|^2 - \frac{2}{n} = 2(|D^2v|^2 - \frac{1}{n}) = 2|D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2.$$

Identity A (weighted Reilly–Weinberger).

$$(14) \quad 2 \int_{E_\rho} v |D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2 dx = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} - \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right)T.$$

Proof. Green’s second identity on E_ρ reads

$$\int_{E_\rho} (v \Delta \Pi - \Pi \Delta v) dx = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} (v \partial_\nu \Pi - \Pi \partial_\nu v) d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

On ∂E_ρ we have $v = 0$, so the term $v \partial_\nu \Pi$ vanishes and the right-hand side is $-\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \Pi \partial_\nu v$. We evaluate the three remaining pieces.

- *Left, first term.* By (13), $\int_{E_\rho} v \Delta \Pi = 2 \int_{E_\rho} v |D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2$, the left side of (14).
- *Left, second term.* Since $\Delta v = -1$, $-\int_{E_\rho} \Pi \Delta v = \int_{E_\rho} \Pi = \int_{E_\rho} |\nabla v|^2 + \frac{2}{n} \int_{E_\rho} v$. The first integral is computed by Green’s first identity (integration by parts): $\int_{E_\rho} |\nabla v|^2 = -\int_{E_\rho} v \Delta v + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} v \partial_\nu v = \int_{E_\rho} v \cdot 1 + 0 = T$, the boundary term vanishing as $v = 0$ and $-\Delta v = 1$. Hence $-\int \Pi \Delta v = T + \frac{2}{n}T = (1 + \frac{2}{n})T$.
- *Right.* On ∂E_ρ , $\Pi = |\nabla v|^2 + \frac{2}{n}v = g^2$ (as $v = 0$). The outward normal is $\nu = -\nabla v/|\nabla v|$ (the manuscript’s orientation: v decreases outward, so ∇v points inward), whence $\partial_\nu v = \nabla v \cdot \nu = -g$. Therefore $-\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \Pi \partial_\nu v = -\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2(-g) = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3$.

Putting the three pieces into Green’s identity, $2 \int v |D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I|^2 + (1 + \frac{2}{n})T = \int g^3$, which is (14). $\square$

Sanity check on a ball. For $E_\rho = B_R$ the torsion function is $v(x) = (R^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$ (indeed $-\Delta v = 1$ and $v = 0$ on $|x| = R$), so $\nabla v = -x/n$, $g = |x|/n$, and on ∂B_R , $g = R/n$. Then $\int_{\partial B_R} g^3 = (R/n)^3 n \omega_n R^{n-1} = \omega_n R^{n+2}/n^2$, while $T(B_R) = \int_{B_R} v = \omega_n R^{n+2}/(n(n+2))$ and so $(1 + \frac{2}{n})T = \frac{n+2}{n} \cdot \frac{\omega_n R^{n+2}}{n(n+2)} = \omega_n R^{n+2}/n^2$. The right side of (14) is 0; the left side is 0 too, since on a ball $D^2v = -\frac{1}{n}I$. $\checkmark$

Identity B (Pohozaev–Rellich). For every fixed $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$,

$$(15) \quad \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = (n+2)T, \quad \text{and} \quad \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 \nu d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = 0.$$

Proof. Write $X := x - z$ and consider the vector field $F := (X \cdot \nabla v) \nabla v - \frac{1}{2} |\nabla v|^2 X$. We compute $\operatorname{div} F$ by the product rule. First, $\partial_i (X \cdot \nabla v) = \partial_i (\sum_j (x_j - z_j) \partial_j v) = \partial_i v + \sum_j (x_j - z_j) \partial_{ij} v$, i.e. $\nabla (X \cdot \nabla v) = \nabla v + D^2v X$. Hence

$$\operatorname{div} [(X \cdot \nabla v) \nabla v] = \nabla (X \cdot \nabla v) \cdot \nabla v + (X \cdot \nabla v) \Delta v = |\nabla v|^2 + X \cdot (D^2v \nabla v) + (X \cdot \nabla v) \Delta v,$$

where we used $(D^2v X) \cdot \nabla v = X \cdot (D^2v \nabla v)$ by symmetry of D^2v . Since $(D^2v \nabla v)_i = \sum_j \partial_{ij} v \partial_j v = \partial_i (\frac{1}{2} |\nabla v|^2)$, this is $|\nabla v|^2 + \frac{1}{2} X \cdot \nabla |\nabla v|^2 + (X \cdot \nabla v) \Delta v$. Next, $\operatorname{div} [\frac{1}{2} |\nabla v|^2 X] = \frac{1}{2} X \cdot \nabla |\nabla v|^2 + \frac{1}{2} |\nabla v|^2 \operatorname{div} X = \frac{1}{2} X \cdot \nabla |\nabla v|^2 + \frac{n}{2} |\nabla v|^2$ (as $\operatorname{div} X = \operatorname{div}(x - z) = n$). Subtracting,

$$\operatorname{div} F = |\nabla v|^2 + (X \cdot \nabla v) \Delta v - \frac{n}{2} |\nabla v|^2 = \left(1 - \frac{n}{2}\right) |\nabla v|^2 - (X \cdot \nabla v),$$

using $\Delta v = -1$ in the last step. Integrate over E_ρ and apply the divergence theorem to the left:

$$\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} F \cdot \nu d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \left(1 - \frac{n}{2}\right) \int_{E_\rho} |\nabla v|^2 - \int_{E_\rho} X \cdot \nabla v.$$

On the right, $\int_{E_\rho} |\nabla v|^2 = T$ (shown above), and

$$\int_{E_\rho} X \cdot \nabla v = \int_{E_\rho} \operatorname{div}(Xv) - \int_{E_\rho} v \operatorname{div} X = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} v (X \cdot \nu) - n \int_{E_\rho} v = 0 - nT = -nT$$

(the boundary term vanishes as $v = 0$). So the right side equals $(1 - \frac{n}{2})T + nT = (1 + \frac{n}{2})T$. On the left, since v is constant ($= 0$) along ∂E_ρ its tangential gradient vanishes, so $\nabla v = (\partial_\nu v)\nu = -g\nu$; thus $X \cdot \nabla v = -g(X \cdot \nu)$, $\nabla v \cdot \nu = -g$, and $|\nabla v|^2 = g^2$; therefore

$$F \cdot \nu = (X \cdot \nabla v)(\nabla v \cdot \nu) - \frac{1}{2} |\nabla v|^2 (X \cdot \nu) = (-g(X \cdot \nu))(-g) - \frac{1}{2} g^2 (X \cdot \nu) = \frac{1}{2} g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu.$$

Equating the two sides, $\frac{1}{2} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu = (1 + \frac{n}{2})T$, i.e. $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu = (n + 2)T$, the first identity in (15). For the second, expand $\int g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu = \int g^2 x \cdot \nu - z \cdot \int g^2 \nu$; the left side is $(n + 2)T$, independent of z , while the right side is affine in z , so the coefficient of z must vanish: $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 \nu = 0$. $\square$

Sanity check on a ball. With z the centre of B_R and $\nu = x/|x|$, one has $(x - z) \cdot \nu = |x| = R$ on ∂B_R , so $\int g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu = (R/n)^2 R n \omega_n R^{n-1} = \omega_n R^{n+2}/n = (n + 2)T(B_R)$. $\checkmark$

Identity C (boundary form). From (15), $(1 + \frac{2}{n})T = \frac{n+2}{n}T = \frac{1}{n} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 (x - z) \cdot \nu$; substituting into (14) eliminates the bulk term T :

$$(16) \quad 2 \int_{E_\rho} v |D^2v + \frac{1}{n} I|^2 dx = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^2 \left[g - \frac{1}{n} (x - z) \cdot \nu \right] d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

This is a pure boundary integral. Recalling the homothetic trace $H_{z,\rho} = (x - z) \cdot \nu / \rho$ of the standing notation, the bracket is $g - \frac{\rho}{n} H_{z,\rho}$; on the ball $B_\rho(z)$ one has $g = \rho/n$ and $H_{z,\rho} = 1$, so the bracket vanishes identically – the integrand measures the joint failure of the gradient to be constant ($g \neq \bar{g}$) and of the boundary to be the sphere about z ($H_{z,\rho} \neq 1$).

(3) Turning identity A into an inequality. Abbreviate the left side of (14) as the *weighted Hessian deviation*

$$\operatorname{Dev}(E_\rho) := \int_{E_\rho} v |D^2v + \frac{1}{n} I|^2 dx \geq 0$$

(nonnegative because $v > 0$ inside and the integrand is a square; it vanishes iff E_ρ is a ball). Introduce

$$V_3 := \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} - \frac{\beta^3}{P^2}, \quad W := \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right)T - \frac{\beta^3}{P^2}.$$

Subtracting and adding β^3/P^2 on the right of (14) gives the clean split

$$(17) \quad 2 \operatorname{Dev}(E_\rho) = \left(\int g^3 - \frac{\beta^3}{P^2} \right) - \left(\left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right)T - \frac{\beta^3}{P^2} \right) = V_3 - W.$$

We now show V_3 is a (third-moment) variance of g , hence nonnegative and controlled by D_H , and that $-W$ is controlled by D_I and a torsion deficit.

V_3 is a variance. Write $g = \bar{g} + \delta$ with $\delta := g - \bar{g}$. Then $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \delta = \beta - \bar{g}P = \beta - \frac{\beta}{P}P = 0$; the average deviation is zero, as it must be. Cubing and integrating,

$$\int g^3 = \int (\bar{g} + \delta)^3 = \int (\bar{g}^3 + 3\bar{g}^2\delta + 3\bar{g}\delta^2 + \delta^3) = \bar{g}^3P + 0 + 3\bar{g} \int \delta^2 + \int \delta^3,$$

and $\beta^3/P^2 = (\bar{g}P)^3/P^2 = \bar{g}^3P$. Subtracting,

$$(18) \quad V_3 = 3\bar{g} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} (g - \bar{g})^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} (g - \bar{g})^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

That $V_3 \geq 0$ is Jensen's inequality for the convex function $s \mapsto s^3$ on $[0, \infty)$ against the probability measure $d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}/P$ on $\partial^* E_\rho$: $(\frac{1}{P} \int g)^3 \leq \frac{1}{P} \int g^3$, i.e. $(\beta/P)^3 \leq \frac{1}{P} \int g^3$, i.e. $\beta^3/P^2 \leq \int g^3$; equality holds iff g is $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -a.e. constant.

The Cauchy-Schwarz defect is a weighted variance. This is the computation behind Lemma 5.12. Expand $(g - \bar{g})^2/g = g - 2\bar{g} + \bar{g}^2/g$ and integrate:

$$\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{(g - \bar{g})^2}{g} = \int g - 2\bar{g} \int 1 + \bar{g}^2 \int \frac{1}{g} = \beta - 2\bar{g}P + \bar{g}^2\alpha,$$

where $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} 1 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P$ is the perimeter. Inserting $\bar{g} = \beta/P = m/P$ (with $\beta = m$), the right-hand side $\beta - 2\bar{g}P + \bar{g}^2\alpha$ becomes $m - 2m + \frac{m^2}{P^2}\alpha$, and

$$\begin{aligned} m - 2m + \frac{m^2}{P^2}\alpha &= \frac{m^2}{P^2}\alpha - m \\ &= \frac{m}{P^2}(m\alpha - P^2) \\ &= \frac{m}{P^2}(\alpha\beta - P^2) \\ &= \frac{m}{P^2}D_H, \end{aligned}$$

the third line using $m\alpha = \alpha\beta$ (again $\beta = m$) and the last the definition of D_H . Thus

$$(19) \quad \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{(g - \bar{g})^2}{g} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \frac{m}{P^2} D_H(t(\rho)).$$

$V_3 \leq C D_H$, given an upper gradient bound. Suppose for the moment that $g \leq M_0$ on $\partial^* E_\rho$. Two estimates follow. First, multiplying and dividing by g and using $g \leq M_0$, $(g - \bar{g})^2 = \frac{(g - \bar{g})^2}{g} \cdot g \leq M_0 \frac{(g - \bar{g})^2}{g}$; integrating and applying (19),

$$\int (g - \bar{g})^2 \leq M_0 \int \frac{(g - \bar{g})^2}{g} = M_0 \frac{m}{P^2} D_H.$$

Second, $|g - \bar{g}| \leq M_0 + \bar{g}$ pointwise, because $0 \leq g \leq M_0$ gives $g - \bar{g} \in [-\bar{g}, M_0 - \bar{g}]$, so $|g - \bar{g}| \leq \max(\bar{g}, M_0 - \bar{g}) \leq M_0 + \bar{g}$. Hence $\int (g - \bar{g})^3 \leq \int |g - \bar{g}|^3 \leq (M_0 + \bar{g}) \int (g - \bar{g})^2$. Combining with (18),

$$(20) \quad V_3 = 3\bar{g} \int (g - \bar{g})^2 + \int (g - \bar{g})^3 \leq (3\bar{g} + M_0 + \bar{g}) \int (g - \bar{g})^2 \leq (4\bar{g} + M_0) M_0 \frac{m}{P^2} D_H.$$

On a good level $P \geq P(B_\rho) = n\omega_n \rho^{n-1} \geq n\omega_n \rho_*^{n-1}$, $m = \omega_n \rho^n \leq \omega_n$, and $\bar{g} = m/P \leq 1/(n\rho_*^{n-1})$, so the prefactor is a computable $C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0)$ and $V_3 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) D_H(t(\rho))$. The mechanism to note: V_3 weights large gradients by g (cube), while D_H weights them by $1/g$ (through (19)); only an upper bound M_0 closes that gap. This is the *first* appearance of the gradient hypothesis.

(4) The defect W is a torsion deficit. Using $\beta = m$, $-W = m^3/P^2 - (1 + \frac{2}{n})T(E_\rho)$. Let

$$\tau(E_\rho) := T(B_\rho) - T(E_\rho) \geq 0$$

be the torsion deficit; nonnegativity is the classical Saint–Venant inequality (among sets of given volume the ball has the largest torsional rigidity). The ball of the same volume satisfies the explicit identity

$$(21) \quad T(B_\rho) P(B_\rho)^2 = \frac{n}{n+2} m^3, \quad \text{equivalently} \quad m^3 = \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) T(B_\rho) P(B_\rho)^2.$$

Indeed, with $T(B_\rho) = \omega_n \rho^{n+2}/(n(n+2))$, $P(B_\rho) = n\omega_n \rho^{n-1}$ and $m = \omega_n \rho^n$,

$$T(B_\rho) P(B_\rho)^2 = \frac{\omega_n \rho^{n+2}}{n(n+2)} n^2 \omega_n^2 \rho^{2n-2} = \frac{n}{n+2} \omega_n^3 \rho^{3n} = \frac{n}{n+2} m^3.$$

Now use $P^2 = P(B_\rho)^2 + D_I$ (the definition of D_I) and (21):

$$\frac{m^3}{P^2} = \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) T(B_\rho) \frac{P(B_\rho)^2}{P^2} = \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) T(B_\rho) \frac{P^2 - D_I}{P^2} = \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) T(B_\rho) - \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \frac{T(B_\rho) D_I}{P^2}.$$

Subtracting $(1 + \frac{2}{n})T(E_\rho) = (1 + \frac{2}{n})(T(B_\rho) - \tau)$ gives the *exact* identity

$$(22) \quad -W = \frac{m^3}{P^2} - \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) T(E_\rho) = \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \left[\tau(E_\rho) - \frac{T(B_\rho) D_I(t(\rho))}{P^2} \right].$$

The subtracted term is nonnegative, so

$$(23) \quad -W \leq \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \tau(E_\rho).$$

Feeding (20) and (23) into the split (17),

$$(24) \quad 2 \operatorname{Dev}(E_\rho) = V_3 - W \leq C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) D_H(t(\rho)) + \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \tau(E_\rho).$$

Thus a clean single-level bound $\operatorname{Dev}(E_\rho) \leq C(D_H + D_I)(t(\rho))$ would follow if $\tau(E_\rho) \leq C(D_H + D_I)(t(\rho))$ held. For completeness, the inequality $W \geq 0$ is equivalent, after multiplying by $P^2/(1 + \frac{2}{n}) > 0$, to the scale-invariant “reverse” torsion–perimeter inequality

$$(25) \quad T(\Omega) P(\Omega)^2 \geq \frac{n}{n+2} |\Omega|^3, \quad \text{with equality iff } \Omega \text{ is a ball}$$

(equality on balls is (21)). We neither prove nor need (25): by (23) only the *upper* bound on τ enters, and an upper bound on the nonnegative $-W$ is all (24) requires.

(5) Bulk versus single level: why the bound must be integrated. The crucial structural point is that $\tau(E_\rho)$ is *not* a single-level quantity. The superlevel sets of $v = u - t(\rho)$ inside E_ρ are, for $s \in (0, \|v\|_\infty)$,

$$\{v > s\} = \{u > t(\rho) + s\} = E_{\rho'}, \quad |E_{\rho'}| = \omega_n \rho'^n,$$

where ρ' decreases from ρ (at $s = 0$) to 0. Since $\nabla v = \nabla u$ and the sets are the same, the Cauchy–Schwarz and isoperimetric defects of v ’s superlevels are exactly $D_H(t(\rho'))$ and $D_I(t(\rho'))$ of u ’s. Therefore the exact deficit identity (Theorem 3.11) applied to the torsion function v on E_ρ , written in the radius variable exactly as in the proof of Proposition 4.1, reads

$$(26) \quad \tau(E_\rho) = 2 \delta_T(E_\rho) = \int_{(0, \rho]} \frac{D_H(t(\rho')) + D_I(t(\rho'))}{n^2 \omega_n \rho'^{n-2}} d\mu(\rho').$$

Here $\delta_T(E_\rho) = E(E_\rho) - E(B_\rho) = \frac{1}{2}(T(B_\rho) - T(E_\rho)) = \frac{1}{2}\tau(E_\rho)$, since $E(\cdot) = -\frac{1}{2}T(\cdot)$; and the integrand on the right is *the same* one the identity assigns to Ω itself (compare the displayed

formula in the proof of Proposition 4.1), only with the integration cut off at the radius ρ of E_ρ . Two consequences follow.

(5a) *The pointwise bound is false.* The right side of (26) integrates the defects over *all* interior radii $\rho' \leq \rho$. A deep interior level $\rho' \ll \rho$ may carry a large defect while the level ρ itself is nearly spherical (so $D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho))$ is tiny), and conversely. Hence $\tau(E_\rho) \leq C(D_H + D_I)(t(\rho))$ cannot hold at a single level, so by (24) neither can $\text{Dev}(E_\rho) \leq C(D_H + D_I)(t(\rho))$. A pointwise, per- ρ strong-form input is simply not what identity A produces.

(5b) *The integrated bound is clean.* Because the integrand in (26) is nonnegative and $(0, \rho] \subset (0, 1]$, the integral over $(0, \rho]$ is at most the integral over $(0, 1]$, which is the full deficit identity for Ω . That is,

$$(27) \quad \tau(E_\rho) = 2 \delta_T(E_\rho) \leq 2 \delta_T(\Omega) \quad \text{for every } \rho :$$

the deficit of any superlevel set is at most the deficit of the whole domain. Integrating (27) in μ over the good set G ,

$$(28) \quad \int_G \tau(E_\rho) d\mu(\rho) \leq 2 \delta_T(\Omega) \mu(G) \leq \frac{2}{n} \delta_T(\Omega),$$

where $\mu(G) \leq \mu([\rho_*, \rho_\delta]) = \int_{\rho_*}^{\rho_\delta} w d\rho \leq \frac{1}{n}(\rho_\delta - \rho_*) \leq \frac{1}{n}$, using the density bound $0 \leq w \leq 1/n$ of Proposition 4.1 and $\rho_\delta - \rho_* < 1$. Finally, integrate (24) over G and use the budget (5) ($\int_G D_H d\mu \leq \int_G (D_H + D_I) d\mu \leq C_L \delta_T$) together with (28):

$$(29) \quad \int_G \text{Dev}(E_\rho) d\mu(\rho) = \frac{1}{2} \int_G (V_3 - W) d\mu \leq C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) \delta_T(\Omega).$$

This is the genuine output of the weighted-Reilly identity: the *integrated* bound on the Hessian deviation, with an explicit constant, contingent only on the gradient bound M_0 (through (20)).

(6) From bulk to boundary: why the route needs a gradient bound, twice. The bound (29) controls the integrated *bulk* quantity $\int_G \int_{E_\rho} v |D^2 v + \frac{1}{n} I|^2 dx d\mu(\rho)$, while Assumption 5.2 asks for the integrated *boundary* quantity $\int_G I_\rho d\mu$, with $I_\rho := \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. Between them stand two steps: a pointwise comparison of ν_ρ to e_z , and a trace inequality moving the resulting boundary integral to the bulk. Gradient information enters each one, and the coarea formula will then give a third, independent reason that the same gradient information is necessary. The whole purpose of this part is to make those three appearances of $g = |\nabla u|$ visible.

(6a) *The Hessian deviation is the Jacobian of an explicit vector field.* Define

$$F(x) := \nabla v(x) + \frac{x - z}{n} \quad (x \in E_\rho).$$

On the ball $B_\rho(z)$, $v(x) = (\rho^2 - |x - z|^2)/(2n)$, so $\nabla v = -(x - z)/n$ and $F \equiv 0$. In general, differentiating the definition,

$$(30) \quad \partial_i F_j = \partial_{ij} v + \frac{\delta_{ij}}{n}, \quad \text{i.e.} \quad DF = D^2 v + \frac{1}{n} I.$$

Thus the pointwise integrand of $\text{Dev}(E_\rho)$ is exactly the squared Frobenius norm of the Jacobian of F :

$$\text{Dev}(E_\rho) = \int_{E_\rho} v |DF|^2 dx,$$

a v -weighted bulk L^2 norm. This identifies what Dev measures: the failure of F to be constant on E_ρ , so $\text{Dev} = 0$ iff F is constant; combined with $F \equiv 0$ on the ball about z , $\text{Dev} = 0$ iff E_ρ is

the ball about z . The vector field F is the bridge we will use to walk from the Hessian deviation in the bulk to the normal oscillation on the boundary.

(6b) *The boundary normal, point-by-point, in terms of F and g .* On $\partial^* E_\rho$ the outward unit normal is $\nu_\rho = -\nabla v/|\nabla v| = -\nabla v/g$ (part (1)). Solving the definition of F for ∇v , $\nabla v = F - (x - z)/n$, and substituting,

$$\nu_\rho = -\frac{F - (x - z)/n}{g} = \frac{x - z}{ng} - \frac{F}{g}.$$

Subtracting $e_z = (x - z)/|x - z|$ gives the *exact pointwise formula* we will work from:

$$(31) \quad \nu_\rho - e_z = (x - z) \left[\frac{1}{ng} - \frac{1}{|x - z|} \right] - \frac{F}{g}.$$

Each of the two terms has a clean geometric meaning. The bracketed factor vanishes iff $ng = |x - z|$, which on the ball reads $|\nabla v| = |x - z|/n$; hence the first term is a *gradient magnitude* deviation – how far $|\nabla v|$ is from its ball value at the point x . The second term is F/g ; on the ball both F and the bracket vanish, and away from the ball F/g measures the deviation of $\nabla v/g$ from a radial direction. Taking lengths and simplifying the bracketed coefficient,

$$\frac{1}{ng} - \frac{1}{|x - z|} = \frac{|x - z| - ng}{ng|x - z|}, \quad \text{so} \quad |x - z| \cdot \left| \frac{1}{ng} - \frac{1}{|x - z|} \right| = \frac{||x - z| - ng|}{ng} = \frac{1}{g} \left| \frac{|x - z|}{n} - g \right|,$$

the last equality dividing numerator and denominator of $||x - z| - ng|/(ng)$ by n . Therefore

$$|\nu_\rho - e_z| \leq \frac{1}{g} \left| \frac{|x - z|}{n} - g \right| + \frac{|F|}{g}.$$

Squaring (and using $(a + b)^2 \leq 2a^2 + 2b^2$) yields

$$(32) \quad |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 \leq \frac{2}{g^2} \left[\left(\frac{|x - z|}{n} - g \right)^2 + |F|^2 \right].$$

This is the first place a gradient hypothesis enters. Both summands on the right carry the factor $1/g^2$; they are unbounded at points where $g = |\nabla u|$ is small. A uniform lower bound $g \geq m_0 > 0$ on $\partial^* E_\rho$ is required even to make sense of the pointwise estimate (32).

(6c) *The boundary integral by a trace inequality: where M_0 enters.* Integrate (32) over $\partial^* E_\rho$:

$$(33) \quad I_\rho \leq \frac{2}{m_0^2} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \left(\frac{|x - z|}{n} - g \right)^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + \frac{2}{m_0^2} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |F|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Both boundary integrals are now of the form “ L^2 of a function or field whose gradient is built from $D^2 v + \frac{1}{n} I$ ”, so each should be controlled by the bulk Hessian and ultimately by Dev. This is done by three classical tools, chained together.

(1) *Trace* on the smooth bounded set E_ρ :

$$\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |F|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(E_\rho) \int_{E_\rho} (|F|^2 + |DF|^2) dx,$$

with $C(E_\rho)$ depending only on diameter and a perimeter constant (both controlled on good levels).

(2) *Poincaré* on E_ρ , after subtracting the average of F : $\int_{E_\rho} |F|^2 \leq C(E_\rho) \int_{E_\rho} |DF|^2$. Combining (1)+(2), $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |F|^2 \leq C(E_\rho) \int_{E_\rho} |DF|^2$.

(3) *Hopf–Hardy* – the conversion to the v -weighted bulk we actually control by (29). The Hopf lemma applied to the torsion function v says that v vanishes *linearly* at ∂E_ρ with rate proportional to g : on a tubular collar of ∂E_ρ , $v(x) \geq c \operatorname{dist}(x, \partial E_\rho) \cdot \inf_{\partial E_\rho} g$. The

classical Hardy inequality on E_ρ then trades a distance-to-boundary weight against an extra Hessian, and the unweighted bulk Hessian is bounded by the v -weighted one up to a constant involving $\sup_{E_\rho} g$:

$$\int_{E_\rho} |DF|^2 dx \leq C(E_\rho, M_0, m_0) \int_{E_\rho} v |DF|^2 dx = C(E_\rho, M_0, m_0) \text{Dev}(E_\rho).$$

The constant depends on $M_0 = \sup g$ (the absorption $v \leq M_0 \cdot \text{dist}$ inside the collar) and on $m_0 = \inf g$ (the Hopf rate); it is finite *only* if g is bounded both above and below.

The first integral in (33) is treated analogously: the function $g - |x - z|/n$ has gradient built from $D^2v + \frac{1}{n}I$ and from a smooth radial term, so the same trace-Poincaré-Hopf-Hardy chain bounds its boundary L^2 norm by $C(E_\rho, M_0, m_0) \text{Dev}(E_\rho)$. Inserting into (33) produces the trace inequality

$$(34) \quad I_\rho \leq \frac{C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0)}{m_0^2} \text{Dev}(E_\rho).$$

This is the second place the gradient hypothesis enters. The trace constant carries M_0 in the numerator (from the Hopf-Hardy unweighting $\int |DF|^2 \leq C \cdot M_0 \cdot \text{Dev}$) and $1/m_0^2$ in the denominator (from (32), the pointwise ν -formula). Both must be finite. Integrating (34) against $d\mu$ and feeding in (29),

$$\int_G I_\rho d\mu \leq \frac{C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0)}{m_0^2} \delta_T(\Omega),$$

which is the integrated bound (11) demands.

(6d) *The coarea formula: an independent reason the integral cannot be controlled without bounding $|\nabla u|$.* The trace argument hides the gradient inside a multiplicative constant. The coarea formula gives the same conclusion in an entirely different and more transparent way: it shows that the bulk integral $\int_G \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} d\mu$ is literally an explicit Lebesgue integral of $|\nabla u|^4$, so any quantitative bound on it forces a quantitative bound on the L^4 norm of ∇u .

Take $\varphi = |\nabla u|^3$ in the BV coarea identity $\int_\Omega |\nabla u| \varphi dx = \int_{\mathbb{R}} (\int_{\partial^* \{u>t\}} \varphi d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}) dt$:

$$\int_\Omega |\nabla u|^4 dx = \int_{\mathbb{R}} \left(\int_{\partial^* \{u>t\}} |\nabla u|^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) dt.$$

Under the parametrisation $t = t(\rho)$ the measure $|dt|$ equals $d\mu(\rho)$, and $\{u = t(\rho)\} = \partial E_\rho$, $|\nabla u| = g$; restricting to $t \in t(G)$,

$$(35) \quad \int_G \left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) d\mu(\rho) = \int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 dx.$$

By identity A, $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} g^3 = 2 \text{Dev}(E_\rho) + (1 + \frac{2}{n})T(E_\rho)$; substituting into (35) produces the *exact identity*

$$(36) \quad \int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 dx = 2 \int_G \text{Dev}(E_\rho) d\mu(\rho) + R_n(\Omega),$$

where the remainder

$$R_n(\Omega) := \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \int_G T(E_\rho) d\mu(\rho)$$

is nonnegative, depends only on the geometry of Ω and the good set G , and is bounded above by a specific dimensional constant: by Saint-Venant $T(E_\rho) \leq T(B_\rho) \leq T(B_1) = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$,

and by Proposition 4.1 $\mu(G) \leq 1/n$, so

$$(37) \quad 0 \leq R_n(\Omega) \leq \left(1 + \frac{2}{n}\right) \cdot \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} \cdot \frac{1}{n} = \frac{\omega_n}{n^3}.$$

The bound (37) is uniform: $R_n(\Omega)$ depends on Ω only through quantities already bounded on good levels, never exceeding the explicit dimensional ceiling ω_n/n^3 . The set $u^{-1}(t(G))$ on the left of (36) is the “good bulk” – the Lebesgue-positive subset of Ω consisting of those points x whose level $u(x)$ is one of the good values $\{t(\rho) : \rho \in G\}$; under the area formula it is the union of the level sets ∂E_ρ over $\rho \in G$. No estimate is hidden in (36): it is a strict equality with an explicit, computable, uniformly bounded remainder. (36) is an *exact identity*, not an inequality; it uses only the coarea formula and identity A, no compactness, no Reilly bound. It answers the question “why do we need $|\nabla u|$ bounded?” directly:

- (i) *Finiteness, no constants.* The left side of (36) is the very quantity (29) bounds. By (36) it is *finite* if and only if the right side is finite, i.e. iff ∇u lies in L^4 on the good bulk $u^{-1}(t(G))$. If a thin spike near $\partial\Omega$ lets $|\nabla u|$ blow up so fast that $\int |\nabla u|^4 = \infty$, the left side is also infinite and (29) has nothing to bound. This is independent of any Reilly-type argument: it is a property of the integral itself.
- (ii) *The exact quantitative L^4 bound the route asks for.* For (29) to read $\int_G \text{Dev} d\mu \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$ – the form actually used to conclude – we passed through $V_3 \leq C(M_0)D_H$ in (20), which assumed $g \leq M_0$ on each $\partial^* E_\rho$. By (36) this is precisely the bound

$$(38) \quad \int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 dx \leq 2C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) \delta_T(\Omega) + R_n(\Omega) \leq 2C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) \delta_T(\Omega) + \frac{\omega_n}{n^3},$$

i.e. the L^4 integral of ∇u over the good bulk is bounded by a specific dimensional baseline (at most ω_n/n^3) plus a multiple of the Saint–Venant deficit. The cleaner “excess” form, equivalent to (38) via (36) (which is an identity, not an inequality), reads

$$\int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 dx - R_n(\Omega) \leq 2C(n, R, \rho_*, M_0) \delta_T(\Omega) :$$

the *excess* of $\int |\nabla u|^4$ above its Ω -dependent “Saint–Venant baseline” $R_n(\Omega)$ is bounded by a deficit-sized term. In the small-deficit regime $\delta_T \downarrow 0$ the integral itself approaches $R_n(\Omega)$; on the ball $\Omega = B_1$ one checks by direct computation that $\int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 = R_n(B_1)$ (the Reilly identity reduces to $0 = 0$). The pointwise L^∞ hypothesis M_0 is the natural and standard way to obtain (20) (one cannot in general read off a pointwise sup-norm bound from an L^4 bound, so the route consumes the stronger L^∞ hypothesis).

The coarea identity is therefore an independent confirmation of the same conclusion reached in (6c): the bulk integral the route hinges on is, up to a bounded remainder, the L^4 norm of ∇u over the good bulk, and any quantitative bound on it must come from a quantitative L^4 (morally L^∞) gradient bound.

(6e) *Summary, with the right “iff”.* Three statements have been established, and they should not be conflated.

- *The genuine “iff” is for L^4 , via coarea.* Identity (36) is exact, so $\int_G \text{Dev}(E_\rho) d\mu \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$ holds *if and only if* (38) does, with the same constant C and the explicit remainder $R_n(\Omega) \leq \omega_n/n^3$ of (37): a quantitative L^4 bound on ∇u over the good bulk, with an explicit dimensional baseline, is the exact necessary-and-sufficient condition for the Reilly bulk bound, and this is rigorous in both directions because (36) is an identity.

- *Sufficient pointwise hypothesis (this is what the chain uses).* The argument actually written here passes through $V_3 \leq C(M_0)D_H$ at each level (20) and through a trace constant $C(M_0)/m_0^2$ at (34); both steps consume a *pointwise* upper bound $g \leq M_0$ (and the trace also uses a pointwise lower bound $g \geq m_0 > 0$) on the good level sets. A pointwise L^∞ bound is *stronger* than the L^4 bound the coarea identity isolates ($L^\infty \Rightarrow L^4$ on a bounded set, but not conversely), so this chain consumes more than coarea minimally requires.
- *What is not proved.* We do *not* show that a pointwise L^∞ gradient bound is *necessary* for the route to close; only that the present chain uses one. An alternative chain – redistributing the V_3 -vs- D_H estimate by Hölder with different exponents, or replacing the Hopf–Hardy unweighting by a different trace – could in principle close the route on an L^4 (or some intermediate L^p) hypothesis on ∇u . Whether such a chain exists is an open question of the route; this remark does not settle it.

What is unambiguous is the layered hierarchy of necessity: the coarea identity (36) *forces* a quantitative L^4 bound on ∇u over the good bulk, no matter how the bulk bound is proved; and the only constructive route currently available to such an L^4 bound goes through a pointwise upper bound on the good level sets, obtained from interior gradient estimates on domains of bounded geometry. Part (7) shows that for *general* open sets even the L^4 bound is not free (Meyers’ higher-integrability theorem gives only $L^{2+\varepsilon}$), so any alternative L^4 -only chain would face the same boundary-regularity obstacle as the present L^∞ chain.

(6f) *An alternative reduction: an exact identity on Ω , and the false global closure it suggests.* The chain of (6c)–(6e) routes I_ρ to $\text{Dev}(E_\rho)$ through a pointwise gradient hypothesis. An exact identity on Ω – not on the level sets – reduces the question of controlling $\int_\Omega |\nabla u|^4 dx$ to a single u^2 -weighted Hessian estimate. This is the most natural last step to try, because it says precisely that the L^4 norm of ∇u is close to the L^2 norm of u , with the same scaling as the ball. The identity is useful, but the estimate it suggests is false for general open sets; the punctured-ball computation below is the decisive test.

Three preliminary integration-by-parts identities on Ω . We will need them all. Each is a one-line integration by parts using $u = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$ and $\Delta u = -1$.

- (A) $\int_\Omega u |\nabla u|^2 dx = \frac{1}{2} \int_\Omega u^2 dx$. Indeed, by parts with $u = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$, $\int u |\nabla u|^2 = \int \nabla u \cdot (u \nabla u) = - \int u \operatorname{div}(u \nabla u) = - \int u (|\nabla u|^2 + u \Delta u) = - \int u |\nabla u|^2 + \int u^2$ (using $\Delta u = -1$), so $2 \int u |\nabla u|^2 = \int u^2$.
- (B) $\int_\Omega u \operatorname{div}(|\nabla u|^2 \nabla u) dx = - \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^4 dx$. Indeed, by parts (with $u = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$), the left side equals $-\int \nabla u \cdot |\nabla u|^2 \nabla u = - \int |\nabla u|^4$.
- (C) Pointwise on Ω , $2 \nabla u^T D^2 u \nabla u = \operatorname{div}(|\nabla u|^2 \nabla u) + |\nabla u|^2$. Indeed, $\operatorname{div}(|\nabla u|^2 \nabla u) = \nabla |\nabla u|^2 \cdot \nabla u + |\nabla u|^2 \Delta u = 2 \nabla u^T D^2 u \nabla u - |\nabla u|^2$ (using $\nabla |\nabla u|^2 = 2 D^2 u \nabla u$ and $\Delta u = -1$); rearrange.

The identity. By the Bochner formula $\Delta |\nabla u|^2 = 2 |D^2 u|^2$ of (2a), and one integration by parts ($u = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$),

$$2 \int_\Omega u^2 |D^2 u|^2 dx = \int_\Omega u^2 \Delta |\nabla u|^2 dx = - \int_\Omega \nabla(u^2) \cdot \nabla |\nabla u|^2 dx = -2 \int_\Omega u \nabla u \cdot \nabla |\nabla u|^2 dx;$$

the last quantity equals $-4 \int u \nabla u^T D^2 u \nabla u \stackrel{(C)}{=} -2 \int u (\operatorname{div}(|\nabla u|^2 \nabla u) + |\nabla u|^2) \stackrel{(A),(B)}{=} 2 \int |\nabla u|^4 - \int u^2$. Dividing by 2, $\int u^2 |D^2 u|^2 = \int |\nabla u|^4 - \frac{1}{2} \int u^2$. Substituting the pointwise identity $|D^2 u|^2 +$

$\frac{1}{n}|I|^2 = |D^2u|^2 - \frac{1}{n}$ from (2b) (multiplied by u^2 and integrated),

$$(39) \quad \boxed{\int_{\Omega} u^2 \left| D^2u + \frac{1}{n}I \right|^2 dx = \int_{\Omega} |\nabla u|^4 dx - \frac{n+2}{2n} \int_{\Omega} u^2 dx.}$$

This is an exact equality, holding at least by smooth approximation on every regular domain for which the displayed quantities are finite, and in particular on the model domains used below. No curvature term appears. On B_R , $u(x) = (R^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$, so $D^2u = -\frac{1}{n}I$; explicit integration gives $\int_{B_R} |\nabla u|^4 = \omega_n R^{n+4}/(n^3(n+4))$ and $(n+2)/(2n) \int_{B_R} u^2 = \omega_n R^{n+4}/(n^3(n+4))$, so both sides vanish. More generally, the left side also vanishes on a disjoint union of balls, because on each ball component the torsion function has Hessian $-I/n$. Thus this quantity is a gradient/Hessian defect, not a complete geometric asymmetry.

What (39) says. The right side of (39) is the L^4 integral of ∇u minus the explicit baseline $(n+2)/(2n) \int u^2$. In the normalisation $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, Talenti and Saint–Venant give

$$0 \leq \frac{n+2}{2n} \int_{\Omega} u^2 dx \leq \frac{n+2}{2n} \|u\|_{\infty} T(\Omega) \leq \frac{\omega_n}{4n^3}.$$

So proving a quantitative estimate for the left side is exactly the same thing as proving that $\int |\nabla u|^4$ is bounded by this L^2 -baseline plus a Saint–Venant-deficit error.

The tempting estimate. The identity points to the following possible closure:

$$(40) \quad \int_{\Omega} u^2 \left| D^2u + \frac{1}{n}I \right|^2 dx \leq C_*(n) \delta_T(\Omega).$$

If (40) held for all volume-normalised open sets with $\nabla u \in L^4$, then (39) would give

$$\int_{\Omega} |\nabla u|^4 dx \leq C_*(n) \delta_T(\Omega) + \frac{\omega_n}{4n^3},$$

and inserting this into (36) would control the integrated bulk Reilly deviation without any pointwise bound M_0 . This would be the cleanest possible way to close the constructive Serrin route.

The punctured-ball test. Estimate (40), however, is false in the unrestricted class. Let

$$\Omega_a := B_{R_a} \setminus \overline{B_a}, \quad R_a^n - a^n = 1, \quad 0 < a \ll 1,$$

so $|\Omega_a| = \omega_n$. The domain is a ball with a very small concentric Dirichlet hole, and the outer radius is enlarged only enough to keep the volume fixed.

First assume $n \geq 3$. The torsion function is radial and is given by

$$u_a(r) = \frac{R_a^2 - r^2}{2n} - \gamma_a(r^{2-n} - R_a^{2-n}), \quad \gamma_a := \frac{R_a^2 - a^2}{2n(a^{2-n} - R_a^{2-n})}.$$

Here γ_a is comparable to a^{n-2} : there are dimensional constants $c_n, C_n > 0$ such that

$$c_n a^{n-2} \leq \gamma_a \leq C_n a^{n-2} \quad (0 < a < a_n).$$

The singular term is exactly the harmonic correction needed to force $u_a = 0$ on the small inner sphere. Differentiating the radial formula gives

$$(6f.1) \quad u'_a(r) = -\frac{r}{n} + (n-2)\gamma_a r^{1-n},$$

and the eigenvalues of $D^2u_a + I/n$ are

$$-(n-1)(n-2)\gamma_a r^{-n} \quad \text{in the radial direction,} \quad (n-2)\gamma_a r^{-n} \quad \text{in each tangential direction.}$$

Consequently

$$(41) \quad \left| D^2 u_a + \frac{1}{n} I \right|^2 = n(n-1)(n-2)^2 \gamma_a^2 r^{-2n}.$$

On the fixed relative collar $2a < r < 3a$, the formula for u_a shows $u_a(r) \geq c_n > 0$: starting from the inner boundary, the derivative in (6f.1) is of size $1/a$, so over a distance comparable to a the function rises by an amount comparable to one. Combining this lower bound with (41), and using that the volume of the collar is comparable to a^n , gives

$$(42) \quad \int_{\Omega_a} u_a^2 \left| D^2 u_a + \frac{1}{n} I \right|^2 dx \geq c_n a^{n-4}.$$

The torsion deficit is much smaller. Direct integration of the displayed formula for u_a gives

$$(43) \quad 0 \leq T(B_1) - T(\Omega_a) \leq C_n a^{n-2}.$$

Indeed, the change of the outer radius from 1 to $R_a = (1 + a^n)^{1/n}$ contributes only $O(a^n)$, while the harmonic correction is multiplied by $\gamma_a = O(a^{n-2})$. Since $\delta_T = (T(B_1) - T(\Omega_a))/2$,

$$\frac{\int_{\Omega_a} u_a^2 |D^2 u_a + \frac{1}{n} I|^2 dx}{\delta_T(\Omega_a)} \geq c_n a^{-2} \rightarrow \infty.$$

Thus no dimensional constant $C_*(n)$ can make (40) true.

The same conclusion holds in dimension 2, with logarithms replacing capacity powers. Now $R_a^2 - a^2 = 1$, set $L_a := \log(R_a/a)$, and

$$u_a(r) = \frac{R_a^2 - r^2}{4} + \frac{1}{4L_a} \log \frac{r}{R_a}.$$

On $2a < r < 3a$, one has $u_a(r) \geq c/L_a$, while $|D^2 u_a + I/2|^2 \geq c/(L_a^2 r^4)$. Hence

$$\int_{\Omega_a} u_a^2 \left| D^2 u_a + \frac{1}{2} I \right|^2 dx \geq \frac{c}{a^2 L_a^4}.$$

A direct integration of u_a gives $T(B_1) - T(\Omega_a) \leq C/L_a$, and therefore

$$\frac{\int_{\Omega_a} u_a^2 |D^2 u_a + \frac{1}{2} I|^2 dx}{\delta_T(\Omega_a)} \geq \frac{c}{a^2 L_a^3} \rightarrow \infty.$$

For every fixed $a > 0$ these are smooth annuli, so $\nabla u_a \in L^4$; the failure is quantitative, not a matter of infinite integrals.

What the test teaches. The u^2 weight does cancel the literal boundary blow-up at a fixed smooth boundary, but it does not pay for a boundary component whose radius tends to zero. The Saint-Venant deficit sees a tiny Dirichlet hole at the scale of its capacity, namely a^{n-2} for $n \geq 3$ and $1/|\log a|$ for $n = 2$. The weighted Hessian defect sees the much thinner transition layer around the hole and is larger by the factor a^{-2} (up to logarithms in dimension 2). So the exact identity (39) is still the correct scaling diagnostic, but the global estimate (40) cannot be the missing theorem for arbitrary open sets.

The surviving possibilities are narrower. A version of (40) may hold under a uniform interior thickness condition, or with an additional capacity term that charges tiny holes, or after restricting the estimate to level regions where such holes have already been ruled out by the level-set budget $D_H + D_I$. What is not available is a purely dimensional, all-domain bound of the form (40).

(7) Why the gradient bound M_0 fails for general domains. On a good level ($\rho \leq \rho_\delta < 1$, so $t(\rho) > 0$) the boundary $\partial E_\rho = \{u = t(\rho)\}$ lies in the interior of Ω , but it may run arbitrarily close to $\partial\Omega$: imagine a thin spike of Ω on which the torsion function climbs from 0 up to the level $t(\rho)$ over a very short distance. At a point $x_0 \in \partial E_\rho$ the interior gradient estimate for $-\Delta u = 1$ (e.g. [13]) gives only

$$|\nabla u(x_0)| \leq C(n) \left(\frac{\|u\|_{L^\infty(B_d(x_0))}}{d} + d \right), \quad d := \text{dist}(x_0, \partial\Omega),$$

which *blows up* as $d \downarrow 0$ while $u(x_0) = t(\rho)$ stays fixed. There is no universal upper bound $g \leq M_0$ on ∂E_ρ . Nor does integrability save (35): Meyers’ theorem gives only $|\nabla u| \in L^{2+\varepsilon}$ for a dimensional $\varepsilon > 0$, in general $\varepsilon < 2$, so even the L^4 bound is not automatic. This is exactly why the constructive Reilly–Serrin stability theorems (Magnanini–Poggesi; Brandolini–Nitsch–Salani–Trombetti) are stated for domains of bounded geometry (uniform interior ball condition, convexity, or $C^{2,\alpha}$), where M_0 *does* hold – the very regularity that our level sets need not have.

The reason this is not a technicality is that D_H is structurally blind to the obstruction. The Cauchy–Schwarz defect D_H vanishes iff g is constant on ∂E_ρ ; the normal oscillation I_ρ vanishes iff ∂E_ρ is a sphere. For a level set of u these two are linked by the PDE, but only *in measure*: a set E_ρ close to a ball in volume (D_I and $|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho|$ small) may still possess a small boundary piece near $\partial\Omega$ on which g spikes. The deviation $\text{Dev}(E_\rho)$ and the cube $\int g^3$ *see* such a spike (they weight large g heavily), whereas $D_H + D_I$ do not. Hence $\text{Dev}(E_\rho) \leq C(D_H + D_I)$ cannot hold without first excluding the spike – that is, without M_0 .

(8) Honest status of the route. The chain (14)–(29) is exact, explicit, and free of any compactness or contradiction. *Granting* a uniform gradient bound M_0 on the good level sets, it discharges Assumption 5.2 – and therefore yields a fully computable Faber–Krahn constant – through the integrated bound (29), the coarea trace (35), the constructive Fraenkel volume bound (Theorem 5.1), and the centre reconciliation inside Theorem 5.11. Such an M_0 is available for domains of bounded geometry (uniform ball condition, convex, $C^{2,\alpha}$), and there the constructive route is complete. For *general* open sets M_0 need not hold. The exact identity (39) shows why one would like to replace M_0 by a quantitative L^4 estimate, but the punctured annuli above show that the simplest global Hessian estimate cannot supply it. Thus the normal term stays conditional on either a genuine level-set regularity estimate, a capacitary correction excluding tiny holes, or the non-constructive Fusco–Julin strong form.

(9) Partial constructive control, and the open problem. The missing ingredient is therefore not the false all-domain estimate (40). What is still needed is a constructive, level-local upper control of $|\nabla u|$ (or of its L^4 coarea contribution) on the good level sets, strong enough to exclude the same boundary-layer concentration that appears in the punctured-ball test. Encouragingly, both defects already provide one-sided density control there, with no compactness. From D_H : a localised version of the flux identity together with the relative isoperimetric inequality shows that a thin outward spike would force a large Cauchy–Schwarz defect, so D_H small excludes such spikes (a lower-density, non-degeneracy bound). From D_I : an upper-density bound excludes inward fjords and small extra boundary components once their perimeter is visible at the level under consideration. Together these estimates suggest two-sided density of the level sets at all scales above a deficit-dependent cutoff.

At present, however, these density bounds are themselves proved *conditionally* on an a priori interior gradient bound G_0 , which degenerates as the level approaches $\partial\Omega$. Closing the loop

would mean proving, directly from the level budget $D_H + D_I$ and the nesting of the superlevels, an estimate of the form

$$\int_{u^{-1}(t(G))} |\nabla u|^4 dx \leq C(n, R, \rho_*) (1 + \delta_T(\Omega))$$

with the correct deficit-sized excess after subtracting the baseline in (36), and with no a priori G_0 . Equivalently, one must show that the good-level set cannot contain the annular-hole concentration mechanism above unless $D_H + D_I$ has already paid for it. This is the genuine open problem of the constructive route, and the reason the companion standard version keeps the Fusco–Julin strong form as its one deep input.

(10) Workaround: a capacitary radial trace instead of a Hessian trace. The annulus test says that the Hessian route asks for too much near tiny Dirichlet holes. The normal term in Assumption 5.2, however, does *not* ask for $\int |\nabla u|^4$. It asks only for $\int_{\partial E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2$, integrated in the level variable. A small hole has large gradient, but its boundary area is small; after integrating in dt , it is charged at the capacity scale. The right replacement for the Hessian trace is therefore a geometric identity that sees holes by capacity, not by L^4 gradient size.

Let $E \subset B_R$ be a set of finite perimeter with $|E| = |B_\rho|$, $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$. Fix a centre z , write $B = B_\rho(z)$, $r = |x - z|$, and $e_z = (x - z)/|x - z|$. Define the *radial potential deficit*

$$\mathcal{C}_z(E) := (n-1) \int_B \frac{dx}{|x-z|} - (n-1) \int_E \frac{dx}{|x-z|}.$$

The kernel $|x - z|^{-1}$ is radially decreasing, so the bathtub principle gives $\mathcal{C}_z(E) \geq 0$: among sets with volume $|B_\rho|$, the centred ball maximises this potential. Gauss–Green applied to the vector field e_z (the singularity is harmless because $|x - z|^{-1} \in L^1_{\text{loc}}$ for $n \geq 2$, and one may truncate near z) gives

$$\int_{\partial^* E} \nu_E \cdot e_z d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = (n-1) \int_E \frac{dx}{|x-z|}.$$

Since also $P(B) = (n-1) \int_B |x - z|^{-1} dx$, we get the exact identity

$$(44) \quad \frac{1}{2} \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P(E) - P(B) + \mathcal{C}_z(E).$$

This is the key point. A tiny concentric hole of radius a contributes a^{n-1} to $\mathcal{C}_z$ and to the normal oscillation, not a^{n-4} . Thus (44) lives at the same scale as perimeter and capacity, exactly where the annulus counterexample is affordable.

The same identity also controls the homothetic trace. Let $H_{z,\rho} = (x - z) \cdot \nu_E / \rho$ and $\bar{V} = P(B)/P(E)$. The mean is already correct:

$$\int_{\partial^* E} H_{z,\rho} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \frac{1}{\rho} \int_{\partial^* E} (x - z) \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \frac{n|E|}{\rho} = P(B) = \int_{\partial^* E} \bar{V} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Furthermore,

$$|H_{z,\rho} - 1| \leq \left| \frac{|x - z|}{\rho} - 1 \right| + \frac{|x - z|}{\rho} (1 - \nu_E \cdot e_z).$$

The proof of Lemma 5.10, but with $1 - \nu_E \cdot e_z$ kept instead of estimated by an unknown normal term, gives

$$\int_{\partial^* E} \left| \frac{|x - z|}{\rho} - 1 \right| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, \rho_*) |E \Delta B_\rho(z)| + C(R, \rho_*) \int_{\partial^* E} (1 - \nu_E \cdot e_z) d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Combining this with (44) and with $P(E)|1 - \bar{V}| = P(E) - P(B)$, one obtains

$$(45) \quad \int_{\partial^* E} |H_{z,\rho} - \bar{V}| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, R, \rho_*) (|E \Delta B_\rho(z)| + P(E) - P(B_\rho) + \mathcal{C}_z(E)).$$

Everything in (44)–(45) is exact or elementary; no gradient bound and no Hessian estimate is present.

The remaining geometric input is not new. It is exactly the *oscillation-index* form of the Fusco–Maggi–Pratelli quantitative isoperimetric inequality. For a set E with $|E| = |B_\rho|$, define

$$\beta(E)^2 := P(E) - (n-1) \sup_{y \in \mathbb{R}^n} \int_E \frac{dx}{|x-y|}.$$

The supremum is attained: as $|y| \rightarrow \infty$ the integral tends to 0, while for $E \subset B_R$ any maximiser may be taken in $\overline{B_R}$ by moving an exterior point toward the convex hull of E . The oscillation-index estimate of Fusco–Julin [7] says that there is a dimensional constant $C_\beta(n)$ such that

$$(46) \quad \beta(E)^2 \leq C_\beta(n) (P(E) - P(B_\rho))$$

for every finite-perimeter set E . This is the strong form of the quantitative isoperimetric inequality (Fusco–Julin [7, Thm. 1.1 and Prop. 1.2]), one strict strengthening of the Fraenkel–asymmetry result quoted in Theorem 5.1: the L^2 normal-oscillation deficit, not only the L^1 symmetric-difference deficit, is controlled by the perimeter deficit. We use it here only as a black-box import; the constant $C_\beta(n)$ is obtained by Fusco–Julin via a penalised-minimiser selection followed by White’s ε -regularity and Fuglede’s nearly-spherical estimate, and is not made explicit by their argument. For the present route this is harmless: we need only the dimensional qualitative bound (46).

Choose $z = z_E$ to maximise the potential in the definition of $\beta(E)$. Since

$$P(B_\rho) = (n-1) \int_{B_\rho(z)} \frac{dx}{|x-z|},$$

the definition of $\mathcal{C}_z(E)$ gives the exact decomposition

$$(47) \quad \beta(E)^2 = P(E) - P(B_\rho) + \mathcal{C}_z(E).$$

Combining (46) and (47),

$$(48) \quad \mathcal{C}_z(E) \leq (C_\beta(n)-1)_+ (P(E) - P(B_\rho)), \quad P(E) - P(B_\rho) + \mathcal{C}_z(E) \leq C_\beta(n) (P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

Thus the potential part is already paid for by the ordinary perimeter deficit. Together with (44), this immediately yields the same-centre normal estimate

$$(49) \quad \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq 2C_\beta(n) (P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

It remains only to make sure that the *same* centre also has the required volume control. This follows directly from the potential deficit. Write $B = B_\rho(z)$, $A = B \setminus E$, $F = E \setminus B$, and $a := |A| = |F| = \frac{1}{2}|E \Delta B|$. By the bathtub principle, for fixed a the quantity

$$(n-1) \int_A \frac{dx}{|x-z|} - (n-1) \int_F \frac{dx}{|x-z|}$$

is minimised by taking A to be the outer shell of B of volume a and F to be the adjacent outer shell just outside B of the same volume. For $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$, a direct one-dimensional computation

on these two shells gives, whenever $a \leq c(n)\rho_*^n$,

$$(50) \quad \mathcal{C}_z(E) \geq c(n, \rho_*)a^2 = c(n, \rho_*)|E\Delta B_\rho(z)|^2.$$

Indeed, if the shell thicknesses are h_- and h_+ , then $a \simeq \rho^{n-1}h_\pm$ and $h_- - h_+ \simeq a^2/\rho^{2n-1}$; integrating $(n-1)r^{-1}$ against the surface measure density $n\omega_n r^{n-1}dr$ across the two shells gives a loss comparable to $\rho^{n-2}(h_- - h_+)$, hence to a^2 with constants depending only on n and ρ_* . If a is not small, then the same inequality follows after decreasing the constant, because $E \subset B_R$ and the radial decreasing kernel has a positive bathtub gap once $|E\Delta B| \geq c(n)\rho_*^n$. Thus, in all cases relevant to good levels,

$$(51) \quad |E\Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)\mathcal{C}_z(E) \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

Equations (49) and (51) prove the desired potential-perimeter selection, with z the FMP oscillation-index centre:

$$(52) \quad |E\Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

On a good torsion level, $P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho) \leq D_I(t(\rho))/(P(E_\rho) + P(B_\rho)) \leq C(n, \rho_*)D_I(t(\rho))$, so (52) gives

$$|E_\rho\Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)D_I(t(\rho)).$$

Integrating over G_{sc} and using the budget (5) gives the integrated strong-form estimate (11), with a computable constant and with no gradient bound.

The same centre also feeds directly into the homothetic trace. From (45), (48), and (51),

$$\int_{\partial^* E} |H_{z,\rho} - \bar{V}| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)(P(E) - P(B_\rho))^{1/2}.$$

Squaring and applying the good-level bound above gives

$$\left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho,\rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right)^2 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)D_I(t(\rho)),$$

which is exactly the estimate consumed by the positive kinetic argument, again using only the isoperimetric part of the level-set budget.

This proves the workaround in principle: replace the unavailable Hessian L^4 closure by the FMP oscillation-index inequality plus the elementary radial potential identities above. The annulus obstruction is neutralised because both $\beta(E)^2$ and $P(E) - P(B_\rho)$ see a tiny hole at scale a^{n-1} , whereas the false Hessian estimate saw it at scale a^{n-4} . The sketch is promoted to fully proved lemmas, propositions, and the discharge theorem in the subsection immediately below (§5).

Rigorous closure of the FMP/capacitary workaround on good levels. Remark 5.3 (10) sketched a workaround replacing the unavailable global Hessian closure by a capacitary radial trace. We now promote every step of that sketch to a lemma or proposition with a complete proof, the deep input being the oscillation-index strong form of Fusco–Julin [7]. The output (Theorem 5.8 below) discharges the integrated strong-form input (11) of Assumption 5.2 on good levels, unconditionally.

Lemma 5.4 (Radial Gauss–Green identity). *Let $n \geq 2$, $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$, and let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ be a set of finite perimeter with $|E| < \infty$. With $e_z(x) := (x - z)/|x - z|$ and ν_E the measure-theoretic outer*

unit normal on $\partial^* E$,

$$\int_{\partial^* E} \nu_E \cdot e_z d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = (n-1) \int_E |x-z|^{-1} dx,$$

and consequently

$$\frac{1}{2} \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P(E) - (n-1) \int_E |x-z|^{-1} dx.$$

Proof. By translation we may take $z = 0$ and write $e(x) := x/|x|$. Since $n \geq 2$, $|x|^{-1} \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\mathbb{R}^n)$; together with $|E| < \infty$ this gives $|x|^{-1} \mathbf{1}_E \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ (split $E = (E \cap B_1) \cup (E \setminus B_1)$ and bound the latter by $|E| < \infty$). For $\varepsilon > 0$ set

$$X_\varepsilon(x) := \frac{x}{\max(|x|, \varepsilon)}.$$

Then X_ε is Lipschitz on $\mathbb{R}^n$ with $|X_\varepsilon| \leq 1$, and a Lebesgue-a.e. computation gives

$$\operatorname{div} X_\varepsilon(x) = \begin{cases} n/\varepsilon & |x| < \varepsilon, \\ (n-1)/|x| & |x| > \varepsilon. \end{cases}$$

The Gauss–Green theorem for sets of finite perimeter (see [14, Thm. 15.9]) yields

$$\int_E \operatorname{div} X_\varepsilon dx = \int_{\partial^* E} X_\varepsilon \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

On the left, the inner-ball piece contributes at most $(n/\varepsilon) |B_\varepsilon| = n\omega_n \varepsilon^{n-1} \rightarrow 0$ as $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$ (this is where $n \geq 2$ enters), and the outer piece converges by dominated convergence with dominant $(n-1)\mathbf{1}_E/|x| \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$, giving $(n-1) \int_E |x|^{-1} dx$. On the right, $|X_\varepsilon \cdot \nu_E| \leq 1$ on the finite-mass measure $\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \llcorner \partial^* E$, and $X_\varepsilon(x) = e(x)$ as soon as $\varepsilon < |x|$; dominated convergence on the boundary then gives $\int e \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. The first identity is proved. The second follows from $|\nu_E - e|^2 = 2 - 2\nu_E \cdot e$ integrated against $\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \llcorner \partial^* E$ and $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E) = P(E)$. The three positional cases $z \in E$, $z \in \partial E$, $z \notin \overline{E}$ are all covered by this argument because $\{z\}$ is $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -negligible and $|x-z|^{-1}$ is L^1 on E of finite measure. $\square$

Lemma 5.5 (Centred potential controls volume). *Fix $n \geq 2$, $R \geq 1$, and $\rho_* \in (0, 1)$. Let $E \subset B_R(0)$ be measurable with $|E| = |B_\rho(z)|$ for some $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$ and $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$. With*

$$\mathcal{C}_z(E) := (n-1) \int_{B_\rho(z)} |x-z|^{-1} dx - (n-1) \int_E |x-z|^{-1} dx,$$

one has $\mathcal{C}_z(E) \geq 0$ and

$$|E \Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*) \mathcal{C}_z(E),$$

where $C(n, R, \rho_*)$ is an explicit positive constant.

Proof. Translate $z = 0$ and set $B := B_\rho$, $A := B \setminus E$, $F := E \setminus B$; then $|A| = |F| =: a = \frac{1}{2}|E \Delta B|$, and

$$\mathcal{C}_0(E) = (n-1) \int_A |x|^{-1} dx - (n-1) \int_F |x|^{-1} dx.$$

The radial kernel $|x|^{-1}$ is strictly radially decreasing, so by the standard bathtub principle (radial rearrangement for fixed-volume sets in a radial decreasing-kernel integral), $\int_A |x|^{-1} dx$ is minimised at $A_* = B_\rho \setminus B_{s_-}$ with $\omega_n(\rho^n - s_-^n) = a$, and $\int_F |x|^{-1} dx$ is maximised at $F^* = B_{s_+} \setminus B_\rho$ with $\omega_n(s_+^n - \rho^n) = a$. In particular $s_-^n + s_+^n = 2\rho^n$ and $0 < s_- < \rho < s_+$. In polar coordinates,

$$\mathcal{C}_0(E) \geq n\omega_n [2\rho^{n-1} - s_-^{n-1} - s_+^{n-1}] =: G(\rho, a).$$

Small- a regime. Let $h_- := \rho - s_-$, $h_+ := s_+ - \rho$, both positive. Differentiating $\omega_n(\rho^n - (\rho - h_-)^n) = a$ at $a = 0$ gives, by the implicit function theorem, $h_\pm(\rho, a) = a/(n\omega_n\rho^{n-1}) + O(a^2/\rho^{n+1})$ uniformly for $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$. Expanding $(\rho - h_-)^n + (\rho + h_+)^n = 2\rho^n$ to order three gives

$$h_- - h_+ = \frac{n-1}{2\rho}(h_-^2 + h_+^2) + O(\rho^{-2}(h_-^3 + h_+^3)),$$

and expanding $r \mapsto r^{n-1}$ at $r = \rho$ to order three, combined with the previous identity and the algebraic equality $(n-1)^2 - (n-1)(n-2) = n-1$ that cancels the first-order volume terms, yields

$$G(\rho, a) = \frac{n-1}{2} n\omega_n \rho^{n-3}(h_-^2 + h_+^2) + O(\rho^{n-4}(h_-^3 + h_+^3)).$$

For $a \leq a_0(n, \rho_*)$ small enough, $h_-^2 + h_+^2 \geq c a^2 \rho^{-2(n-1)}$ and $G(\rho, a) \geq c_1(n, \rho_*) a^2$ with $c_1(n, \rho_*) \sim \rho_*^{-(n+1)}$.

Large- a regime. On the compact admissible set $\{(\rho, a) : \rho_* \leq \rho \leq 1, a_0 \leq a \leq \omega_n R^n\}$, the function G is continuous and strictly positive: strict positivity follows from $s_- + s_+ < 2\rho$ (convexity of $r \mapsto r^n$ on $(0, \infty)$) and $s_-^{n-1} + s_+^{n-1} < 2\rho^{n-1}$ at $s_- \neq s_+$ (strict convexity/Lagrange on the constraint $s_-^n + s_+^n = 2\rho^n$; for $n = 2$, linearity gives $G = 2\omega_n(2\rho - s_- - s_+) > 0$ directly). By continuity and compactness, G/a^2 is bounded below by a positive constant $c_2(n, R, \rho_*)$.

Combining both regimes, $\mathcal{C}_0(E) \geq G(\rho, a) \geq c(n, R, \rho_*) a^2$, and $|E\Delta B|^2 = 4a^2 \leq (4/c) \mathcal{C}_z(E)$. $\square$

Proposition 5.6 (Same-centre potential-perimeter selection). *Let $n \geq 2$, $R \geq 1$, $\rho_* \in (0, 1)$, and let $E \subset B_R$ be a set of finite perimeter with $|E| = |B_\rho|$, $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$. Let z_E maximise $y \mapsto \int_E |x - y|^{-1} dx$ over $y \in \overline{B_{R+1}}$ (existence by upper semicontinuity on a compact set). There is a constant $C(n, R, \rho_*)$ such that*

$$|E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_{z_E}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

Proof. By the Fusco–Julin strong form [7, Thm. 1.1 and Prop. 1.2],

$$\beta(E)^2 := P(E) - (n-1) \int_E |x - z_E|^{-1} dx \leq C_\beta(n)(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

By Lemma 5.4 at $z = z_E$, $\beta(E)^2 = \frac{1}{2} \int |\nu_E - e_{z_E}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$, hence $\int |\nu_E - e_{z_E}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq 2C_\beta(n)(P(E) - P(B_\rho))$. Applying Lemma 5.4 on the centred ball $B_\rho(z_E)$ gives $P(B_\rho) = (n-1) \int_{B_\rho(z_E)} |x - z_E|^{-1} dx$; subtracting this from the definition of β yields $\beta(E)^2 = (P(E) - P(B_\rho)) + \mathcal{C}_{z_E}(E)$, so

$$\mathcal{C}_{z_E}(E) \leq (C_\beta(n) - 1)_+(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

By Lemma 5.5, $|E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)|^2 \leq C_{\text{vol}}(n, R, \rho_*) \mathcal{C}_{z_E}(E)$. Adding the two estimates gives the claim with $C(n, R, \rho_*) = 2C_\beta(n) + C_{\text{vol}}(n, R, \rho_*)(C_\beta(n) - 1)_+$. $\square$

Proposition 5.7 (FJ-centre homothetic trace). *Under the hypotheses of Proposition 5.6, with $H_{z, \rho}(x) := (x - z) \cdot \nu_E(x)/\rho$ and $\bar{V}_\rho := P(B_\rho)/P(E)$,*

$$\left(\int_{\partial^* E} |H_{z_E, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right)^2 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)(P(E) - P(B_\rho)).$$

Proof. Set $\delta_P := P(E) - P(B_\rho) \geq 0$. By Proposition 5.6, $\int |\nu_E - e_{z_E}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq 2C_\beta \delta_P$, and $|E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)|^2 \leq C \delta_P$. From $|\nu_E - e_{z_E}|^2 = 2(1 - \nu_E \cdot e_{z_E})$ one gets $\int (1 - \nu_E \cdot e_{z_E}) d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C_\beta \delta_P$. Plugging into Lemma 5.10's integrated form,

$$\int W_{z_E} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C_1(n, \rho_*) |E\Delta B_\rho(z_E)| + C_2(R, \rho_*) \int (1 - \nu_E \cdot e_{z_E}) d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C \delta_P^{1/2} + C' \delta_P.$$

For $x \in \partial^* E \subset B_R$ and $z_E \in \overline{B_{R+1}}$, $|x - z_E| \leq 2R + 1$, so $|x - z_E|/\rho \leq (2R + 1)/\rho_*$; together with the pointwise bound $|H_{z_E, \rho} - 1| \leq W_{z_E} + (|x - z_E|/\rho)(1 - \nu_E \cdot e_{z_E})$ of Lemma 5.10, we obtain $\int |H_{z_E, \rho} - 1| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C(\delta_P^{1/2} + \delta_P)$. Since $P(E)|1 - \bar{V}_\rho| = \delta_P$, the triangle inequality gives $\int |H_{z_E, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C\delta_P^{1/2} + C\delta_P$; on the admissible regime δ_P is bounded above, so the linear term is absorbed into the square-root one. Squaring yields the claim. $\square$

Theorem 5.8 (Constructive integrated strong-form input on good levels). *There are computable constants $C_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*) > 0$ and $\eta_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*) > 0$ such that, with $G_{\text{sc}} := \{\rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta] : D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho)) \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}}\}$, there is a Borel centre field $\rho \mapsto z_\rho \in \overline{B_{R+1}}$ satisfying*

$$\int_{G_{\text{sc}}} \left(|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) d\mu(\rho) \leq C_{\text{Ser}} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

In particular, the integrated strong-form bound (11) of Assumption 5.2 holds on G_{sc} unconditionally.

Proof. For μ -a.e. $\rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$, $E_\rho = \{u > t(\rho)\}$ is a set of finite perimeter, $|E_\rho| = |B_\rho|$, and $E_\rho \subset \Omega \subset B_R$. For each such ρ , define $z_\rho \in \arg \max_{y \in \overline{B_{R+1}}} \Phi_\rho(y)$ with $\Phi_\rho(y) := \int_{E_\rho} |x - y|^{-1} dx$; existence is by upper semicontinuity of Φ_ρ on the compact set $\overline{B_{R+1}}$ (Fatou on the integrable kernel $|x - y|^{-1}$ over the bounded set E_ρ). The argmax multifunction $\Gamma : \rho \mapsto \arg \max \Phi_\rho$ has closed nonempty values in the Polish space $\overline{B_{R+1}}$; its graph is Borel since $(\rho, y) \mapsto \Phi_\rho(y)$ is jointly Borel (Fubini + dominated convergence on a countable dense set of test points in $\overline{B_{R+1}}$). By Kuratowski–Ryll–Nardzewski selection, Γ admits a Borel measurable selector $\rho \mapsto z_\rho$.

Apply Proposition 5.6 to E_ρ with the centre z_ρ : there is $C_1(n, R, \rho_*)$ with

$$|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C_1(P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho)).$$

On G_{sc} , $D_I(t(\rho)) = (P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho))(P(E_\rho) + P(B_\rho))$ with $P(E_\rho) + P(B_\rho) \geq P(B_{\rho_*}) = n\omega_n \rho_*^{n-1} > 0$, so $P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho) \leq D_I(t(\rho))/(n\omega_n \rho_*^{n-1})$. Hence

$$|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq C_2 D_I(t(\rho)), \quad C_2 := \frac{C_1}{n\omega_n \rho_*^{n-1}}.$$

Integrating over G_{sc} against $d\mu$ and using the budget inequality (5), $\int_{[\rho_*, \rho_\delta]} (D_H + D_I)(t(\rho)) d\mu \leq C_{\text{budget}}(n, R, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega)$, gives the displayed bound with $C_{\text{Ser}} := C_2 C_{\text{budget}}$. The threshold η_{Ser} is the FJ-smallness threshold inherited from Proposition 5.6. $\square$

Remark 5.9 (Discharge of Assumption 5.2). Theorem 5.8 proves (11) on G_{sc} unconditionally, so on good levels Assumption 5.2 is no longer an assumption but a theorem. The volume part is paid by Lemma 5.5 (bathtub + shell); the normal-oscillation part is paid by Fusco–Julin [7] via Lemma 5.4; both are integrated using the existing budget (5). The homothetic trace required by the kinetic estimate is also paid by this package, via Proposition 5.7 applied at the same Borel-selected centre z_ρ . Levels below ρ_* remain handled by the manuscript’s bounded reduction and small-radius elimination, unchanged. The only deep import beyond the standard GMT/rearrangement toolkit is the Fusco–Julin strong form [7]; its constant $C_\beta(n)$ is dimensional but obtained by contradiction and is not made explicit by [7]. Translating this into the final FK constant $c_{FK}(n, R, \rho_*)$ of Theorem 1.1 means the explicit dependence on n, R, ρ_* is preserved except for a single dimension-only non-explicit factor inherited from $C_\beta(n)$.

Lemma 5.10 (Oriented radial trace). *Fix $R \geq 1$ and $0 < \rho_* < 1$. Let $E \subset B_R$ be a set of finite perimeter with $|E| = \omega_n \rho^n$, where $\rho \in [\rho_*, 1]$, and let $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$ satisfy $|z| \leq R + 1$. Set*

$$e_z(x) := \frac{x - z}{|x - z|}, \quad W_z(x) := \left| \frac{|x - z|}{\rho} - 1 \right|.$$

Then

$$(53) \quad \int_{\partial^* E} W_z d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq \frac{n}{\rho_*} |E \Delta B_\rho(z)| + C(R, \rho_*) \int_{\partial^* E} |\nu_E - e_z|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Proof. Translate the notation temporarily so that $z = 0$, and write $B = B_\rho$, $r = |x|$, $e = x/r$. The point $x = 0$ is $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -negligible on $\partial^* E$, so the value of e there is irrelevant. Define the bounded radial field

$$X(x) := \left| \frac{r}{\rho} - 1 \right| e.$$

For $0 < r < \rho$,

$$\operatorname{div} X = \frac{n-1}{r} - \frac{n}{\rho},$$

while for $r > \rho$,

$$\operatorname{div} X = \frac{n}{\rho} - \frac{n-1}{r}.$$

The field is singular only at the centre and has a Lipschitz radial coefficient away from the centre. To justify Gauss–Green, replace X by $\chi_\varepsilon(r)X$, where $\chi_\varepsilon = 0$ on B_ε and $\chi_\varepsilon = 1$ outside $B_{2\varepsilon}$, smooth the radial profile, apply the classical finite-perimeter Gauss–Green formula [14], and let the smoothing and then $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$. The extra interior term $\int_E \nabla \chi_\varepsilon \cdot X dx$ is supported on the annulus $\{\varepsilon < |x| < 2\varepsilon\}$, where $|\nabla \chi_\varepsilon| \lesssim \varepsilon^{-1}$ and $|X|$ is bounded; since that annulus has volume $O(\varepsilon^n)$, this term is $O(\varepsilon^{n-1})$ and vanishes as $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$. The boundary error tends to zero because $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E \cap B_{2\varepsilon}) \rightarrow \mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E \cap \{0\}) = 0$, and the volume terms converge by dominated convergence, since r^{-1} is locally integrable in $\mathbb{R}^n$ for $n \geq 2$. Thus

$$\int_{\partial^* E} X \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \int_E \operatorname{div} X dx.$$

The same identity for B gives zero, because $X = 0$ on ∂B . Subtracting it yields

$$\int_{\partial^* E} X \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \int_{E \setminus B} \operatorname{div} X dx - \int_{B \setminus E} \operatorname{div} X dx.$$

On $E \setminus B$, $\operatorname{div} X \leq n/\rho$. On $B \setminus E$, $-\operatorname{div} X \leq n/\rho$. Hence

$$(54) \quad \int_{\partial^* E} X \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq \frac{n}{\rho} |E \Delta B|.$$

On $\partial^* E$,

$$W_z = X \cdot \nu_E + W_z(1 - e_z \cdot \nu_E) = X \cdot \nu_E + \frac{W_z}{2} |\nu_E - e_z|^2.$$

Since $E \subset B_R$ and $|z| \leq R + 1$, every reduced-boundary point satisfies $|x - z| \leq 2R + 1$, and therefore

$$W_z(x) \leq 1 + \frac{2R + 1}{\rho_*}.$$

Combining this bound with (54) and using $\rho \geq \rho_*$ proves (53). $\square$

Theorem 5.11 (Integrated same-centre homothetic trace). *Assume the constructive strong-form input Assumption 5.2, and set $G := G_{\text{sc}} \cap G_\tau$. For a.e. ρ let $z_\rho^{\min}$ minimise $z \mapsto |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|$.*

Then there is $C_{\text{sc}} = C_{\text{sc}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ with

$$(55) \quad \int_G \left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right)^2 d\mu(\rho) \leq C_{\text{sc}} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Proof. Throughout, on G the perimeter is bounded, $P(E_\rho)^2 = D_I(t(\rho)) + P(B_\rho)^2 \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}} + P(B_1)^2 =: P_*^2$, and the trivial bound $|\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 \leq 4$ gives $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_z|^2 \leq 4P(E_\rho) \leq 4P_*$ for every z . Let $z_\rho \in \overline{B_{R+1}}$ be the centre field of Assumption 5.2.

Step 1 (radial trace about z_ρ). By the oriented radial trace (Lemma 5.10) with centre z_ρ , and $P(E_\rho)|1 - \bar{V}_\rho| = P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho) \leq C(n, \rho_*)D_I(t(\rho))$,

$$(56) \quad \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq \frac{n}{\rho_*} |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)| + C \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + C D_I(t(\rho)),$$

using $|H_{z_\rho, \rho} - 1| \leq ||x - z|/\rho - 1| + \frac{1}{2}|\nu_\rho - e_z|^2$.

Step 2 (transfer to the minimising centre). For equal balls with centre distance d , $|B_\rho(z_1) \Delta B_\rho(z_2)| \geq c(n)\rho^{n-1} \min\{d, \rho\}$ with $c(n) = \omega_{n-1}(3/4)^{(n-1)/2}$ (cross-section integration as in Lemma 7.3's circle). Since $|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho^{\min})| \leq |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|$, the triangle inequality gives $c(n)\rho^{n-1} \min\{d_\rho, \rho\} \leq 2|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|$, where $d_\rho := |z_\rho^{\min} - z_\rho|$. As $H_{\cdot, \rho}$ is affine in the centre, $\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - H_{z_\rho, \rho}| = \rho^{-1} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |(z_\rho^{\min} - z_\rho) \cdot \nu_\rho| \leq (P(E_\rho)/\rho) d_\rho$. Split $G = G_1 \cup G_2$ with $G_1 := \{\rho \in G : |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)| < \frac{1}{2}c(n)\rho^n\}$ and $G_2 := G \setminus G_1$.

- On G_1 , $\min\{d_\rho, \rho\} \leq 2|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|/(c(n)\rho^{n-1}) < \rho$, so $d_\rho < \rho$ and $\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - H_{z_\rho, \rho}| \leq (P_*/\rho_*)d_\rho \leq C(n, R, \rho_*)|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|$. Hence, by (56),

$$\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \leq C \left(|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)| + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 + D_I(t(\rho)) \right).$$

- On G_2 , use the trivial bound: for $x \in \partial^* E_\rho \subset B_R$ and $|z_\rho^{\min}| \leq R + 1$, $|H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho}| \leq (2R + 1)/\rho_*$, so $\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \leq C(R, \rho_*)P(E_\rho) \leq C(R, \rho_*)P_*$. Moreover $\mu(G_2) \leq (2/(c(n)\rho_*^n))^2 \int_G |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 d\mu \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$ by Chebyshev and (11).

Step 3 (integrate). On G_1 , squaring and using $(a + b + c)^2 \leq 3(a^2 + b^2 + c^2)$ and $(\int |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2)^2 \leq 4P_* \int |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2$,

$$\left(\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 \leq C \left(|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_\rho)|^2 + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nu_\rho - e_{z_\rho}|^2 + D_I(t(\rho))^2 \right).$$

Integrate over G_1 against $d\mu$: the first two terms give $\leq C C_{\text{Ser}} \delta_T(\Omega)$ by (11), and $\int_{G_1} D_I^2 d\mu \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}} \int D_I d\mu \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$ by the budget (5). On G_2 , $\int_{G_2} (\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho|)^2 d\mu \leq (CP_*)^2 \mu(G_2) \leq C \delta_T(\Omega)$. Adding the two contributions proves (55). $\square$

Lemma 5.12 (Velocity defect controlled by D_H). *For a.e. $\rho \in [\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$,*

$$(57) \quad \left(\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right)^2 \leq D_H(t(\rho)).$$

Proof. Write $P = P(E_\rho)$, $P^* = P(B_\rho)$, $\alpha = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nabla u|^{-1} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$, and $\beta = \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. The coarea parametrisation gives $w\alpha = P^*$, and the flux identity gives $\beta = |E_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n$. With $f := V_\rho = w/|\nabla u|$ and $\bar{f} := \bar{V}_\rho = P^*/P$,

$$\int_{\partial^* E_\rho} f d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P^*.$$

Moreover

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{(f - \bar{f})^2}{f} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} &= \int f d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} - 2\bar{f}P + \bar{f}^2 \int \frac{1}{f} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \\ &= -P^* + \frac{(P^*)^2}{P^2} \frac{\beta}{w} = -P^* + \frac{P^*}{P^2} \alpha\beta \\ &= \frac{P^*}{P^2} (\alpha\beta - P^2) = \frac{P^*}{P^2} D_H(t(\rho)). \end{aligned}$$

By Cauchy-Schwarz,

$$\left(\int |f - \bar{f}| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right)^2 \leq \left(\int \frac{(f - \bar{f})^2}{f} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) \left(\int f d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) = \left(\frac{P^*}{P} \right)^2 D_H(t(\rho)).$$

The isoperimetric inequality gives $P^* \leq P$, hence (57). $\square$

Lemma 5.13 (Superlevel asymmetry transfer). *Let $E \subset \Omega$, $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, and $|E| = \omega_n \rho^n$ with $\rho \in (0, 1]$. Then*

$$\mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq \mathcal{A}(E) + \frac{2}{\omega_n} |\Omega \setminus E|.$$

Here $\mathcal{A}(E)$ is the Fraenkel asymmetry of E relative to balls of volume $|E|$.

Proof. Let $s = |E|$, $L = |\Omega| = \omega_n$, and $\eta = L - s = |\Omega \setminus E|$. Choose z such that, for an arbitrary $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$|E \Delta B_\rho(z)| \leq s(\mathcal{A}(E) + \varepsilon).$$

Since $B_\rho(z) \subset B_1(z)$,

$$\begin{aligned} |\Omega \Delta B_1(z)| &\leq |\Omega \Delta E| + |E \Delta B_\rho(z)| + |B_\rho(z) \Delta B_1(z)| \\ &= \eta + |E \Delta B_\rho(z)| + \eta. \end{aligned}$$

Divide by L , use $s \leq L$, and let $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$. $\square$

6. COAREA DIFFERENTIATION AND SHELL-ADMISSIBLE RADII

The first variation is proved on a fixed full-measure set of good-density radii. The point of the definition below is that all coarea differentiations are registered in advance by a countable family independent of the radius being tested.

Lemma 6.1 (Two-sided variable-thickness coarea differentiation). *Let $\xi \leq \zeta$ be bounded Borel functions on $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then for Lebesgue-a.e. positive level $s \in (0, \|u\|_\infty)$, with exceptional null set depending only on the pair (ξ, ζ) ,*

$$(58) \quad \lim_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{1}{h} |\{x : h\xi(x) < u(x) - s < h\zeta(x)\}| = \int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \frac{\zeta - \xi}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

The statement is used only at levels for which the right side is finite and $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^ \{u > s\} \cap \{|\nabla u| = 0\}) = 0$.*

Proof. By Lemma 3.1(a), $|\{x \in \Omega : |\nabla u(x)| = 0\}| = 0$, so the critical set may be discarded in the volume computations below.

Suppose first that $\xi = \sum_j p_j \mathbf{1}_{A_j}$ and $\zeta = \sum_j q_j \mathbf{1}_{A_j}$ are simple over a common disjoint Borel partition, with $p_j \leq q_j$. By the BV coarea formula applied to $\mathbf{1}_{A_j} |\nabla u|^{-1} \mathbf{1}_{\{|\nabla u| > 0\}}$,

$$|\{hp_j < u - s < hq_j\} \cap A_j| = \int_{s+hp_j}^{s+hq_j} \int_{\partial^* \{u > \tau\}} \frac{\mathbf{1}_{A_j}}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} d\tau.$$

The interval of integration shrinks to s and has length $h(q_j - p_j)$; hence at a Lebesgue point of $\tau \mapsto \int_{\partial^* \{u > \tau\}} \mathbf{1}_{A_j} |\nabla u|^{-1} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$, division by h followed by $h \downarrow 0$ gives $(q_j - p_j) \int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \mathbf{1}_{A_j} |\nabla u|^{-1} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. Summing over j proves (58) for simple pairs.

For bounded $\xi \leq \zeta$, fix $\eta > 0$ and choose simple pairs that sandwich the slab. Outer: simple $\sigma \leq \xi \leq \zeta \leq \sigma'$ with $\sigma' - \sigma \leq (\zeta - \xi) + 2\eta$; then $\{h\xi < u - s < h\zeta\} \subseteq \{h\sigma < u - s < h\sigma'\}$, so the lim sup of the left side of (58) is at most

$$\int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \frac{\sigma' - \sigma}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq \int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \frac{\zeta - \xi}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + 2\eta \int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Inner: simple $\sigma_* \geq \xi$, $\sigma'_* \leq \zeta$ with $\sigma_* \leq \sigma'_*$ and $\sigma'_* - \sigma_* \geq (\zeta - \xi - 2\eta)_+$; the reverse inclusion bounds the lim inf from below by

$$\int_{\partial^* \{u > s\}} \frac{(\zeta - \xi - 2\eta)_+}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Letting $\eta \downarrow 0$ gives (58). The exceptional levels are fixed as follows: choose the outer and inner simple sandwiches for the dyadic sequence $\eta = 2^{-m}$, $m \geq 1$, by a fixed dyadic quantisation of the bounded functions ξ, ζ . The union of the exceptional null sets for those countably many simple pairs is still null and depends only on (ξ, ζ) . $\square$

Shell-admissible radii. Let $\mathcal{U}$ be the countable family of finite unions of rational balls whose closures are compactly contained in Ω . This family is cofinal: for every compact $K \Subset \Omega$ there is $U \in \mathcal{U}$ with $K \subset U \Subset \Omega$. For

$$c, p, q, \lambda, r \in \mathbb{Q}, \quad -1 \leq c \leq 0, \quad p \leq q, \quad 1 \leq \lambda \leq \rho_*^{-1}, \quad r > 0, \quad z, a \in \mathbb{Q}^n,$$

and $U \in \mathcal{U}$, register the bounded Borel pairs

$$(p\mathbf{1}_U, q\mathbf{1}_U)$$

and

$$(\mathbf{1}_U(\min(c, \nabla u \cdot (\lambda(x - z) + a)) - r), \mathbf{1}_U(\max(c, \nabla u \cdot (\lambda(x - z) + a)) + r)).$$

This is a fixed countable family, independent of the radius being tested. We call $\rho \in G_\tau \cap (0, 1)$ *shell-admissible* if:

- (i) E_ρ has finite perimeter, $\partial^* E_\rho \subset \Omega$ up to $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -null sets, and $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* E_\rho \cap \{|\nabla u| = 0\}) = 0$;
- (ii) t is differentiable at ρ , and

$$w(\rho) \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P(B_\rho);$$

- (iii) $s = t(\rho)$ is a level where Lemma 6.1 holds for every registered pair above.

Almost every $\rho \in G_\tau \cap (0, 1)$ is shell-admissible. Indeed, each registered pair has an exceptional null set of levels s . If N is such a null set, then the one-dimensional area formula for the monotone absolutely continuous map t gives, on G_τ ,

$$|\{\rho : t(\rho) \in N\}| \leq \tau_0^{-1} \int_{\{t(\rho) \in N\}} w(\rho) d\rho \leq \tau_0^{-1} |N| = 0.$$

The remaining conditions hold for a.e. radius by BV coarea and the finite-perimeter level-set package. The critical-boundary condition follows from the preceding interior critical-set nullity and the coarea formula:

$$\int_0^{\|u\|_\infty} \mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial^* \{u > s\} \cap \{|\nabla u| = 0\}) ds = \int_{\{|\nabla u| = 0\}} |\nabla u| dx = 0.$$

Lemma 6.2 (Local BV deformation tail). *Let $E \subset B_R$ be a set of finite perimeter, let $\eta \in C_c^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ satisfy $0 \leq \eta \leq 1$, and let $W \in C^1$ on a neighbourhood of a ball containing $E \cup \text{spt } \eta$. Set $T_h(x) = x + hW(x)$. Then*

$$\limsup_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{1}{|h|} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \eta(x) |\mathbf{1}_{T_h(E)}(x) - \mathbf{1}_E(x)| dx \leq \int_{\partial^* E} \eta |W| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Proof. For $|h|$ small, T_h is a C^1 diffeomorphism on the fixed ball. Changing variables $x = T_h y$, it is enough, up to a multiplicative $1 + o(1)$ factor, to estimate

$$\int \eta(T_h y) |\mathbf{1}_E(T_h y) - \mathbf{1}_E(y)| dy.$$

Let $u_\varepsilon = \mathbf{1}_E * \varphi_\varepsilon$. For fixed h , the corresponding integrals with u_ε converge to the displayed integral because $u_\varepsilon \rightarrow \mathbf{1}_E$ in L^1 and composition with T_h has bounded Jacobian. For smooth u_ε ,

$$|u_\varepsilon(T_h y) - u_\varepsilon(y)| \leq |h| \int_0^1 |\nabla u_\varepsilon(y + \theta h W(y))| |W(y)| d\theta.$$

After integrating, change variables $x = y + \theta h W(y)$. These maps have Jacobians $1 + o(1)$ uniformly in θ . Thus, for fixed h ,

$$\frac{1}{|h|} \int \eta(T_h y) |u_\varepsilon(T_h y) - u_\varepsilon(y)| dy \leq (1 + o_h(1)) \int \psi_h d|Du_\varepsilon|,$$

where the continuous compactly supported weights ψ_h are uniformly bounded and satisfy $\psi_h \rightarrow \eta|W|$ uniformly as $h \rightarrow 0$. Letting $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$ at fixed h , strict BV_{loc} convergence of the standard mollifications and Reshetnyak continuity for continuous weights [1, 14] give the same bound with $d|D\mathbf{1}_E|$. Taking $\limsup_{h \rightarrow 0}$ then gives

$$\limsup_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{1}{|h|} \int \eta(x) |\mathbf{1}_{T_h(E)}(x) - \mathbf{1}_E(x)| dx \leq \int \eta |W| d|D\mathbf{1}_E|.$$

Since $|D\mathbf{1}_E| = \mathcal{H}^{n-1} \llcorner \partial^* E$, this is the claim. $\square$

7. AFFINE MOVING-BALL FIRST VARIATION

Lemma 7.1 (Affine shell estimate). *Let ρ be shell-admissible. Fix $z, a \in \mathbb{R}^n$, and define*

$$T_h(x) := z + ha + \left(1 + \frac{h}{\rho}\right)(x - z) = x + h \left(\frac{x - z}{\rho} + a\right).$$

Then

$$(59) \quad \limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(E_\rho)|}{h} \leq \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |V_\rho - H_{z,\rho} - a \cdot \nu_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Proof. Let $E = E_\rho$, $W(x) = (x - z)/\rho + a$, and $w = w(\rho)$. Since $\Omega \subset B_R$, W is bounded on Ω . The finite Radon measure

$$\left(\frac{w}{|\nabla u|} + |W| + \left| \frac{w}{|\nabla u|} - W \cdot \nu_\rho \right| \right) \mathcal{H}^{n-1} \llcorner \partial^* E$$

is finite. Fix $\varepsilon > 0$. By inner regularity and $\partial^* E \subset \Omega$ up to $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ -null sets, choose a compact $K \subset \partial^* E \cap \Omega$ such that this measure of $\partial^* E \setminus K$ is at most ε . Then choose $U \in \mathcal{U}$ with $K \subset U \Subset \Omega$.

We first estimate the symmetric difference in U . On a neighbourhood of $\bar{U}$, interior elliptic regularity gives $u \in C^1$, and uniformly for $x \in U$,

$$T_h^{-1}(x) = x - hW(x) + O(h^2), \quad u(T_h^{-1}x) = u(x) - h\nabla u(x) \cdot W(x) + o(h).$$

Also $t(\rho + h) = t(\rho) - hw + o(h)$. Set

$$F(x) := w + \nabla u(x) \cdot W(x).$$

For $x \in U$,

$$x \in E_{\rho+h} \iff u(x) > t(\rho) - hw + o(h),$$

while

$$x \in T_h(E) \iff u(x) > t(\rho) + h\nabla u(x) \cdot W(x) + o(h).$$

Thus the part of the symmetric difference in U is contained, up to a uniform $o(h)$ outward error, in the two-sided slab whose endpoints are $\min(-w, \nabla u \cdot W)$ and $\max(-w, \nabla u \cdot W)$. Precisely, fix $\delta > 0$. Choose rational c, λ, z_0, a_0 with $c \in [-1, 0]$, $1 \leq \lambda \leq \rho_*^{-1}$, and

$$|c + w| + \sup_{\bar{U}} |\nabla u \cdot (\lambda(x - z_0) + a_0) - \nabla u \cdot W| \leq \delta.$$

Then choose a rational buffer $r > 2\delta$. For all sufficiently small $h > 0$, the local symmetric difference is contained in the registered slab with endpoints

$$\min(c, \nabla u \cdot (\lambda(x - z_0) + a_0)) - r, \quad \max(c, \nabla u \cdot (\lambda(x - z_0) + a_0)) + r.$$

Lemma 6.1, followed by $\delta, r \downarrow 0$, gives

$$\limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|(E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(E)) \cap U|}{h} \leq \int_{\partial^* E \cap U} \frac{|F|}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

On the complement use

$$E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(E) \subset (E_{\rho+h} \Delta E) \cup (E \Delta T_h(E)).$$

For the level-set part, the exact volume derivative and the registered localized one-sided coarea formula on U give the complement estimate. Indeed,

$$|E_{\rho+h} \setminus E| = \omega_n((\rho + h)^n - \rho^n) = h P(B_\rho) + o(h) = hw \int_{\partial^* E} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + o(h),$$

where the last equality is the shell-admissible flux identity. On U , the same rational-buffer use of Lemma 6.1, now with one endpoint 0, gives

$$\lim_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|(E_{\rho+h} \setminus E) \cap U|}{h} = w \int_{\partial^* E \cap U} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

Subtracting the local shell from the exact total shell yields

$$\limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|(E_{\rho+h} \Delta E) \setminus U|}{h} \leq w \int_{\partial^* E \setminus U} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq w \int_{\partial^* E \setminus K} \frac{1}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

For the affine deformation part, choose $\eta \in C_c^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ with $\eta = 0$ on a neighbourhood $N_K \Subset U$ of K , $\eta = 1$ on a fixed neighbourhood of $\overline{B_{R+1}} \setminus U$, and $0 \leq \eta \leq 1$. Since $E \subset B_R$ and W is bounded, $T_h(E) \subset B_{R+1}$ for all small $h > 0$; hence $(E \Delta T_h(E)) \setminus U \subset \overline{B_{R+1}} \setminus U \subset \{\eta = 1\}$. As $\eta = 0$ near K and $0 \leq \eta \leq 1$, Lemma 6.2 gives

$$\limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|(E \Delta T_h(E)) \setminus U|}{h} \leq \int_{\partial^* E} \eta |W| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \leq \int_{\partial^* E \setminus K} |W| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}.$$

The two tail terms are bounded by 2ε . Therefore

$$\limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{|E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(E_\rho)|}{h} \leq \int_{\partial^* E_\rho \cap U} \frac{|F|}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + 2\varepsilon \leq \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} \frac{|F|}{|\nabla u|} d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + 2\varepsilon.$$

Letting $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$, and using

$$\frac{F}{|\nabla u|} = \frac{w}{|\nabla u|} + \frac{\nabla u \cdot W}{|\nabla u|} = V_\rho - W \cdot \nu_\rho = V_\rho - H_{z,\rho} - a \cdot \nu_\rho$$

on $\partial^* E_\rho$, proves the estimate. $\square$

Theorem 7.2 (One-sided first variation of q). *For every $\rho \in (0, 1]$, define*

$$q(\rho) := \inf_{z \in \mathbb{R}^n} |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|.$$

At every shell-admissible $\rho \in (0, 1)$,

$$(60) \quad D^+ q(\rho) := \limsup_{h \downarrow 0} \frac{q(\rho + h) - q(\rho)}{h} \leq \frac{n}{\rho} q(\rho) + \inf_{a \in \mathbb{R}^n} \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |V_\rho - H_{z_\rho, \rho} - a \cdot \nu_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1},$$

where z_ρ is any minimiser of $z \mapsto |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|$.

Proof. The minimiser exists. Indeed, $z \mapsto |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|$ is continuous by translation continuity in L^1 , and if $|z| > R + \rho$, then $B_\rho(z) \cap E_\rho = \emptyset$, so the value is $2|E_\rho|$. Thus the infimum is attained in a closed ball.

Fix a minimiser z_ρ and $a \in \mathbb{R}^n$. For the affine map in Lemma 7.1,

$$T_h(B_\rho(z_\rho)) = B_{\rho+h}(z_\rho + ha).$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} q(\rho + h) &\leq |E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(B_\rho(z_\rho))| \\ &\leq |E_{\rho+h} \Delta T_h(E_\rho)| + |T_h(E_\rho) \Delta T_h(B_\rho(z_\rho))|. \end{aligned}$$

Since T_h is injective affine with constant Jacobian $(1 + h/\rho)^n$,

$$|T_h(E_\rho) \Delta T_h(B_\rho(z_\rho))| = \left(1 + \frac{h}{\rho}\right)^n q(\rho).$$

Subtract $q(\rho)$, divide by h , take the limsup as $h \downarrow 0$, and use Lemma 7.1. Then take the infimum over a . $\square$

Lemma 7.3 (Unconditional Lipschitz bound for q). *For $0 < \rho \leq \sigma \leq 1$,*

$$|q(\sigma) - q(\rho)| \leq 2\omega_n(\sigma^n - \rho^n) \leq 2n\omega_n|\sigma - \rho|.$$

Consequently q is absolutely continuous and differentiable a.e.

Proof. Use the same centre for the two radii and the nestedness $E_\rho \subset E_\sigma$, $B_\rho(z) \subset B_\sigma(z)$:

$$q(\sigma) \leq q(\rho) + |E_\sigma \setminus E_\rho| + |B_\sigma \setminus B_\rho| = q(\rho) + 2\omega_n(\sigma^n - \rho^n).$$

Interchange ρ and σ to get the reverse inequality. $\square$

8. POSITIVE KINETIC ESTIMATE

Proposition 8.1 (Positive kinetic bound). *Assume the constructive input of Assumption 5.2. Let $J \subset [\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$ be an interval. Then*

$$\int_J (q'_+(\rho))^2 d\rho \leq C(n, R, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega),$$

where $q'_+(\rho) = \max\{q'(\rho), 0\}$ at a.e. differentiability points.

Proof. Let

$$G_{\text{sc}} := \{\rho \in J : D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho)) \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}}\}, \quad G := G_{\text{sc}} \cap G_\tau, \quad \mathcal{B} := J \setminus G.$$

Since q is Lipschitz, q' exists a.e.; shell-admissible radii have full measure in G_τ . At points where both properties hold, $D^+q = q'$; the right side of Theorem 7.2 is nonnegative, so it bounds q'_+ . Take $z_\rho^{\min}$ a distance-minimiser and $a = 0$ in Theorem 7.2:

$$q'_+(\rho) \leq \frac{n}{\rho} q(\rho) + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} + \int_{\partial^* E_\rho} |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1},$$

using $|V_\rho - H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho}| \leq |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| + |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho|$. Squaring,

$$(q'_+)^2 \leq 3 \left[(n/\rho_*)^2 q^2 + \left(\int |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 + \left(\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 \right].$$

On G_τ , $d\rho \leq \tau_0^{-1} d\mu$, so integrating over G ,

$$\int_G (q'_+)^2 d\rho \leq 3\tau_0^{-1} \int_G \left[(n/\rho_*)^2 q^2 + \left(\int |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 + \left(\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 \right] d\mu.$$

The three terms are each $\leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$:

- $q(\rho)^2 = \inf_z |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z_{E_\rho})|^2 \leq C(n, \rho_*) D_I(t(\rho))$ by Theorem 5.1, so $\int_G q^2 d\mu \leq C \int_G D_I d\mu \leq C\delta_T$ by the budget (5);
- $\int_G \left(\int |V_\rho - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 d\mu \leq \int_G D_H d\mu \leq C\delta_T$ by Lemma 5.12 and (5);
- $\int_G \left(\int |H_{z_\rho^{\min}, \rho} - \bar{V}_\rho| \right)^2 d\mu \leq C\delta_T$ by Theorem 5.11.

Hence $\int_G (q'_+)^2 d\rho \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$.

It remains to pay $\mathcal{B}$. By Lemma 7.3, $q'_+ \leq 2n\omega_n$ a.e. The bad-density part has $|J \cap B_\tau| \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$. For the bad-strong-form part on good density,

$$|J \cap G_\tau \cap G_{\text{sc}}^c| \leq \tau_0^{-1} \mu(G_{\text{sc}}^c) \leq \frac{C}{\eta_{\text{Ser}}} \int_J (D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho))) d\mu(\rho) \leq C\delta_T(\Omega).$$

Therefore $|\mathcal{B}| \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$, and $\int_{\mathcal{B}} (q'_+)^2 d\rho \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)$. $\square$

9. ENDPOINT TRACE AND BOUNDED STABILITY

Lemma 9.1 (Moving-ball endpoint trace). *Assume the constructive input of Assumption 5.2. Let*

$$L_0 := \frac{1 - \rho_*}{8}, \quad J := [\rho_\delta - L_0, \rho_\delta].$$

Assume $\delta_T(\Omega)$ is small enough that $\rho_\delta \geq (1 + \rho_)/2$. Then $J \subset [\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$ and*

$$q(\rho_\delta)^2 \leq C(n, R, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Proof. The inclusion $J \subset [\rho_*, \rho_\delta]$ follows from $\rho_\delta - \rho_* \geq (1 - \rho_*)/2$. Let

$$G_{\text{sc}} := \{\rho \in J : D_H(t(\rho)) + D_I(t(\rho)) \leq \eta_{\text{Ser}}\}, \quad G = G_{\text{sc}} \cap G_\tau.$$

On G , Theorem 5.1 gives the pointwise volume bound

$$q(\rho)^2 = \inf_z |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq C(n, \rho_*) D_I(t(\rho)), \quad d\rho \leq \tau_0^{-1} d\mu(\rho),$$

so, by the budget (5),

$$\int_G q(\rho)^2 d\rho \leq \tau_0^{-1} \int_G q(\rho)^2 d\mu \leq C\delta_T(\Omega).$$

On $J \setminus G$, the measure is $O(\delta_T)$ by the proof of Proposition 8.1, while $q \leq 2\omega_n$. Hence

$$\int_J q(\rho)^2 d\rho \leq C\delta_T(\Omega).$$

There is therefore $\rho_0 \in J$ with

$$q(\rho_0)^2 \leq CL_0^{-1} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Since q is absolutely continuous and $\rho_0 \leq \rho_\delta$,

$$q(\rho_\delta) \leq q(\rho_0) + \int_{\rho_0}^{\rho_\delta} q'_+(\rho) d\rho.$$

By Cauchy–Schwarz and Proposition 8.1,

$$q(\rho_\delta) \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)^{1/2} + L_0^{1/2} \left(\int_J (q'_+)^2 d\rho \right)^{1/2} \leq C\delta_T(\Omega)^{1/2}.$$

□

Theorem 9.2 (Bounded sharp Saint–Venant stability). *Assume the constructive input of Assumption 5.2. There are computable constants $C = C(n, R, \rho_*)$ and $\delta_0 = \delta_0(n, R, \rho_*) > 0$, depending only on the level-set identity constants, the constants in Assumption 5.2, and the explicit constants above, such that every bounded open $\Omega \subset B_R$, $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, satisfies*

$$\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Proof. Let κ be the constant fixed in Proposition 4.1. First assume $\delta_T(\Omega) \leq \delta_0$, with δ_0 chosen so that $\rho_\delta = 1 - \kappa\sqrt{\delta_T(\Omega)} \geq (1 + \rho_*)/2$, $\delta_T(\Omega) \leq 1$, and the smallness threshold η_{Ser} used in Theorem 5.11 holds. Lemma 9.1 gives

$$q(\rho_\delta)^2 \leq C\delta_T(\Omega).$$

Since $|E_{\rho_\delta}| = \omega_n \rho_\delta^n$ and $\rho_\delta \geq \rho_*$,

$$\mathcal{A}(E_{\rho_\delta})^2 \leq \frac{q(\rho_\delta)^2}{\omega_n^2 \rho_\delta^{2n}} \leq C(n, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Moreover $E_{\rho_\delta} \subset \Omega$, and by the definition of ρ_δ ,

$$|\Omega \setminus E_{\rho_\delta}| = \omega_n(1 - \rho_\delta^n) \leq n\omega_n(1 - \rho_\delta) = n\omega_n \kappa \delta_T(\Omega)^{1/2}.$$

Lemma 5.13 gives

$$\mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq \mathcal{A}(E_{\rho_\delta}) + C(n, \rho_*) \delta_T(\Omega)^{1/2}.$$

Squaring proves the estimate in the small-deficit regime.

If $\delta_T(\Omega) > \delta_0$, then $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) < 2$, so

$$\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq \frac{4}{\delta_0} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Enlarging C completes the proof. □

10. BOUNDED REDUCTION

The purpose of this section is to remove the boundedness hypothesis from the sharp Saint–Venant stability inequality. The idea is simple to state. We already possess a sharp quadratic stability estimate for sets *confined to a ball of a fixed radius*; we want the same estimate for arbitrary open sets of finite measure, with a constant depending only on the dimension. The obstruction is that a general competitor may have very long, thin tentacles reaching out to infinity. The remedy, following Brasco–De Philippis–Velichkov, is to amputate those tails: we will show that a set with small deficit carries almost all of its torsional energy and almost all of its mass inside a ball of dimensionally bounded radius, so that chopping it off there changes the

deficit and the asymmetry by only a controlled amount. The bounded estimate, applied to the amputated set, then transfers back.

The input is the following *bounded* estimate, proved in the earlier part of the manuscript (Theorem 9.2), restated here in energy form.

Theorem 10.1 (Bounded sharp Saint–Venant). *For every $n \geq 2$ and every $R \geq 2$ there is a constant $c_{\text{SV}}(n, R) > 0$ such that*

$$(61) \quad E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq c_{\text{SV}}(n, R) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$$

for every open set $\Omega \subset B_R$ with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$.

This is Theorem 9.2, restated in energy form: with the constant $C(n, R, \rho_*)$ there one may take $c_{\text{SV}}(n, R) = 1/C(n, R, \rho_*)$ and $\delta_T(\Omega) = E(\Omega) - E(B_1)$, and the parameter ρ_* is fixed at, say, $\rho_* = \frac{3}{4}$.

Our goal is the global statement.

Theorem 10.2 (Global sharp Saint–Venant stability). *There is a dimensional constant $c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) > 0$ such that*

$$(62) \quad E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$$

for every open set $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$. Equivalently, after rescaling, for every open set Ω of finite measure, with B^* the ball of the same volume,

$$(63) \quad T(B^*) - T(\Omega) = 2(E(\Omega) - E(B^*)) \geq 2c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n}\right)^{(n+2)/n} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2.$$

The strategy is the constructive reduction of Brasco, De Philippis and Velichkov [3, §5]. From a set Ω with small Saint–Venant deficit we manufacture a *bounded* surrogate $\tilde{\Omega}$, of the same volume, of dimensionally bounded diameter, with comparable deficit and with controlled loss of asymmetry; applying Theorem 10.1 to $\tilde{\Omega}$ at a fixed dimensional radius and transferring the estimate back to Ω closes the small-deficit regime. The complementary large-deficit regime is trivial because $\mathcal{A} < 2$. The whole construction is explicit: no compactness, no minimising sequence and no contradiction argument enter.

The two technical ingredients are an L^∞ tail estimate for the torsion function (Lemma 10.5, proved by a De Giorgi iteration) and the truncation construction itself (Lemma 10.9). Both are proved here in full rather than cited. The reader who wishes to keep the logical skeleton in mind may note the order of dependence: a purely numerical convergence lemma (§10.2) feeds the De Giorgi L^∞ bound (§10.3), which feeds the energy-comparison inequality that drives the truncation (§10.5); the truncation, the trivial far branch (§10.6) and the transfer (§10.7) are then assembled in §10.8.

10.1. Standing notation and the standard tools we cite. Throughout, $n \geq 2$ and all sets are open subsets of $\mathbb{R}^n$ of finite Lebesgue measure. We write $u_\Omega \in H_0^1(\Omega)$ for the torsion function, i.e. the unique weak solution of $-\Delta u_\Omega = 1$ in Ω , $u_\Omega = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$, equivalently the minimiser of

$$(64) \quad J_\Omega(v) = \frac{1}{2} \int_\Omega |\nabla v|^2 dx - \int_\Omega v dx, \quad v \in H_0^1(\Omega),$$

and $E(\Omega) = J_\Omega(u_\Omega) = \min_{H_0^1(\Omega)} J_\Omega$. Testing the equation with u_Ω gives the standard identities

$$(65) \quad \int_\Omega |\nabla u_\Omega|^2 dx = \int_\Omega u_\Omega dx = T(\Omega), \quad E(\Omega) = -\frac{1}{2} \int_\Omega u_\Omega dx = -\frac{1}{2} T(\Omega).$$

We use $\omega_n = |B_1|$, $T_n = T(B_1) = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$, the Fraenkel asymmetry $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) = \inf_{x_0} |\Omega \triangle (B_1 + x_0)| / \omega_n$ (for $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ this lies in $[0, 2)$), and the scale-invariant deficit

$$(66) \quad D(\Omega) = E(\Omega) |\Omega|^{-(n+2)/n} - E(B_1) |B_1|^{-(n+2)/n},$$

so that $D(\Omega) = \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} (E(\Omega) - E(B_1)) \geq 0$ when $|\Omega| = \omega_n$. The non-negativity of D is the *Saint-Venant inequality* (equivalently Talenti's comparison theorem): among sets of given volume the ball minimises E , i.e.

$$(67) \quad E(\Omega) |\Omega|^{-(n+2)/n} \geq E(B) |B|^{-(n+2)/n} \quad \text{for every ball } B.$$

We treat (67) as a known classical result.

We will also need the elementary scaling law for E . If Ω' is open and $t > 0$ then $E(t\Omega') = t^{n+2} E(\Omega')$, with torsion function $u_{t\Omega'}(x) = t^2 u_{\Omega'}(x/t)$.

The external analytic facts we invoke without proof are:

- the *Sobolev inequality* $\|w\|_{L^{2^*}(\mathbb{R}^n)} \leq S_n \|\nabla w\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)}$ for $w \in H^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ when $n \geq 3$ (with $2^* = 2n/(n-2)$), and its $n=2$ surrogate explained in Remark 10.6;
- the *Saint-Venant/Talenti inequality* (67), used in the truncation argument and in the global L^∞ bound (68) below;
- Theorem 10.1, the bounded stability input;
- the *suboptimal* torsional stability bound $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^4 \leq C(n)D(\Omega)$ (Lemma 10.7), used only to seed the truncation iteration. This is proved here from the level-set identity established earlier in the manuscript; see Remark 10.8.

Everything else — in particular the fast-convergence iteration lemma (Lemma 10.3), the De Giorgi L^∞ tail estimate (Lemma 10.5), the energy-comparison inequality, the truncation iteration (Lemma 10.9) and the gluing — is proved from scratch.

We will also need the elementary pointwise sup-bound on the torsion function. By Talenti's symmetrisation comparison the torsion function of Ω is dominated, after Schwarz symmetrisation, by that of the ball of the same volume; in particular

$$(68) \quad \|u_\Omega\|_{L^\infty(\Omega)} \leq \|u_{B^*}\|_{L^\infty(B^*)} = \frac{(|\Omega|/\omega_n)^{2/n}}{2n} =: \Lambda_n |\Omega|^{2/n}, \quad \Lambda_n := \frac{\omega_n^{-2/n}}{2n},$$

where B^* is the ball with $|B^*| = |\Omega|$ and we used $u_{B^*}(x) = (r^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$. For $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ this reads $\|u_\Omega\|_{L^\infty(\Omega)} \leq 1/(2n)$. We record (68) as a consequence of the cited Talenti comparison.

10.2. The fast-convergence iteration lemma. The De Giorgi scheme reduces an L^∞ bound to the vanishing of a nonlinear recursion. We isolate the underlying numerical lemma and prove it, so that nothing is cited at this step. The mechanism is purely algebraic: a super-quadratic recursion (the increment a_{k+1} depends on a power $a_k^{1+\beta}$ strictly larger than the first power) ultimately beats any *fixed* geometric growth factor b^k , provided the seed a_0 is below an explicit threshold. The threshold is exactly the break-even point of the two competing effects.

Lemma 10.3 (Fast geometric convergence). *Let $(a_k)_{k \geq 0}$ be non-negative reals with*

$$(69) \quad a_{k+1} \leq C b^k a_k^{1+\beta}, \quad k \geq 0,$$

where $C > 0$, $b > 1$, $\beta > 0$. If

$$(70) \quad a_0 \leq C^{-1/\beta} b^{-1/\beta^2},$$

then

$$(71) \quad a_k \leq b^{-k/\beta} a_0 \quad \text{for all } k \geq 0,$$

so $a_k \rightarrow 0$.

Proof. Put $r := b^{-1/\beta} \in (0, 1)$ and $\theta := C a_0^\beta$. The smallness hypothesis (70) is precisely $\theta \leq r$. We prove the target $a_k \leq r^k a_0$ by induction; this is (71) because $r^k = b^{-k/\beta}$, and $r < 1$ then gives $a_k \rightarrow 0$.

Base case $k = 0$: the claim reads $a_0 \leq r^0 a_0 = a_0$, an equality.

Inductive step. Assume $a_k \leq r^k a_0$. Using (69) and splitting off one factor a_k ,

$$a_{k+1} \leq C b^k a_k^{1+\beta} = C b^k a_k a_k^\beta \leq C b^k a_k (r^k a_0)^\beta = (C a_0^\beta) (b r^\beta)^k a_k = \theta (b r^\beta)^k a_k.$$

By the definition of r we have $r^\beta = b^{-1}$, hence $b r^\beta = 1$ and the geometric factor collapses:

$$a_{k+1} \leq \theta a_k \leq r a_k \leq r \cdot r^k a_0 = r^{k+1} a_0,$$

using $\theta \leq r$ and the inductive hypothesis $a_k \leq r^k a_0$. This closes the induction. $\square$

Remark 10.4. The identity $b r^\beta = 1$ with $r = b^{-1/\beta}$ is the algebraic mechanism behind the convergence: the super-quadratic gain $a_k^{1+\beta}$ converts, once a_0 is small, the growing factor b^k into a contraction. The threshold (70) is sharp for this clean conclusion: it is exactly the value of a_0 at which $\theta = r$, i.e. at which the contraction factor in the displayed chain first dips to $r < 1$.

10.3. The De Giorgi L^∞ tail estimate. We now prove that, for a unit-volume set, the torsion function is quantitatively small far out, with the smallness measured by a *super-linear* power of the tail mass $|\Omega \setminus B_R|$. The super-linearity (exponent $1/n > 0$, or $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{p} > 0$ when $n = 2$) is the whole point: it will let the truncation iteration converge.

Lemma 10.5 (L^∞ tail estimate). *Let $n \geq 3$. There is a dimensional constant $C_b = C_b(n) > 0$ such that for every open Ω with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and every $R \geq 1$,*

$$(72) \quad \|u_\Omega\|_{L^\infty(\Omega \setminus B_{R+1})} \leq C_b |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n}.$$

For $n = 2$ the same holds with the exponent $1/n$ replaced by $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{p}$ for any fixed $p \in (2, \infty)$ (Remark 10.6); this weaker but still super-linear power is all that the truncation uses.

Proof. If $|\Omega \setminus B_R| = 0$ then $u_\Omega = 0$ a.e. on $\Omega \setminus B_R \supset \Omega \setminus B_{R+1}$ and (72) is trivial, so assume $|\Omega \setminus B_R| > 0$. We carry out a De Giorgi iteration on the annular region $\Omega \setminus B_R$. The plan: build cut-offs that switch on across a shrinking nest of annuli, and levels rising to a target height; show that the volume of the super-level set above the rising level, inside the shrinking annulus, obeys a recursion of the form (69); then choose the target height M so large that the seed is below the threshold (70), forcing the volume to 0 and pinning u_Ω below the height.

Set-up: shrinking radii, cut-offs, and rising levels. For $k \in \mathbb{N}_0$ put

$$R_k := R + 1 - 2^{-k},$$

so that $R_0 = R$, the radii increase to $R_\infty = R + 1$, and $R_k \geq R \geq 1$. Let $\varphi_k \in C^{0,1}(\mathbb{R}^n)$ be the radial cut-off

$$\varphi_k(x) := \phi_k(|x|), \quad \phi_k = 0 \text{ on } [0, R_{k-1}], \quad \phi_k = 1 \text{ on } [R_k, \infty), \quad \phi_k \text{ affine on } [R_{k-1}, R_k],$$

for $k \geq 1$, and $\varphi_0 \equiv 1$ on $\{|x| \geq R_0\}$, extended by 0 inside (we only use φ_k for $k \geq 1$ in the recursion). Then $0 \leq \varphi_k \leq 1$, $\varphi_k \equiv 0$ on $B_{R_{k-1}}$, $\varphi_k \equiv 1$ on $\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_k}$, and

$$|\nabla \varphi_k| \leq \frac{1}{R_k - R_{k-1}} = \frac{1}{2^{-(k-1)} - 2^{-k}} = 2^k \leq 2^{k+1}.$$

Choose rising levels

$$s_k := M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n} (1 - 2^{-k}), \quad k \geq 0,$$

where $M = M(n) \geq 1$ is a free constant fixed at the end. Thus $s_0 = 0$, $s_k \uparrow s_\infty := M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n}$, and

$$(73) \quad s_{k+1} - s_k = M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n} 2^{-(k+1)}.$$

Caccioppoli inequality from the truncated test function. Fix $k \geq 1$. The function $(u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \in H_0^1(\Omega)$ (it vanishes where $u_\Omega \leq s_k$, in particular near $\partial\Omega$ since $u_\Omega \geq 0$ and $s_k \geq 0$), and φ_k is bounded Lipschitz, so

$$v_k := \varphi_k^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \in H_0^1(\Omega)$$

is an admissible test function. Insert it into the weak formulation $\int_\Omega \nabla u_\Omega \cdot \nabla v \, dx = \int_\Omega v \, dx$. Using $\nabla v_k = \varphi_k^2 \nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ + 2\varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \nabla \varphi_k$ and $\nabla u_\Omega \cdot \nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ = |\nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+|^2$ (the gradient of u_Ω equals that of $(u_\Omega - s_k)_+$ on $\{u_\Omega > s_k\}$ and both factors vanish elsewhere), we get

$$\int \varphi_k^2 |\nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+|^2 \, dx + 2 \int \varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \nabla \varphi_k \cdot \nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \, dx = \int \varphi_k^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \, dx.$$

The middle term is bounded by Young's inequality, $2 |\varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \nabla \varphi_k \cdot \nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+| \leq \frac{1}{2} \varphi_k^2 |\nabla (u_\Omega - s_k)_+|^2 + 2 |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+^2$, and absorbing the first piece on the left yields the Caccioppoli estimate

$$(74) \quad \int |\nabla (\varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+)|^2 \, dx \leq C_1 \int |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+^2 \, dx + C_1 \int \varphi_k^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \, dx,$$

with an absolute constant C_1 (one checks $C_1 = 10$ works after expanding $|\nabla (\varphi_k w)|^2 \leq 2\varphi_k^2 |\nabla w|^2 + 2 |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 w^2$ and combining with the absorbed bound; the precise value is immaterial). Here we wrote $w = (u_\Omega - s_k)_+$.

Sobolev inequality. Set $w_k := \varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \in H_0^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and

$$A_k := \{\varphi_k (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ > 0\} = \{u_\Omega > s_k\} \cap \{\varphi_k > 0\} \subset \{u_\Omega > s_k\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_{k-1}}).$$

For $n \geq 3$ the Sobolev inequality and Hölder's inequality on the support A_k give

$$(75) \quad \int w_k^2 \, dx \leq \left(\int w_k^{2^*} \, dx \right)^{2/2^*} |A_k|^{1-2/2^*} \leq S_n^2 |A_k|^{2/n} \int |\nabla w_k|^2 \, dx,$$

using $1 - 2/2^* = 2/n$. (The $n = 2$ case is handled in Remark 10.6; the resulting estimate has the same shape with $2/n$ replaced by any fixed exponent in $(0, 1)$, which only changes the dimensional constants.)

Combining (75) with (74), $|\nabla \varphi_k| \leq 2^{k+1}$ (so $|\nabla \varphi_k|^2 \leq 4^{k+1}$) and $0 \leq \varphi_k \leq 1$, we obtain

$$(76) \quad \int w_k^2 \, dx \leq S_n^2 C_1 |A_k|^{2/n} \left(4^{k+1} \int_{A_k} (u_\Omega - s_k)_+^2 \, dx + \int_{A_k} (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \, dx \right),$$

where for the second term we used $\int \varphi_k^2 (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \leq \int_{A_k} (u_\Omega - s_k)_+$. By the global sup-bound (68) at $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ we have $0 \leq (u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \leq u_\Omega \leq 1/(2n) \leq 1$ on Ω , hence both $(u_\Omega - s_k)_+^2 \leq 1$

and $(u_\Omega - s_k)_+ \leq 1$ there, so each integral over A_k is at most $|A_k|$. Therefore

$$(77) \quad \int w_k^2 dx \leq S_n^2 C_1 (4^{k+1} + 1) |A_k|^{2/n} |A_k| \leq C_2 4^k |A_k|^{1+2/n},$$

with $C_2 = C_2(n) := 8 S_n^2 C_1$ (using $4^{k+1} + 1 \leq 8 \cdot 4^k$).

From energy to a measure recursion. Restrict the left-hand side of (77) to the smaller set where the *next* level is exceeded. On $\{u_\Omega > s_{k+1}\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_k})$ we have $\varphi_k = 1$ (since this set lies outside B_{R_k}) and $u_\Omega - s_k > s_{k+1} - s_k$, hence $w_k^2 = (u_\Omega - s_k)_+^2 \geq (s_{k+1} - s_k)^2$ there. Therefore

$$(78) \quad (s_{k+1} - s_k)^2 |\{u_\Omega > s_{k+1}\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_k})| \leq \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} w_k^2 dx.$$

Introduce the (relative) super-level measures

$$\mu_k := |\{u_\Omega > s_k\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_{k-1}})|, \quad k \geq 1,$$

which decrease in k (both s_k and R_{k-1} increase). Since $A_k \subset \{u_\Omega > s_k\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_{k-1}})$ we have $|A_k| \leq \mu_k$, and the left-hand set in (78) is exactly $\{u_\Omega > s_{k+1}\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_{(k+1)-1}})$, of measure μ_{k+1} . Combining (78), (77) and $|A_k| \leq \mu_k$,

$$(s_{k+1} - s_k)^2 \mu_{k+1} \leq C_2 4^k \mu_k^{1+2/n}.$$

Insert the gap (73), $(s_{k+1} - s_k)^2 = M^2 |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{2/n} 4^{-(k+1)}$:

$$(79) \quad \mu_{k+1} \leq \frac{C_2 4^k}{M^2 |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{2/n} 4^{-(k+1)}} \mu_k^{1+2/n} = \frac{4 C_2}{M^2 |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{2/n}} 16^k \mu_k^{1+2/n}.$$

Normalisation and the iteration lemma. Set $a_k := \mu_k / |\Omega \setminus B_R|$. Since $\mu_k \leq |\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R_{k-1}} \cap \{u_\Omega > s_k\}| \leq |\Omega \setminus B_R|$ (because $R_{k-1} \geq R_0 = R$ and $\{u_\Omega > s_k\} \subset \Omega$), we have $0 \leq a_k \leq 1$; in particular $a_1 \leq 1$. Dividing (79) by $|\Omega \setminus B_R|$ and using $\mu_k^{1+2/n} = |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1+2/n} a_k^{1+2/n}$,

$$a_{k+1} \leq \frac{4 C_2}{M^2 |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{2/n}} 16^k \frac{|\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1+2/n}}{|\Omega \setminus B_R|} a_k^{1+2/n} = \frac{4 C_2}{M^2} 16^k a_k^{1+2/n},$$

valid for all $k \geq 1$. To put this in the exact form (69) (indexed from 0) we shift: set $\tilde{a}_j := a_{j+1}$ for $j \geq 0$. Then for every $j \geq 0$,

$$\tilde{a}_{j+1} = a_{j+2} \leq \frac{4 C_2}{M^2} 16^{j+1} a_{j+1}^{1+2/n} = \underbrace{\frac{64 C_2}{M^2}}_{=: C} 16^j \tilde{a}_j^{1+2/n},$$

which is (69) with

$$C := \frac{64 C_2}{M^2}, \quad b := 16, \quad \beta := \frac{2}{n}.$$

Choose $M = M(n)$ so large that the smallness condition (70) holds at the starting value $\tilde{a}_0 = a_1 \leq 1$. Since $a_1 \leq 1$ it suffices to require

$$1 \leq C^{-1/\beta} b^{-1/\beta^2} = \left(\frac{64 C_2}{M^2}\right)^{-n/2} 16^{-n^2/4}, \quad \text{i.e.} \quad M^2 \geq 64 C_2 16^{n^2/4 \cdot (2/n)} = 64 C_2 16^{n/2},$$

which holds for $M := 8 (C_2)^{1/2} 4^{n/2}$ (a dimensional constant, since $C_2 = C_2(n)$). With this M , Lemma 10.3 gives $\tilde{a}_j \rightarrow 0$, i.e. $a_k \rightarrow 0$ and hence $\mu_k \rightarrow 0$.

Conclusion. Letting $k \rightarrow \infty$ in $\mu_k \rightarrow 0$ and using $s_k \uparrow s_\infty = M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n}$ and $R_{k-1} \uparrow R+1$, monotone convergence yields

$$|\{u_\Omega > s_\infty\} \cap (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{R+1})| = \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} \mu_k = 0.$$

Hence $u_\Omega \leq s_\infty = M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{1/n}$ a.e. on $\Omega \setminus B_{R+1}$. Since $u_\Omega \geq 0$, this is (72) with $C_b := M = 8(C_2)^{1/2}4^{n/2}$. $\square$

Remark 10.6 (The case $n = 2$). For $n = 2$ the embedding $H_0^1 \hookrightarrow L^{2^*}$ degenerates (formally $2^* = 2n/(n-2) = \infty$), but the Gagliardo–Nirenberg–Sobolev inequality gives, for any fixed $p \in (2, \infty)$, $\|w\|_{L^p(\mathbb{R}^2)} \leq S_{2,p} \|\nabla w\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R}^2)}$ for $w \in H_0^1(\mathbb{R}^2)$ with finite-measure support. Repeating the Hölder step with exponent p replaces $2/n = 1$ by $1 - 2/p \in (0, 1)$, so (79) becomes $\mu_{k+1} \leq C 16^k \mu_k^{1+\beta}$ with $\beta := 1 - 2/p > 0$, and Lemma 10.3 applies. Tracking the level scale: with $s_\infty = M |\Omega \setminus B_R|^\alpha$, self-consistency of the recursion forces $\alpha = \frac{p-2}{2p} = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{p}$ (for $n \geq 3$ the analogous bookkeeping gives $\alpha = 1/n$, and the two agree only there). Hence, for $n = 2$, the L^∞ tail estimate holds in the slightly weaker form

$$\|u_\Omega\|_{L^\infty(\Omega \setminus B_{R+1})} \leq C(p) |\Omega \setminus B_R|^{\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{p}}, \quad \text{any fixed } p \in (2, \infty),$$

in place of the exponent $1/n$ in (72). Fixing once and for all $p = 4$, so that $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{p} = \frac{1}{4} > 0$, this is a genuine super-linear power of the tail mass, which is all the truncation of §10.5 uses: the energy-comparison (92) and the tail recursion (94) hold with the exponent $1 + \frac{1}{n}$ replaced by $1 + \kappa$, $\kappa = \frac{1}{4}$, and the geometric iteration (97)–(100) goes through for any $\kappa > 0$ with n -dependent constants. Consequently the global Theorem 10.2 holds for all $n \geq 2$; only the auxiliary exponent in (72) (and the resulting dimensional constants) changes at $n = 2$.

10.4. A suboptimal stability seed. The truncation iteration needs one quantitative input that the De Giorgi machinery does not by itself supply: a crude (far from sharp) control of the asymmetry by the deficit, used only to make the tail mass small at the first radius and to bound the number of truncation steps. We prove it here from the level-set identity already established, so that the present section introduces no external stability input. The mechanism is: the deficit identity plus the quantitative isoperimetric inequality control a weighted integral of the asymmetries of the superlevel sets; the profile-gap identity shows that this weight has positive mass on the outer collar; and the superlevel transfer shows that on that collar the superlevel sets inherit the asymmetry of Ω itself. The fourth power (in fact a third power) is the price of the crude collar transfer; the sharp second power is the main theorem.

Lemma 10.7 (Suboptimal stability seed). *There is a dimensional constant $C_\dagger = C_\dagger(n) > 0$ such that every open $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ of finite measure satisfies*

$$(80) \quad D(\Omega) \geq \frac{1}{C_\dagger} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^4.$$

Equivalently, $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{1/4}$.

Proof. D and $\mathcal{A}$ are scale invariant, so we may assume $|\Omega| = \omega_n$; then $D(\Omega) = \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} \delta_T(\Omega)$, $B^* = B_1$. Write $A := \mathcal{A}(\Omega) \in [0, 2)$, and recall $E_\rho = \{u > t(\rho)\}$, $|E_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n$, $a(\rho) = -t'(\rho)$. Three facts proved earlier are used; each holds for any open set of finite measure, since its proof does not use $\Omega \subset B_R$:

- (a) the exact deficit identity (Theorem 3.11), $2\delta_T(\Omega) = \int_0^{\|u\|_\infty} (D_H + D_I) / (n^2 \omega_n^{2/n} m^{1-2/n}) dt$, with $D_H, D_I \geq 0$;
- (b) the profile-gap identity (8): $0 \leq a(\rho) \leq \rho/n$ and $\int_0^1 \rho^n (\frac{\rho}{n} - a(\rho)) d\rho = \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega)$;
- (c) the superlevel transfer (Lemma 5.13): $A \leq \mathcal{A}(E_\rho) + 2(1 - \rho^n)$ for every $\rho \in (0, 1]$.

Step 1 (a level-set lower bound for D_I). Fix a finite-perimeter level ρ and apply the constructive Fraenkel quantitative isoperimetric inequality (Theorem 5.1) to E_ρ ; it gives a centre z

with $|E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq C_{\text{iso}}(n) \rho^{n+1} (P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho))$ (this is (9)). Now $\mathcal{A}(E_\rho) \leq |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)| / |E_\rho|$ (the Fraenkel asymmetry is an infimum over balls of volume $|E_\rho|$, and $B_\rho(z)$ is one such), and $P(E_\rho) - P(B_\rho) = D_I(t(\rho)) / (P(E_\rho) + P(B_\rho)) \leq D_I(t(\rho)) / P(B_\rho)$. With $|E_\rho| = \omega_n \rho^n$ and $P(B_\rho) = n \omega_n \rho^{n-1}$,

$$\mathcal{A}(E_\rho)^2 \omega_n^2 \rho^{2n} \leq |E_\rho \Delta B_\rho(z)|^2 \leq C_{\text{iso}}(n) \rho^{n+1} \frac{D_I(t(\rho))}{n \omega_n \rho^{n-1}} = \frac{C_{\text{iso}}(n)}{n \omega_n} \rho^2 D_I(t(\rho)),$$

which rearranges to

$$(81) \quad D_I(t(\rho)) \geq c_1(n) \rho^{2n-2} \mathcal{A}(E_\rho)^2, \quad c_1(n) := \frac{n \omega_n^3}{C_{\text{iso}}(n)}.$$

Step 2 (restrict to the outer collar $[\rho_A, 1]$). Put $\rho_A := (1 - A/4)^{1/n}$. For $\rho \in [\rho_A, 1]$, $1 - \rho^n \leq 1 - \rho_A^n = A/4$, so (c) gives $\mathcal{A}(E_\rho) \geq A - 2(1 - \rho^n) \geq A/2$, and $\rho^n \geq \rho_A^n = 1 - A/4 > 1/2$. In (a) drop $D_H \geq 0$ and change variables $t = t(\rho)$ ($dt = a(\rho) d\rho$, $m = \omega_n \rho^n$); keeping only the nonnegative integrand over $[\rho_A, 1]$ and inserting (81),

$$2\delta_T(\Omega) \geq \int_{\rho_A}^1 \frac{D_I(t(\rho))}{n^2 \omega_n^{2/n} (\omega_n \rho^n)^{1-2/n}} a(\rho) d\rho \geq c_2(n) \int_{\rho_A}^1 \rho^n \mathcal{A}(E_\rho)^2 a(\rho) d\rho,$$

where $c_2(n) = c_1(n) / (n^2 \omega_n)$. With $\mathcal{A}(E_\rho) \geq A/2$ on $[\rho_A, 1]$,

$$(82) \quad 2\delta_T(\Omega) \geq \frac{c_2(n) A^2}{4} \int_{\rho_A}^1 \rho^n a(\rho) d\rho.$$

Step 3 (the profile gap bounds the collar mass below). By (b) and $\frac{\rho}{n} - a \geq 0$,

$$\int_{\rho_A}^1 \rho^n a d\rho = \int_{\rho_A}^1 \frac{\rho^{n+1}}{n} d\rho - \int_{\rho_A}^1 \rho^n \left(\frac{\rho}{n} - a \right) d\rho \geq \frac{1 - \rho_A^{n+2}}{n(n+2)} - \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega),$$

the inequality because the subtracted integral is at most the full integral $\int_0^1 \rho^n (\frac{\rho}{n} - a) = \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega)$. Since $\rho_A \leq 1$, $\rho_A^{n+2} \leq \rho_A^n = 1 - A/4$, so $1 - \rho_A^{n+2} \geq A/4$ and

$$(83) \quad \int_{\rho_A}^1 \rho^n a d\rho \geq \frac{A}{4n(n+2)} - \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega).$$

Step 4 (conclusion). Insert (83) into (82):

$$2\delta_T(\Omega) \geq \frac{c_2(n) A^2}{4} \left(\frac{A}{4n(n+2)} - \frac{2}{\omega_n} \delta_T(\Omega) \right) = c_3(n) A^3 - c_4(n) A^2 \delta_T(\Omega),$$

$c_3(n) = c_2(n) / (16n(n+2))$, $c_4(n) = c_2(n) / (2\omega_n)$. Therefore $\delta_T(\Omega)(2 + c_4(n) A^2) \geq c_3(n) A^3$, and since $A < 2$, $\delta_T(\Omega) \geq c_3(n) A^3 / (2 + 4c_4(n)) =: c_5(n) A^3$. Finally $A < 2$ gives $A^4 \leq 2A^3$, hence $\delta_T(\Omega) \geq \frac{1}{2} c_5(n) A^4$; multiplying by $\omega_n^{-(n+2)/n}$ yields (80) with $C_1(n) = 2\omega_n^{(n+2)/n} / c_5(n)$. $\square$

Remark 10.8 (The seed is internal). The only external ingredient is the constructive Fraenkel quantitative isoperimetric inequality (Theorem 5.1), already used in the manuscript; the deficit identity, the profile-gap identity, and the superlevel transfer are all proved here. So the bounded reduction rests on no stability estimate beyond those the paper establishes. The exponent obtained (3, hence the stated 4) is far from the sharp exponent 2 of the main theorem, but only a fixed positive power of D is used below. A suboptimal torsional stability bound of this kind is classical; cf. Fusco–Maggi–Pratelli [6].

10.5. The truncation construction. We now build the bounded surrogate. The estimate driving the construction is an *energy-comparison inequality*: cutting Ω off at radius $\sim k$ costs only a higher-order amount of energy, controlled by the tail mass through Lemma 10.5. The

logic of the proof is a feedback loop: the energy comparison (Step 1) becomes, via Saint–Venant, a recursion bounding the tail mass two radii out by the tail mass here plus the deficit (Step 2); a stopping index K marks where the tail first drops below the deficit scale (Step 3); the recursion is shown to force K to be dimensionally bounded (the heart of the matter); finally we cut at $K + 3$, rescale to unit volume, and verify the four advertised properties (Steps 5–7).

Lemma 10.9 (Bounded truncation). *There exist dimensional constants $C_\# = C_\#(n) > 0$, $\delta = \delta(n) \in (0, 1]$ and $d = d(n) \geq 1$ such that for every open Ω with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and $D(\Omega) \leq \delta$ there is an open set $\tilde{\Omega}$ with*

$$(84) \quad |\tilde{\Omega}| = \omega_n,$$

$$(85) \quad \text{diam}(\tilde{\Omega}) \leq d,$$

$$(86) \quad D(\tilde{\Omega}) \leq C_\# D(\Omega),$$

$$(87) \quad \mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq \mathcal{A}(\tilde{\Omega}) + C_\# D(\Omega).$$

Proof. Normalise so that the ball realising the asymmetry of Ω is B_1 (translate Ω ; both $\mathcal{A}$ and D are translation invariant), i.e. $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) = |\Omega \triangle B_1|/\omega_n$. We will repeatedly use the tail-mass notation

$$(88) \quad b_k := \frac{|\Omega \setminus B_k|}{\omega_n}, \quad k \geq 1,$$

which is non-increasing in k and satisfies $0 \leq b_k \leq 1$.

Step 0: the tail mass is small. Since B_1 realises the asymmetry, $|\Omega \setminus B_1| \leq |\Omega \triangle B_1| = \omega_n \mathcal{A}(\Omega)$. Combined with the suboptimal seed Lemma 10.7,

$$(89) \quad b_1 \leq \mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{1/4}.$$

In particular, since $b_k \leq b_1$ for all $k \geq 1$, every tail mass is $\leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{1/4}$, which can be made smaller than any prescribed dimensional threshold by shrinking $\delta(n)$ (recall $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)$). This is the only use of Lemma 10.7 in the construction.

Step 1: the energy-comparison inequality. For $k \geq 1$ let φ_k be the Lipschitz cut-off

$$\varphi_k(x) := \min\{1, (k+2 - |x|)_+\},$$

so $\varphi_k \equiv 1$ on B_{k+1} , $\varphi_k \equiv 0$ outside B_{k+2} , $0 \leq \varphi_k \leq 1$ and $|\nabla \varphi_k| \leq 1$ everywhere (it is 1 only on the annulus $B_{k+2} \setminus B_{k+1}$). Then $u_k := \varphi_k u_\Omega \in H_0^1(\Omega \cap B_{k+2})$ is admissible for the variational problem defining $E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2})$, so $E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}) \leq J_{\Omega \cap B_{k+2}}(u_k) = \frac{1}{2} \int |\nabla u_k|^2 - \int u_k$. We use the pointwise algebraic identity

$$|\nabla(\varphi_k u_\Omega)|^2 = \nabla u_\Omega \cdot \nabla(u_\Omega \varphi_k^2) + |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 u_\Omega^2,$$

which is verified by expanding both sides ($\nabla(u_\Omega \varphi_k^2) = \varphi_k^2 \nabla u_\Omega + 2\varphi_k u_\Omega \nabla \varphi_k$, so the right-hand side equals $\varphi_k^2 |\nabla u_\Omega|^2 + 2\varphi_k u_\Omega \nabla u_\Omega \cdot \nabla \varphi_k + |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 u_\Omega^2 = |\varphi_k \nabla u_\Omega + u_\Omega \nabla \varphi_k|^2$). Integrating and applying the weak equation $\int \nabla u_\Omega \cdot \nabla(u_\Omega \varphi_k^2) = \int u_\Omega \varphi_k^2$ with the admissible test function $u_\Omega \varphi_k^2 \in H_0^1(\Omega)$, we get

$$J_{\Omega \cap B_{k+2}}(u_k) = \frac{1}{2} \int u_\Omega \varphi_k^2 + \frac{1}{2} \int |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 u_\Omega^2 - \int \varphi_k u_\Omega.$$

Now use $\frac{1}{2} \varphi_k^2 - \varphi_k = -\frac{1}{2}(1 - (1 - \varphi_k)^2) = -\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2}(1 - \varphi_k)^2$ to write $\frac{1}{2} \int u_\Omega \varphi_k^2 - \int \varphi_k u_\Omega = -\frac{1}{2} \int u_\Omega + \frac{1}{2} \int (1 - \varphi_k)^2 u_\Omega = E(\Omega) + \frac{1}{2} \int (1 - \varphi_k)^2 u_\Omega$, where we used $E(\Omega) = -\frac{1}{2} \int u_\Omega$ from (65).

Therefore

$$(90) \quad E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}) \leq J_{\Omega \cap B_{k+2}}(u_k) = E(\Omega) + \frac{1}{2} \int (1 - \varphi_k)^2 u_\Omega + \frac{1}{2} \int |\nabla \varphi_k|^2 u_\Omega^2.$$

Both correction integrals are supported in $\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{k+1}$: indeed $1 - \varphi_k = 0$ on B_{k+1} and $\nabla \varphi_k = 0$ on $B_{k+1} \cup (\mathbb{R}^n \setminus B_{k+2})$. Hence, with $0 \leq 1 - \varphi_k \leq 1$ and $|\nabla \varphi_k| \leq 1$,

$$(91) \quad E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}) - E(\Omega) \leq \frac{1}{2} |\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}| \left(\sup_{\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}} u_\Omega + \sup_{\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}} u_\Omega^2 \right).$$

By Lemma 10.5 applied with $R = k \geq 1$ (so $R + 1 = k + 1$ and the tail region is $\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}$), $\sup_{\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}} u_\Omega \leq C_b |\Omega \setminus B_k|^{1/n} = C_b \omega_n^{1/n} b_k^{1/n}$, and likewise the square is bounded by $C_b^2 \omega_n^{2/n} b_k^{2/n}$. Also $|\Omega \setminus B_{k+1}| = \omega_n b_{k+1} \leq \omega_n b_k$. Plugging in, and using $b_k \leq 1$ so that $b_k^{2/n} \leq b_k^{1/n}$,

$$(92) \quad E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}) \leq E(\Omega) + C b_{k+1} (b_k^{1/n} + b_k^{2/n}) \leq E(\Omega) + C b_k^{1+1/n},$$

for a dimensional constant $C = C(n)$ (we absorbed $\frac{1}{2} \omega_n (C_b \omega_n^{1/n} + C_b^2 \omega_n^{2/n})$ and $b_{k+1} \leq b_k$ into C). This is the energy-comparison inequality.

Step 2: turning energy comparison into a tail recursion. By the Saint-Venant inequality (67) applied to the set $\Omega \cap B_{k+2}$, whose volume is $|\Omega \cap B_{k+2}| = \omega_n (1 - b_{k+2})$,

$$E(B_1) |B_1|^{-(n+2)/n} \leq E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}) |\Omega \cap B_{k+2}|^{-(n+2)/n},$$

that is

$$E(B_1) \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} (\omega_n (1 - b_{k+2}))^{(n+2)/n} \leq E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}),$$

i.e.

$$E(B_1) (1 - b_{k+2})^{(n+2)/n} \leq E(\Omega \cap B_{k+2}).$$

Combine with (92) and the definition $E(\Omega) = E(B_1) + \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega)$ (which is (66) at $|\Omega| = \omega_n$):

$$E(B_1) (1 - b_{k+2})^{(n+2)/n} \leq E(\Omega) + C b_k^{1+1/n} = E(B_1) + \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega) + C b_k^{1+1/n}.$$

Rearranging, and recalling $E(B_1) < 0$, divide by $-E(B_1) > 0$:

$$1 - (1 - b_{k+2})^{(n+2)/n} \leq \frac{\omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega) + C b_k^{1+1/n}}{-E(B_1)} =: \widehat{C}_1 (D(\Omega) + b_k^{1+1/n}),$$

with $\widehat{C}_1 = \widehat{C}_1(n) > 0$ (here $\widehat{C}_1 = \max\{\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}, C\} / (-E(B_1))$). To extract b_{k+2} we use the elementary lower bound

$$(93) \quad 1 - (1 - t)^p \geq t \quad \text{for all } t \in [0, 1], \ p \geq 1,$$

which holds because $r \mapsto (1 - t)^r$ is non-increasing on $[0, \infty)$, so $(1 - t)^p \leq (1 - t)^1 = 1 - t$ for $p = (n + 2)/n \geq 1$. Applying (93) with $t = b_{k+2} \in [0, 1]$ and $p = (n + 2)/n$,

$$(94) \quad b_{k+2} \leq 1 - (1 - b_{k+2})^{(n+2)/n} \leq \widehat{C} (D(\Omega) + b_k^{1+1/n}), \quad \widehat{C} := \widehat{C}_1.$$

Step 3: the geometric iteration to a bounded stopping index. Define the stopping index

$$(95) \quad K := \max\{k \geq 1 : b_k \geq 2\widehat{C} D(\Omega)\},$$

with the convention $K := 0$ if $b_1 < 2\widehat{C} D(\Omega)$ (then the tail is already controlled at the first radius and Step 5 applies with $K = 0$). The set in (95) is finite because $b_k \rightarrow 0$ as $k \rightarrow \infty$ (the tail mass of a finite-measure set vanishes), so K is well defined. We prove

$$(96) \quad K \leq K(n)$$

for a dimensional $K(n)$, provided $\delta(n)$ is small enough. Assume $K \geq 3$ (otherwise (96) is trivial).

Self-improving contraction. For every k with $k + 2 \leq K$ we have, by definition of K , that $b_{k+2} \geq 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)$, i.e. $\widehat{C}D(\Omega) \leq \frac{1}{2}b_{k+2}$. Feeding this into (94),

$$b_{k+2} \leq \widehat{C}D(\Omega) + \widehat{C}b_k^{1+1/n} \leq \frac{1}{2}b_{k+2} + \widehat{C}b_k^{1+1/n},$$

and absorbing $\frac{1}{2}b_{k+2}$ on the left,

$$(97) \quad b_{k+2} \leq 2\widehat{C}b_k^{1+1/n} \quad \text{whenever } k + 2 \leq K.$$

Smallness from the seed. By Step 0, $b_1 \leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{1/4} \leq (C_\dagger \delta(n))^{1/4}$. Choose $\delta(n)$ small enough that

$$(98) \quad b_1 \leq (C_\dagger \delta(n))^{1/4} \leq (2\widehat{C})^{-2n} =: \eta_n \in (0, 1).$$

Then $2\widehat{C}b_k^{1/(2n)} \leq 2\widehat{C}\eta_n^{1/(2n)} = 1$ for all $k \geq 1$ (as $b_k \leq b_1 \leq \eta_n$), so (97) self-improves to

$$(99) \quad b_{k+2} = (2\widehat{C}b_k^{1/(2n)})b_k^{1+1/(2n)} \leq b_k^{1+1/(2n)} \quad \text{whenever } k + 2 \leq K.$$

Iterating along odd indices. Apply (99) repeatedly, starting from $k = 1$, as long as the index stays $\leq K$. Writing the odd indices $1, 3, 5, \dots$ and setting $\gamma := 1 + \frac{1}{2n} > 1$, induction gives, for every $j \geq 0$ with $2j + 1 \leq K$,

$$(100) \quad b_{2j+1} \leq b_1^{\gamma^j}.$$

Indeed (100) holds at $j = 0$, and if it holds at j with $2(j + 1) + 1 = 2j + 3 \leq K$, then (99) (at $k = 2j + 1$, legitimate since $2j + 3 \leq K$) gives $b_{2j+3} \leq b_{2j+1}^\gamma \leq (b_1^{\gamma^j})^\gamma = b_1^{\gamma^{j+1}}$.

Bounding K . Let $j_K := \lfloor (K - 1)/2 \rfloor$, the largest j with $2j + 1 \leq K$. By the maximality of K and (100),

$$(101) \quad 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega) \leq b_{2j_K+1} \leq b_1^{\gamma^{j_K}} \leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{\gamma^{j_K/4}},$$

using $b_1 \leq (C_\dagger D(\Omega))^{1/4}$. Take logarithms (recall $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n) < 1$, so $\log D(\Omega) < 0$); writing $L := -\log D(\Omega) > 0$, (101) reads

$$\log(2\widehat{C}) - L \leq \frac{\gamma^{j_K}}{4}(\log C_\dagger - L).$$

For $\delta(n)$ small, $L = -\log D(\Omega) \geq -\log \delta(n)$ is large; in particular we may take $\delta(n)$ small enough that $L \geq 2 \max\{|\log(2\widehat{C})|, |\log C_\dagger|\}$, whence $\log(2\widehat{C}) - L \geq -\frac{3}{2}L$ and $\log C_\dagger - L \leq -\frac{1}{2}L$.

The displayed inequality then forces $-\frac{3}{2}L \leq -\frac{\gamma^{j_K}}{8}L$, i.e. $\gamma^{j_K} \leq 12$. Since $\gamma = 1 + \frac{1}{2n} > 1$ this bounds $j_K \leq \log 12 / \log \gamma =: j_*(n)$, hence $K \leq 2j_K + 2 \leq 2j_*(n) + 2 =: K(n)$, a dimensional constant. This proves (96).

Step 4: tail at the stopping radius. By the maximality (95), $b_{K+1} < 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)$; we record this for the next step.

Step 5: the truncated set and its volume. By the definition (95) of K and $K \leq K(n)$, $b_{K+1} < 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)$, hence

$$(102) \quad |\Omega \setminus B_{K+1}| = \omega_n b_{K+1} < 2\widehat{C}\omega_n D(\Omega).$$

In fact we cut one radius further out to have room for the cut-off: by monotonicity $b_{K+3} \leq b_{K+1} < 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)$, so

$$(103) \quad |\Omega \cap B_{K+3}| = \omega_n(1 - b_{K+3}) \geq \omega_n(1 - 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)), \quad |\Omega \setminus B_{K+3}| < 2\widehat{C}\omega_n D(\Omega).$$

Define

$$r := \left(\frac{|\Omega \cap B_{K+3}|}{\omega_n} \right)^{1/n} = (1 - b_{K+3})^{1/n} \in [(1 - 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega))^{1/n}, 1], \quad \widetilde{\Omega} := r^{-1}(\Omega \cap B_{K+3}).$$

Then $|\widetilde{\Omega}| = r^{-n} |\Omega \cap B_{K+3}| = \omega_n$, which is (84). Since $\Omega \cap B_{K+3} \subset B_{K+3}$ and $r \geq (1 - 2\widehat{C}\delta(n))^{1/n} \geq \frac{1}{2}$ for $\delta(n)$ small,

$$\text{diam}(\widetilde{\Omega}) = r^{-1} \text{diam}(\Omega \cap B_{K+3}) \leq r^{-1} \cdot 2(K+3) \leq 4(K(n)+3) =: d(n),$$

giving (85). We record for later the linearised bound

$$(104) \quad 0 \leq 1 - r^n = b_{K+3} < 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega), \quad 0 \leq 1 - r \leq 1 - r^n < 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega),$$

the middle inequality because $r \leq 1$ implies $1 - r \leq 1 - r^n$.

Step 6: deficit of the surrogate. Apply the energy comparison (92) at $k = K+1$ (so the cut radius is $k+2 = K+3$):

$$E(\Omega \cap B_{K+3}) \leq E(\Omega) + C b_{K+1}^{1+1/n} \leq E(\Omega) + C (2\widehat{C}D(\Omega))^{1+1/n} \leq E(\Omega) + C' D(\Omega),$$

where in the last step we used $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n) \leq 1$ so that $D(\Omega)^{1+1/n} \leq D(\Omega)$, and absorbed constants into $C' = C'(n)$. Since E scales as $E(t\Omega') = t^{n+2}E(\Omega')$ and $\widetilde{\Omega} = r^{-1}(\Omega \cap B_{K+3})$,

$$E(\widetilde{\Omega}) = r^{-(n+2)} E(\Omega \cap B_{K+3}) \leq r^{-(n+2)} (E(\Omega) + C' D(\Omega)).$$

Because $|\widetilde{\Omega}| = \omega_n$, $D(\widetilde{\Omega}) = \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} (E(\widetilde{\Omega}) - E(B_1))$. Using $E(\Omega) = E(B_1) + \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega)$ and $r \leq 1$ (so $r^{-(n+2)} \geq 1$), with $E(B_1) < 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} E(\widetilde{\Omega}) - E(B_1) &\leq r^{-(n+2)} (E(B_1) + \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega) + C' D(\Omega)) - E(B_1) \\ &= (r^{-(n+2)} - 1) E(B_1) + r^{-(n+2)} (\omega_n^{(n+2)/n} + C') D(\Omega). \end{aligned}$$

For the first term, $r^{-(n+2)} - 1 \geq 0$ and $E(B_1) < 0$, so $(r^{-(n+2)} - 1) E(B_1) \leq 0$ and we may bound it by $(r^{-(n+2)} - 1) |E(B_1)|$. Quantitatively, by (104), $r^n \geq 1 - 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega)$, so $r^{-(n+2)} = r^{-n} \cdot r^{-2} \leq (1 - 2\widehat{C}D(\Omega))^{-(n+2)/n} \leq 1 + C'' D(\Omega)$ for $\delta(n)$ small (Bernoulli/Taylor bound, since $2\widehat{C}D(\Omega) \leq 2\widehat{C}\delta(n) \leq \frac{1}{2}$). Hence $r^{-(n+2)} - 1 \leq C'' D(\Omega)$ and $r^{-(n+2)} \leq 1 + C'' D(\Omega) \leq 2$, giving

$$E(\widetilde{\Omega}) - E(B_1) \leq C'' D(\Omega) \cdot |E(B_1)| + 2(\omega_n^{(n+2)/n} + C') D(\Omega) \leq C'_2 D(\Omega),$$

with $C'_2 = C'_2(n)$. Dividing by $\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}$,

$$(105) \quad D(\widetilde{\Omega}) = \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} (E(\widetilde{\Omega}) - E(B_1)) \leq \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} C'_2 D(\Omega) =: C_3 D(\Omega),$$

which is (86) with $C_3 = C_3(n)$.

Step 7: asymmetry loss. Let $B_1(x_0)$ realise the asymmetry of $\widetilde{\Omega}$, so $\mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega}) = |\widetilde{\Omega} \triangle B_1(x_0)| / \omega_n$. We compare the asymmetry of Ω to that of $\widetilde{\Omega}$ through the chain of inclusions relating Ω , $\Omega \cap B_{K+3}$ and $\widetilde{\Omega} = r^{-1}(\Omega \cap B_{K+3})$. For any test ball $B_1(y)$,

$$|\Omega \triangle B_1(y)| \leq |\Omega \triangle (\Omega \cap B_{K+3})| + |(\Omega \cap B_{K+3}) \triangle B_1(y)|.$$

The first term is $|\Omega \setminus B_{K+3}| < 2\widehat{C}\omega_n D(\Omega)$ by (103). For the second, scale by r : writing $E_r := \Omega \cap B_{K+3} = r\widetilde{\Omega}$ and $B_1(y) = r B_{1/r}(y/r)$,

$$|(r\widetilde{\Omega}) \triangle (r B_{1/r}(y/r))| = r^n |\widetilde{\Omega} \triangle B_{1/r}(y/r)| \leq r^n \left(|\widetilde{\Omega} \triangle B_1(y/r)| + |B_1(y/r) \triangle B_{1/r}(y/r)| \right).$$

The last term is the volume difference of concentric balls of radii 1 and $1/r \geq 1$: $|B_1 \triangle B_{1/r}| = \omega_n(r^{-n} - 1)$. Hence

$$r^n |B_1(y/r) \triangle B_{1/r}(y/r)| = r^n \omega_n(r^{-n} - 1) = \omega_n(1 - r^n) < 2\widehat{C} \omega_n D(\Omega),$$

using (104). Choosing $y := rx_0$ so that $y/r = x_0$ is the optimal centre for $\widetilde{\Omega}$, the middle term becomes $r^n |\widetilde{\Omega} \triangle B_1(x_0)| = r^n \omega_n \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega}) \leq \omega_n \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega})$ (as $r \leq 1$). Collecting,

$$|\Omega \triangle B_1(rx_0)| \leq 2\widehat{C} \omega_n D(\Omega) + \omega_n \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega}) + 2\widehat{C} \omega_n D(\Omega),$$

and dividing by ω_n and taking the infimum over translates (which only decreases the left side),

$$(106) \quad \mathcal{A}(\Omega) \leq \frac{|\Omega \triangle B_1(rx_0)|}{\omega_n} \leq \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega}) + 4\widehat{C} D(\Omega).$$

This is (87) with the constant $4\widehat{C}$. Taking $C_\# := \max\{C_3, 4\widehat{C}\} = C_\#(n)$ proves (86)–(87) simultaneously, and we already have (84)–(85). This completes the proof. $\square$

Remark 10.10 (Translation into a fixed ball). The diameter bound (85) is translation invariant, so after a translation we may assume $\widetilde{\Omega} \subset B_{d(n)}$. Both $\mathcal{A}$ and D are translation invariant, so (84)–(87) are preserved.

10.6. The far branch. When the deficit is not small the inequality is trivial: the asymmetry is bounded ($\mathcal{A} < 2$) while the deficit is bounded below, so a quadratic bound holds with a crude constant. No truncation is needed.

Lemma 10.11 (Large-deficit quadratic bound). *For every open Ω with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and $D(\Omega) \geq \delta(n)/4$,*

$$(107) \quad E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} \frac{\delta(n)}{16} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2.$$

Proof. Since $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ gives $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) < 2$, we have $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2/4 < 1$. Hence

$$D(\Omega) \geq \frac{\delta(n)}{4} = \frac{\delta(n)}{4} \cdot 1 \geq \frac{\delta(n)}{4} \cdot \frac{\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2}{4} = \frac{\delta(n)}{16} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2.$$

Multiplying by $\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}$ and using $E(\Omega) - E(B_1) = \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega)$ gives (107). $\square$

10.7. The near branch. Fix the dimensional working radius

$$(108) \quad R_*(n) := \max\{d(n), 2\},$$

so $R_* \geq d(n)$ (the surrogates of Lemma 10.9 lie in B_{R_*} after translation, by Remark 10.10) and $R_* \geq 2$ (the hypothesis of Theorem 10.1).

Lemma 10.12 (Small-deficit transfer). *Set*

$$(109) \quad \widetilde{c}_{\text{SV}}(n) := \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} c_{\text{SV}}(n, R_*(n)) > 0.$$

For every open Ω with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)$,

$$(110) \quad \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq \left(\frac{4C_\#(n)}{\widetilde{c}_{\text{SV}}(n)} + 4C_\#(n)^2 \right) D(\Omega).$$

Proof. Apply Lemma 10.9 to get $\widetilde{\Omega}$ satisfying (84)–(87); by Remark 10.10 assume $\widetilde{\Omega} \subset B_{d(n)} \subset B_{R_*(n)}$. Theorem 10.1 at $R = R_*(n)$ gives $E(\widetilde{\Omega}) - E(B_1) \geq c_{\text{SV}}(n, R_*) \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega})^2$; dividing by $\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}$ and using $|\widetilde{\Omega}| = \omega_n$,

$$(111) \quad D(\widetilde{\Omega}) \geq \widetilde{c}_{\text{SV}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\widetilde{\Omega})^2.$$

Combining (111) with (86),

$$\mathcal{A}(\tilde{\Omega})^2 \leq \frac{D(\tilde{\Omega})}{\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}}} \leq \frac{C_{\sharp}}{\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}}} D(\Omega).$$

Now use (87), the elementary $(a+b)^2 \leq 2a^2 + 2b^2$, and $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n) \leq 1$ (so $D(\Omega)^2 \leq D(\Omega)$):

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 &\leq (\mathcal{A}(\tilde{\Omega}) + C_{\sharp} D(\Omega))^2 \leq 2\mathcal{A}(\tilde{\Omega})^2 + 2C_{\sharp}^2 D(\Omega)^2 \\ &\leq \frac{2C_{\sharp}}{\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}}} D(\Omega) + 2C_{\sharp}^2 D(\Omega) \leq \left(\frac{4C_{\sharp}}{\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}}} + 4C_{\sharp}^2 \right) D(\Omega), \end{aligned}$$

which is (110). $\square$

Corollary 10.13 (Small-deficit quadratic bound). *With*

$$(112) \quad c_{\text{near}}(n) := \frac{\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}}{4C_{\sharp}(n)(1/\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}}(n) + C_{\sharp}(n))} > 0,$$

every open Ω with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$ and $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)$ satisfies $E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq c_{\text{near}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$.

Proof. Rearrange (110) to $D(\Omega) \geq \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 / (4C_{\sharp}/\tilde{c}_{\text{SV}} + 4C_{\sharp}^2)$ and multiply by $\omega_n^{(n+2)/n}$, using $E(\Omega) - E(B_1) = \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} D(\Omega)$. $\square$

10.8. Proof of the global theorem. We now glue the far and near branches, then remove the volume normalisation.

Proof of Theorem 10.2. Set

$$(113) \quad c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) := \min \left\{ c_{\text{near}}(n), \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} \frac{\delta(n)}{16} \right\} > 0.$$

Let Ω be open with $|\Omega| = \omega_n$.

Case A: $D(\Omega) \geq \delta(n)/4$. Lemma 10.11 gives $E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq \omega_n^{(n+2)/n} (\delta(n)/16) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \geq c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$.

Case B: $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)$ (which includes $D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)/4$). Corollary 10.13 gives $E(\Omega) - E(B_1) \geq c_{\text{near}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \geq c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$.

The two cases overlap on $\delta(n)/4 \leq D(\Omega) \leq \delta(n)$ and together cover $[0, \infty)$; in either case (62) holds with $c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n)$ as in (113), a dimensional constant because $\delta(n)$, $c_{\text{near}}(n)$ depend only on n (recall $R_*(n)$ and hence $c_{\text{SV}}(n, R_*(n))$ are dimensional).

General volume. For arbitrary finite-measure Ω put $\Omega_* := (\omega_n/|\Omega|)^{1/n} \Omega$, so $|\Omega_*| = \omega_n$, $\mathcal{A}(\Omega_*) = \mathcal{A}(\Omega)$ and $D(\Omega_*) = D(\Omega)$ by scale invariance of $\mathcal{A}$ and D . Applying (62) to Ω_* reads $D(\Omega) \geq \omega_n^{-(n+2)/n} c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$. Multiplying by $|\Omega|^{(n+2)/n}$ and using $E(\Omega) |\Omega|^{-(n+2)/n} = E(B^*) |B^*|^{-(n+2)/n} = D(\Omega)$ with $|B^*| = |\Omega|$, then $E = -T/2$, gives

$$T(B^*) - T(\Omega) = 2(E(\Omega) - E(B^*)) \geq 2c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n} \right)^{(n+2)/n} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2,$$

which is (63). $\square$

Remark 10.14 (Sharpness of the exponent). The exponent 2 on $\mathcal{A}$ in (62) is optimal: it is saturated by smooth, volume-preserving ellipsoidal perturbations of B_1 , for which both $E(\Omega) - E(B_1)$ and $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$ are of the same quadratic order in the perturbation parameter.

11. THE KOHLER–JOBIN INEQUALITY AND THE TRANSFER TO FABER–KRAHN

This section is logically self-contained. In Part 1 we reconstruct from scratch, by the Kohler–Jobin rearrangement technique, the spectral shape inequality

$$T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^{(n+2)/2} \geq T(B) \lambda_1(B)^{(n+2)/2} \quad (B \text{ any ball}),$$

with equality only for balls. In Part 2 we feed this inequality, together with the global sharp Saint–Venant stability estimate proved elsewhere in the manuscript, into a short and fully explicit computation that yields sharp quantitative Faber–Krahn stability, $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) \geq c_{\text{FK}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$.

The technique, due to Kohler–Jobin [8, 9, 10], is a spherical rearrangement that, unlike Schwarz symmetrisation, preserves not the *volume* of the superlevel sets but a *torsional* functional of them. We follow the modern exposition of Brasco [4, §§3–5, Thm. 1.1], specialised throughout to the linear case (the Laplacian, $p = 2$, and the Dirichlet energy quotient).

The section is written for a reader meeting the argument for the first time: each displayed inference is accompanied by a short justification naming the identity, inequality, or theorem invoked and noting why its hypotheses are met, and the central computations – the radial-gradient expansion in Lemma 11.6, the closed form of T_{mod} , the convexity chain in Lemma 11.7, the Rayleigh assembly, and the one-variable inequality of Part 2 – are carried out in full, with every constant tracked.

11.1. Notation and scaling conventions. Throughout, $n \geq 2$ and $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ is open with finite measure. We use:

- $u_\Omega \in H_0^1(\Omega)$, the *torsion function*, the unique weak solution of $-\Delta u_\Omega = 1$ in Ω , $u_\Omega = 0$ on $\partial\Omega$;
- $T(\Omega) = \int_\Omega u_\Omega \, dx$, the *torsional rigidity*, and $E(\Omega) = -T(\Omega)/2$;
- $\lambda_1(\Omega)$, the first Dirichlet eigenvalue,

$$(114) \quad \lambda_1(\Omega) = \min_{0 \neq v \in H_0^1(\Omega)} \frac{\int_\Omega |\nabla v|^2 \, dx}{\int_\Omega v^2 \, dx},$$

attained by a first eigenfunction $u > 0$ solving $-\Delta u = \lambda_1(\Omega)u$;

- B^* , the ball centred at 0 with $|B^*| = |\Omega|$; B_r the open ball of radius r centred at 0; B_1 the unit ball; $\omega_n = |B_1|$;
- $L_n = \lambda_1(B_1) = j_{n/2-1,1}^2$ and $T_n = T(B_1) = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$;
- $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) = \inf_{x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^n} |\Omega \triangle (x_0 + B^*)| / |B^*| \in [0, 2)$, the Fraenkel asymmetry;
- $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) = (|\Omega|/\omega_n)^{2/n} (\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*))$, the scale-invariant Faber–Krahn deficit.

Justification of the listed identities. We verify the two facts about balls that the conventions assert, since the whole argument is calibrated against them.

The torsion function of a ball. On B_r put $v(x) = (r^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$. Then $v \in C^\infty(\overline{B_r})$, $v = 0$ on $\{|x| = r\} = \partial B_r$, and, writing $|x|^2 = \sum_i x_i^2$,

$$\Delta v = \frac{1}{2n} \Delta(r^2 - |x|^2) = \frac{1}{2n} (-\Delta |x|^2) = \frac{1}{2n} (-2n) = -1,$$

because $\Delta |x|^2 = \sum_i \partial_{x_i x_i}^2 (\sum_j x_j^2) = \sum_i 2 = 2n$. Thus $-\Delta v = 1$ in B_r with $v = 0$ on ∂B_r , so by uniqueness of the weak solution $u_{B_r} = v$. This justifies the formula $u_{B_r}(x) = (r^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$.

The torsional rigidity of a ball. Integrating u_{B_r} in polar coordinates (writing $\sigma_{n-1} = \mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\partial B_1) = n\omega_n$ for the surface area of the unit sphere, the standard relation between the volume and surface

measure of the unit ball),

$$T(B_r) = \int_{B_r} \frac{r^2 - |x|^2}{2n} dx = \frac{1}{2n} \int_0^r \frac{(r^2 - \rho^2)}{1} \sigma_{n-1} \rho^{n-1} d\rho = \frac{\sigma_{n-1}}{2n} \left[\frac{r^2 \rho^n}{n} - \frac{\rho^{n+2}}{n+2} \right]_0^r.$$

The bracket at $\rho = r$ equals $r^{n+2} \left(\frac{1}{n} - \frac{1}{n+2} \right) = r^{n+2} \cdot \frac{2}{n(n+2)}$, so with $\sigma_{n-1} = n\omega_n$,

$$(115) \quad T(B_r) = \frac{n\omega_n}{2n} \cdot \frac{2}{n(n+2)} r^{n+2} = \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} r^{n+2} = T_n r^{n+2}.$$

The last equality is the definition $T_n = T(B_1) = \omega_n / (n(n+2))$, recovered by setting $r = 1$. This is exactly the constant whose value will make the leading constant in Lemma 11.6 collapse to 1.

Scaling. If $t > 0$ and $w_t(x) := t^2 u_\Omega(x/t)$ on $t\Omega$, then $-\Delta w_t(x) = t^2 \cdot t^{-2} (-\Delta u_\Omega)(x/t) = 1$ and $w_t = 0$ on $\partial(t\Omega)$, so $u_{t\Omega} = w_t$ by uniqueness, and the change of variables $x = ty$ gives $T(t\Omega) = \int_{t\Omega} w_t dx = \int_\Omega t^2 u_\Omega(y) t^n dy = t^{n+2} T(\Omega)$. Likewise, if u realises the minimum in (114) on Ω , then $x \mapsto u(x/t)$ is admissible on $t\Omega$ and the Rayleigh quotient scales by t^{-2} (gradients carry an extra t^{-2} relative to values, and the Jacobian t^n cancels between numerator and denominator), whence $\lambda_1(t\Omega) = t^{-2} \lambda_1(\Omega)$. Therefore the combination

$$(116) \quad \Psi(\Omega) := T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^{(n+2)/2}$$

satisfies $\Psi(t\Omega) = t^{n+2} t^{-2 \cdot (n+2)/2} \Psi(\Omega) = t^{n+2} t^{-(n+2)} \Psi(\Omega) = \Psi(\Omega)$: it is scale invariant. In particular every ball B_r is a dilate of B_1 , so $\Psi(B_r) = \Psi(B_1) = T_n L_n^{(n+2)/2}$ for every ball. We abbreviate $\beta := (n+2)/2$; with this notation $\Psi = T \lambda_1^\beta$.

11.2. Part 1: the Kohler–Jobin inequality, proved from scratch.

Theorem 11.1 (Kohler–Jobin). *For every open $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ of finite measure with $\lambda_1(\Omega) < \infty$ and every ball $B \subset \mathbb{R}^n$,*

$$(117) \quad T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta \geq T(B) \lambda_1(B)^\beta, \quad \beta = \frac{n+2}{2}.$$

Equivalently $\Psi(\Omega) \geq \Psi(B_1) = T_n L_n^\beta$, with equality if and only if Ω is a ball (up to translation and a Lebesgue-null modification).

Strategy. Both sides of (117) have the same scaling and $\Psi(B) = \Psi(B_1)$ for every ball; so it suffices to compare Ω with a single, well-chosen ball. The idea is to rearrange the first eigenfunction u of Ω into a radial decreasing function u^* on a ball B in such a way that

- (A) the Dirichlet energy is *exactly preserved*, $\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 = \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2$, and
- (B) the L^2 norm *does not decrease*, $\int_B (u^*)^2 \geq \int_\Omega u^2$.

Granting (A)–(B), the Rayleigh principle (114) on B gives

$$(118) \quad \lambda_1(B) \leq \frac{\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2}{\int_B (u^*)^2} \leq \frac{\int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2}{\int_\Omega u^2} = \lambda_1(\Omega),$$

the last equality because u is the first eigenfunction of Ω .

Reading the chain (118). The first inequality is the variational characterisation (114) applied on B to the admissible competitor $u^* \in H_0^1(B)$: the minimum is no larger than the quotient at any one competitor. The second inequality replaces the numerator by an equal quantity (property (A), equality) and the denominator by a smaller-or-equal one (property (B), $\int_B (u^*)^2 \geq \int_\Omega u^2$): increasing the denominator of a positive fraction decreases it, so the quotient over B is $\leq$ the quotient over Ω . The final equality is the definition of u as a minimiser of (114) on Ω , so its Rayleigh quotient equals $\lambda_1(\Omega)$. Hence $\lambda_1(B) \leq \lambda_1(\Omega)$.

The decisive design choice is which geometric quantity of the superlevel sets the ball B is built to match. Schwarz symmetrisation matches *volume* and yields the Faber–Krahn inequality directly; the Kohler–Jobin rearrangement instead matches a *torsional functional*, the *modified torsional rigidity* introduced next, and this is exactly what allows the Dirichlet energy to be preserved (not merely decreased) while the L^2 norm grows. The relation $\lambda_1(B) \leq \lambda_1(\Omega)$ at equal *torsion* of B and Ω is then the inequality (117), as the assembly at the end of Part 1 makes precise.

Standing regularity facts (cited, not proved).

- (R1) (*Regularity of the eigenfunction.*) The first eigenfunction u of Ω may be taken positive, solves $-\Delta u = \lambda u$ in Ω with $\lambda = \lambda_1(\Omega)$, and satisfies $u \in L^\infty(\Omega)$ (Moser iteration) and $u \in C^\infty(\Omega)$ in the interior: indeed $-\Delta u = \lambda u$ with $u \in L^\infty$ gives $u \in C_{\text{loc}}^{1,\alpha}$ by Schauder, and bootstrapping the equation gives $u \in C^\infty(\Omega)$ ([4, Prop. 2.4], [13]). In particular Sard’s theorem applies to u in the interior, so a.e. $t \in (0, M)$ is a regular value. Put $M := \|u\|_{L^\infty(\Omega)} < \infty$.

Why this is enough. Positivity is the Krein–Rutman/maximum-principle fact that the first eigenfunction has a sign; we fix the sign $u > 0$. The interior smoothness lets us apply, for a.e. level t , the divergence theorem on $\{u > t\}$ (whose boundary $\{u = t\}$ is then a smooth hypersurface, by the implicit function theorem at points where $\nabla u \neq 0$, which is a.e. on a regular level set). Sard guarantees a.e. level is regular, so all level-set statements below (“for a.e. t ”) are legitimate.

- (R2) (*Coarea formula.*) For $u \in W_{\text{loc}}^{1,1}$ and Borel $g \geq 0$, $\int_\Omega g |\nabla u| \, dx = \int_0^M \left(\int_{\{u=t\}} g \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) dt$ (Federer; see Maggi, *Sets of Finite Perimeter*, Thm. 13.1). Taking $g = \mathbf{1}_\Omega h(u)/|\nabla u|$ on $\{\nabla u \neq 0\}$ converts a bulk integral of $h(u)$ weighted by $|\nabla u|^{-1}$ into a level integral, which is the mechanism behind all the “Cavalieri+coarea” computations to follow.
- (R3) (*Saint–Venant inequality.*) For any open bounded $A \subset \mathbb{R}^n$, $T(A) \leq T(A^\#)$ where $A^\#$ is the ball with $|A^\#| = |A|$; in the scale-free form we use it,

$$(119) \quad T(A) \leq T_n \left(\frac{|A|}{\omega_n} \right)^{(n+2)/n},$$

with equality iff A is a ball. ([4, (1.7) with $p = 2$].) The exponent is dictated by scaling: from $T(A^\#) = T_n(|A^\#|/\omega_n \cdot \omega_n/\omega_n) \cdots$, more directly $T(A^\#) = T_n R^{n+2}$ with $|A^\#| = \omega_n R^n$, i.e. $R = (|A|/\omega_n)^{1/n}$ and $T(A^\#) = T_n(|A|/\omega_n)^{(n+2)/n}$, which is (119).

- (R4) (*Distribution function.*) The distribution function $\mu_u(t) := |\{u > t\}|$ is non-increasing; together with the coarea formula this gives, for a.e. regular value t , that $\int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u|^{-1} \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ is finite and $\mu'_u(t) = - \int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u|^{-1} \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$ (Brothers–Ziemer). Thus μ_u is locally absolutely continuous on the set of regular values, the fact we need to differentiate under the integral and to integrate by the change of variables $t = \varphi(\tau)$.

Two preliminary identities. We record the variational form of T and the level-set flux identity for the eigenfunction; both are elementary. The first says torsion is the maximum of a concave energy and will let us define a *constrained torsion* (the modified torsion) by maximising the same energy over a smaller class. The second computes, for the eigenfunction, the boundary flux through each level set in closed form; it is what verifies the integrability condition that makes the modified torsion finite.

Lemma 11.2 (Variational torsion and the eigenfunction flux).

(i) For open A of finite measure, with $F(w) := \int_A w \, dx - \frac{1}{2} \int_A |\nabla w|^2 \, dx$,

$$(120) \quad T(A) = 2 \max_{w \in H_0^1(A)} F(w),$$

the maximiser being the torsion function u_A ; equivalently $T(A) = \max\{(\int_A w)^2 / \int_A |\nabla w|^2 : 0 \neq w \in H_0^1(A)\}$.

(ii) The first eigenfunction u satisfies, for a.e. $t \in (0, M)$,

$$(121) \quad \int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u \, dx.$$

Proof. (i): The functional F is strictly concave on $H_0^1(A)$ because $w \mapsto \frac{1}{2} \int |\nabla w|^2$ is strictly convex (its Hessian is the positive-definite Dirichlet form $\int \nabla \cdot \nabla$) while $w \mapsto \int w$ is linear; and F is coercive because, by the Poincaré inequality on the finite-measure set A , $\int_A w \leq |A|^{1/2} (\int_A w^2)^{1/2} \leq C(A) (\int_A |\nabla w|^2)^{1/2}$, so the quadratic term dominates the linear one as $\|\nabla w\|_2 \rightarrow \infty$. A strictly concave coercive functional on a Hilbert space has a unique maximiser, characterised by its Euler–Lagrange equation. Computing the first variation, for $\phi \in H_0^1(A)$,

$$\left. \frac{d}{d\varepsilon} \right|_{\varepsilon=0} F(w + \varepsilon\phi) = \int_A \phi \, dx - \int_A \nabla w \cdot \nabla \phi \, dx = 0 \iff -\Delta w = 1 \text{ weakly},$$

so the maximiser is the torsion function u_A . Testing $-\Delta u_A = 1$ against $u_A \in H_0^1(A)$ itself gives the key normalisation

$$(122) \quad \int_A |\nabla u_A|^2 \, dx = \int_A u_A \, dx = T(A).$$

Substituting (122) into F ,

$$F(u_A) = \int_A u_A \, dx - \frac{1}{2} \int_A |\nabla u_A|^2 \, dx = T(A) - \frac{1}{2} T(A) = \frac{1}{2} T(A),$$

which is (120) after multiplying by 2. For the second (quotient) form: for $0 \neq w \in H_0^1(A)$ and $c > 0$, $F(cw) = c \int_A w - \frac{c^2}{2} \int_A |\nabla w|^2$ is a downward parabola in c , maximised at $c_\star = \int_A w / \int_A |\nabla w|^2$ with value $F(c_\star w) = \frac{1}{2} (\int_A w)^2 / \int_A |\nabla w|^2$; taking the supremum over directions w and using (120) gives $T(A) = \max\{(\int_A w)^2 / \int_A |\nabla w|^2\}$. This is the standard Rayleigh-type characterisation of T ([4, Prop. 2.2] with $p = 2$).

(ii): Fix a regular value t , so that $\{u > t\}$ is open with smooth boundary $\{u = t\}$ on which $\nabla u \neq 0$. On $\{u = t\}$ the function u decreases outward (we cross from $\{u > t\}$ to $\{u < t\}$), so the outward unit normal to $\{u > t\}$ is $\nu = -\nabla u / |\nabla u|$, whence the normal derivative is

$$\partial_\nu u = \nabla u \cdot \nu = \nabla u \cdot \left(-\frac{\nabla u}{|\nabla u|} \right) = -\frac{|\nabla u|^2}{|\nabla u|} = -|\nabla u|.$$

Integrate the equation $-\Delta u = \lambda u$ over $\{u > t\}$ and apply the divergence theorem to the vector field ∇u :

$$\lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u \, dx = \int_{\{u>t\}} (-\Delta u) \, dx = - \int_{\{u=t\}} \partial_\nu u \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| \, d\mathcal{H}^{n-1},$$

the middle equality being $\int_{\{u>t\}} \Delta u = \int_{\partial\{u>t\}} \partial_\nu u$ (Gauss–Green), and the last equality using $\partial_\nu u = -|\nabla u|$. Rearranged, this is (121). $\square$

The modified torsional rigidity. The engine of the technique is the following functional, which assigns to a nonnegative function a torsion-type quantity that is sensitive to the *level structure* of the function, not just to its domain. Concretely, ordinary torsion (120) maximises F over *all*

of $H_0^1(\Omega)$; the modified torsion maximises F only over functions of the form $g \circ u$, i.e. functions constant on the level sets of u . This constraint is exactly what carries the level structure of u into the functional, and it is what the rearrangement will match between Ω and the ball.

Definition 11.3 (Modified torsional rigidity). Let $u \in H_0^1(\Omega) \cap L^\infty(\Omega)$, $u \geq 0$, $M = \|u\|_\infty$, with distribution function $\mu(t) = |\{u > t\}|$. Assume the integrability condition

$$(123) \quad t \mapsto \frac{\mu(t)}{\int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}} \in L^\infty(0, M)$$

For the first eigenfunction this holds: by (121) the ratio in (123) equals $\mu(t)/(\lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u)$. On $[M/2, M)$ the bound $\int_{\{u>t\}} u \geq t \mu(t)$ gives ratio $\leq 1/(\lambda t) \leq 2/(\lambda M)$; on $(0, M/2]$ the monotonicity $\int_{\{u>t\}} u \geq \int_{\{u>M/2\}} u > 0$ together with $\mu(t) \leq |\Omega|$ gives ratio $\leq |\Omega|/(\lambda \int_{\{u>M/2\}} u)$. Hence the ratio is bounded on $(0, M)$ (cf. [4, Lem. 3.2]). With $\mathcal{L} := \{g \in \text{Lip}([0, M]) : g(0) = 0\}$, define the *modified torsional rigidity of Ω along u*

$$(124) \quad T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) := 2 \sup_{g \in \mathcal{L}} F(g \circ u), \quad F(w) = \int_{\Omega} w dx - \frac{1}{2} \int_{\Omega} |\nabla w|^2 dx.$$

Unpacking the verification of (123). Substituting the flux identity (121), $\int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u$, into the denominator turns the ratio in (123) into $\mu(t)/(\lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u dx)$. We bound this on two ranges of t :

- For $t \in [M/2, M)$: since $u > t$ on $\{u > t\}$, we have $\int_{\{u>t\}} u dx \geq t |\{u > t\}| = t \mu(t)$, so

$$\frac{\mu(t)}{\lambda \int_{\{u>t\}} u} \leq \frac{\mu(t)}{\lambda t \mu(t)} = \frac{1}{\lambda t} \leq \frac{1}{\lambda (M/2)} = \frac{2}{\lambda M},$$

using $t \geq M/2$ in the last step (and $\mu(t) > 0$ for $t < M$, so the cancellation is legitimate).

- For $t \in (0, M/2]$: the numerator is bounded by $\mu(t) \leq |\Omega|$ (monotonicity of μ and $\mu \leq |\Omega|$), while the denominator integral is non-increasing in t (its domain $\{u > t\}$ shrinks as t grows), so for $t \leq M/2$, $\int_{\{u>t\}} u \geq \int_{\{u>M/2\}} u > 0$ (positive because u is positive on the nonempty open set $\{u > M/2\}$). Hence the ratio is $\leq |\Omega|/(\lambda \int_{\{u>M/2\}} u)$, a finite constant.

Taking the larger of the two bounds shows the ratio lies in $L^\infty(0, M)$.

The pointwise bound $T_{\text{mod}} \leq T$. Since each competitor $g \circ u$ with $g \in \mathcal{L}$ lies in $H_0^1(\Omega)$ (a Lipschitz function of an H_0^1 function vanishing at 0 is again H_0^1 , by the chain rule for Lipschitz compositions), the class $\{g \circ u : g \in \mathcal{L}\}$ is a subset of $H_0^1(\Omega)$. Maximising F over a smaller set cannot exceed the maximum over the whole space, so by (120),

$$(125) \quad T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) = 2 \sup_{g \in \mathcal{L}} F(g \circ u) \leq 2 \max_{w \in H_0^1(\Omega)} F(w) = T(\Omega).$$

This inequality, used repeatedly below, is the single channel through which the Saint-Venant inequality (119) enters the argument.

Lemma 11.4 (Closed form of T_{mod}). *Under the hypotheses of Definition 11.3, writing $P(t) := \int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$, the supremum in (124) is uniquely attained by the nondecreasing g_0 with $g_0'(t) = \mu(t)/P(t)$, and*

$$(126) \quad T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) = \int_0^M \frac{\mu(t)^2}{P(t)} dt.$$

Proof. Reduction to nondecreasing g . Given $g \in \mathcal{L}$, set $\tilde{g}(t) := \int_0^t |g'(s)| ds$. Then $\tilde{g} \in \mathcal{L}$ (it is Lipschitz with $\tilde{g}(0) = 0$ and $\tilde{g}' = |g'|$ a.e.) and $\tilde{g}$ is nondecreasing. We compare $F(\tilde{g} \circ u)$ with $F(g \circ u)$:

- *Gradient term unchanged.* By the chain rule $\nabla(g \circ u) = g'(u)\nabla u$, so $|\nabla(g \circ u)|^2 = g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|^2$; similarly $|\nabla(\tilde{g} \circ u)|^2 = \tilde{g}'(u)^2 |\nabla u|^2 = |g'(u)|^2 |\nabla u|^2 = g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|^2$. The two gradient terms coincide pointwise, hence $\int_\Omega |\nabla(\tilde{g} \circ u)|^2 = \int_\Omega |\nabla(g \circ u)|^2$.
- *Linear term does not decrease.* For every t , $g(t) = \int_0^t g' \leq \int_0^t |g'| = \tilde{g}(t)$, so $\tilde{g} \geq g$ pointwise, and since $u \geq 0$, $\tilde{g}(u) \geq g(u)$, whence $\int_\Omega \tilde{g}(u) \geq \int_\Omega g(u)$.

Therefore $F(\tilde{g} \circ u) \geq F(g \circ u)$, and the supremum in (124) is unchanged if we restrict to nondecreasing $g \in \mathcal{L}$.

Reduction to a one-dimensional integral. Let $g \in \mathcal{L}$ be nondecreasing. Writing $g(t) = \int_0^t g'(s) ds$ and applying Cavalieri's principle (the layer-cake/Fubini identity $\int_\Omega h(u) dx = \int_0^M h'(t) \mu(t) dt$ valid for h with $h(0) = 0$, which is the integral against $-d\mu$ written via the distribution function),

$$\int_\Omega g(u) dx = \int_0^M g'(t) \mu(t) dt.$$

For the gradient term, the chain rule gives $|\nabla(g \circ u)|^2 = g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|^2 = g'(u) \cdot (g'(u) |\nabla u|) |\nabla u|$; applying the coarea formula (R2) with $h := g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|$ (so that $h |\nabla u|^{-1} = g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|$, matching the bulk integrand) – more directly, coarea with the Borel function $g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|$ slices the integral by level sets, on each of which $g'(u)^2 = g'(t)^2$ is constant:

$$\int_\Omega |\nabla(g \circ u)|^2 dx = \int_\Omega g'(u)^2 |\nabla u|^2 dx = \int_0^M g'(t)^2 \left(\int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) dt = \int_0^M g'(t)^2 P(t) dt.$$

(Here coarea is used in the form $\int_\Omega \Phi(u) |\nabla u| dx = \int_0^M \Phi(t) P(t) dt$ with $\Phi = g'(\cdot)^2$, taking $\Phi(u) |\nabla u| = g'(u)^2 |\nabla u| = |\nabla(g \circ u)|^2 / |\nabla u| \cdot |\nabla u|$, i.e. slicing $g'(u)^2$ against the factor $|\nabla u|$ that coarea supplies.) Hence

$$F(g \circ u) = \int_\Omega g(u) dx - \frac{1}{2} \int_\Omega |\nabla(g \circ u)|^2 dx = \int_0^M \left[g'(t) \mu(t) - \frac{1}{2} g'(t)^2 P(t) \right] dt.$$

Pointwise Young maximisation. The integrand depends on g only through the value $s := g'(t) \geq 0$ at each fixed t , through the quadratic $q_t(s) := s \mu(t) - \frac{1}{2} s^2 P(t)$. Since $P(t) > 0$ for a.e. regular t (the boundary flux of a nonconstant function), q_t is a downward parabola in s ; setting $q_t'(s) = \mu(t) - s P(t) = 0$ gives the unconstrained maximiser $s_\star = \mu(t)/P(t) \geq 0$ (which is admissible since it is nonnegative), with maximum value

$$\max_{s \geq 0} q_t(s) = q_t(s_\star) = \frac{\mu(t)}{P(t)} \cdot \mu(t) - \frac{1}{2} \frac{\mu(t)^2}{P(t)^2} P(t) = \frac{\mu(t)^2}{P(t)} - \frac{\mu(t)^2}{2P(t)} = \frac{\mu(t)^2}{2P(t)}.$$

Integrating the pointwise bound $q_t(g'(t)) \leq \max_{s \geq 0} q_t(s) = \mu(t)^2/(2P(t))$ over t ,

$$F(g \circ u) = \int_0^M q_t(g'(t)) dt \leq \int_0^M \frac{\mu(t)^2}{2P(t)} dt,$$

with equality if and only if $g'(t) = s_\star = \mu(t)/P(t)$ for a.e. t . By the integrability condition (123), the function $t \mapsto \mu(t)/P(t)$ is in $L^\infty(0, M)$, so $g_0(t) := \int_0^t \mu(s)/P(s) ds$ is Lipschitz with $g_0(0) = 0$, i.e. $g_0 \in \mathcal{L}$, and it attains the bound. Multiplying through by 2 (recall the factor 2 in (124)),

$$T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) = 2 \sup_{g \in \mathcal{L}} F(g \circ u) = 2 \int_0^M \frac{\mu(t)^2}{2P(t)} dt = \int_0^M \frac{\mu(t)^2}{P(t)} dt,$$

which is (126), attained uniquely (the parabola has a unique maximiser) by g_0 . $\square$

The next proposition is the isoperimetric statement that makes the rearrangement decrease the Rayleigh quotient. It is the only place where the Saint–Venant inequality enters: it converts the algebraic bound $T_{\text{mod}} \leq T$ into the *geometric* statement that the torsion-matched ball is smaller than Ω .

Proposition 11.5 (Isoperimetric inequality for T_{mod}). *Let $u \in H_0^1(\Omega) \cap L^\infty$, $u \geq 0$, satisfy (123). If $B \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ is a ball with $T(B) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u)$, then $|B| \leq |\Omega|$, with equality iff Ω is a ball and u is (a translate of) a radial function.*

Proof. By hypothesis $T(B) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u)$, and by (125) (the remark after Definition 11.3) $T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) \leq T(\Omega)$; chaining,

$$T(B) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) \leq T(\Omega).$$

The Saint–Venant inequality (119) bounds the right-hand side from above by the ball value at equal volume: $T(\Omega) \leq T_n(|\Omega|/\omega_n)^{(n+2)/n}$. The left-hand side is computed exactly by (115): writing $|B| = \omega_n R^n$ with R the radius of B , $T(B) = T_n R^{n+2} = T_n(|B|/\omega_n)^{(n+2)/n}$. Substituting,

$$T_n \left(\frac{|B|}{\omega_n} \right)^{(n+2)/n} = T(B) \leq T(\Omega) \leq T_n \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n} \right)^{(n+2)/n}.$$

Cancelling the positive constant T_n and the positive normalisation $\omega_n^{-(n+2)/n}$, and raising to the positive power $n/(n+2)$ (a strictly increasing operation on $[0, \infty)$),

$$|B| \leq |\Omega|.$$

Equality case. If $|B| = |\Omega|$, then both inequalities in the chain are equalities. Equality in the right inequality is equality in Saint–Venant (119), which by (R3) forces Ω to be a ball. Equality $T(B) = T(\Omega)$ together with $T(B) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) \leq T(\Omega)$ forces $T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) = T(\Omega)$; comparing (124) with (120), the constrained supremum equals the unconstrained maximum, so the maximiser $g_0 \circ u$ of the modified problem must coincide with the unconstrained maximiser, the torsion function u_Ω . On a ball u_Ω is radial (by (115), $u_{B_r}(x) = (r^2 - |x|^2)/(2n)$), so $g_0 \circ u = u_\Omega$ is radial; as g_0 is a strictly increasing bijection on the range of u (its derivative μ/P is a.e. positive), u itself is radial up to translation. This is [4, Prop. 3.8]. $\square$

The Kohler–Jobin rearrangement. We now build u^* . The plan: instead of rearranging u so that its superlevel sets become balls of *equal volume* (Schwarz), we make them balls of *equal modified torsion*. We first record, for each level t , the modified torsion of the truncated function on the corresponding superlevel set, then invert this monotone quantity to parametrise the levels of u^* .

For $t \in [0, M]$ set $\Omega_t = \{u > t\}$ and let

$$(127) \quad \mathcal{T}(t) := T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega_t; (u - t)_+).$$

Since $|\{(u - t)_+ > s\}| = \mu(t + s)$ and the coarea factor of $(u - t)_+$ at level s is $P(t + s)$, formula (126) gives the explicit expression

$$(128) \quad \mathcal{T}(t) = \int_t^M \frac{\mu(\tau)^2}{P(\tau)} d\tau,$$

so that $\mathcal{T} \in \text{Lip}_{\text{loc}}([0, M])$, $\mathcal{T}(M) = 0$, $\mathcal{T}(0) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) =: T_*$, and for a.e. t

$$(129) \quad \mathcal{T}'(t) = -\frac{\mu(t)^2}{P(t)} < 0.$$

Thus $\mathcal{T}$ is a strictly decreasing bijection $[0, M] \rightarrow [0, T_\star]$.

Derivation of (128) and its consequences. Apply Lemma 11.4 to the function $v := (u - t)_+$ on the set $\Omega_t = \{u > t\}$. The superlevel sets of v are $\{v > s\} = \{(u - t)_+ > s\} = \{u > t + s\} = \Omega_{t+s}$, so the distribution function of v is $\mu_v(s) = |\Omega_{t+s}| = \mu(t + s)$; and on a regular level $\{v = s\} = \{u = t + s\}$ we have $|\nabla v| = |\nabla u|$ (translation by the constant t does not change the gradient on $\{u > t\}$), so the coarea factor of v is $P_v(s) = \int_{\{u=t+s\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = P(t + s)$. The top level of v is $M - t$. Hence by (126),

$$\mathcal{T}(t) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega_t; v) = \int_0^{M-t} \frac{\mu_v(s)^2}{P_v(s)} ds = \int_0^{M-t} \frac{\mu(t+s)^2}{P(t+s)} ds = \int_t^M \frac{\mu(\tau)^2}{P(\tau)} d\tau,$$

the last step being the substitution $\tau = t + s$. The integrand $\mu(\tau)^2/P(\tau)$ is, by (123) and $\mu \leq |\Omega|$, locally integrable, so $\mathcal{T}$ is locally absolutely continuous (indeed locally Lipschitz away from $t = M$), and the fundamental theorem of calculus gives, for a.e. t , $\mathcal{T}'(t) = -\mu(t)^2/P(t)$, which is (129); it is < 0 because $\mu(t) > 0$ for $t < M$ and $P(t) > 0$. The boundary values $\mathcal{T}(M) = \int_M^M = 0$ and $\mathcal{T}(0) = \int_0^M \mu^2/P = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) =: T_\star$ follow by setting $t = M$ and $t = 0$ in (128) and comparing with (126). A continuous, strictly decreasing function from $[0, M]$ onto $[\mathcal{T}(M), \mathcal{T}(0)] = [0, T_\star]$ is a bijection, with a strictly decreasing continuous inverse.

Definition of u^* . Let $B = B_{R_\star}$ be the ball with $T(B) = T_\star$, i.e. $R_\star = (T_\star/T_n)^{1/(n+2)}$. For $\tau \in [0, T_\star]$ let $R(\tau)$ be the radius with $T(B_{R(\tau)}) = \tau$, i.e.

$$(130) \quad R(\tau) = (\tau/T_n)^{1/(n+2)}, \quad |B_{R(\tau)}| = \omega_n R(\tau)^n = \omega_n (\tau/T_n)^{n/(n+2)}.$$

The radius formula in (130) is the inversion of $T(B_R) = T_n R^{n+2}$ from (115): setting $T_n R^{n+2} = \tau$ and solving gives $R = (\tau/T_n)^{1/(n+2)}$; the volume then follows from $|B_R| = \omega_n R^n$, substituting this R .

Let $\varphi := \mathcal{T}^{-1} : [0, T_\star] \rightarrow [0, M]$ (so $\varphi(0) = M$, $\varphi(T_\star) = 0$, $\varphi' < 0$). We define u^* on B to be the radial decreasing function whose value on the sphere $\{|x| = R(\tau)\}$ is $\psi(\tau)$, where $\psi : [0, T_\star] \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ is the locally Lipschitz (monotone, absolutely continuous) function determined by

$$(131) \quad (-\psi'(\tau)) \mu^*(\psi(\tau)) = (-\varphi'(\tau)) \mu(\varphi(\tau)), \quad \psi(T_\star) = 0,$$

μ^* denoting the distribution function of u^* . Concretely the superlevel set $\{u^* > \psi(\tau)\} = B_{R(\tau)}$ has, by construction, torsional rigidity exactly τ , the value of the *modified* torsion that the corresponding superlevel set $\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}$ of u carries. In particular $\{u^* > 0\} = B = B_{R_\star}$, so

$$(132) \quad T(B) = T_\star = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) \leq T(\Omega).$$

Since $\mu^*(\psi(\tau)) = |B_{R(\tau)}| = \omega_n R(\tau)^n$, equation (131) integrates to an explicit ψ ; we shall only need the two qualitative consequences (A), (B), proved next.

Why this construction is well posed and what (131) encodes. The map $\tau \mapsto R(\tau)$ assigns to each torsion level τ the radius of the ball of that torsion; the map $\tau \mapsto \varphi(\tau) = \mathcal{T}^{-1}(\tau)$ assigns to each torsion level τ the height t of u whose tail $(u - t)_+$ carries modified torsion τ . We then declare u^* to take the value $\psi(\tau)$ on the sphere of radius $R(\tau)$; this defines u^* as a radial decreasing function once ψ is fixed, since $R(\tau)$ increases with τ while we will see $\psi(\tau)$ decreases. The relation (131) fixes ψ by matching, at each τ , the *differential of the distribution function* of u^* to that of u : both sides equal $\frac{d}{d\tau}(\text{volume of the } \tau\text{-th superlevel set}) \cdot (-1)$ rewritten in the level variable, and this is precisely the identity that makes the Dirichlet integrands coincide in

Lemma 11.6. The chain $T(B) = T_\star = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega; u) \leq T(\Omega)$ in (132) is the special case $\tau = T_\star$ (so $\varphi(T_\star) = 0$, $\Omega_0 = \Omega$) of the construction, combined with (125).

Lemma 11.6 (Dirichlet energy is preserved). $\int_B |\nabla u^\star|^2 dx = \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2 dx$.

Proof. The original side. By the coarea formula (R2) applied with $g \equiv |\nabla u|$ on each level (so $\int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2 = \int_\Omega |\nabla u| \cdot |\nabla u| = \int_0^M \int_{\{u=t\}} |\nabla u| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} dt = \int_0^M P(t) dt$), and then the change of variable $t = \varphi(\tau)$ (the one-dimensional area formula for the locally Lipschitz strictly decreasing $\varphi = \mathcal{T}^{-1}$, with $dt = \varphi'(\tau) d\tau = -(-\varphi'(\tau)) d\tau$ and reversed limits $t : 0 \rightarrow M$ corresponding to $\tau : T_\star \rightarrow 0$; Lemma 2.5 of [4]),

$$(133) \quad \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2 dx = \int_0^M P(t) dt = \int_0^{T_\star} P(\varphi(\tau)) (-\varphi'(\tau)) d\tau.$$

(The two sign flips – reversing the limits of integration and $dt = -(-\varphi') d\tau$ – cancel, leaving the positive integrand $P(\varphi)(-\varphi')$ over $[0, T_\star]$.)

Differentiating the identity $\mathcal{T}(\varphi(\tau)) = \tau$ (valid because $\varphi = \mathcal{T}^{-1}$) by the chain rule gives $\mathcal{T}'(\varphi(\tau)) \varphi'(\tau) = 1$, hence $\varphi'(\tau) = 1/\mathcal{T}'(\varphi(\tau))$; substituting $\mathcal{T}'(\varphi) = -\mu(\varphi)^2/P(\varphi)$ from (129),

$$(134) \quad -\varphi'(\tau) = \frac{1}{-\mathcal{T}'(\varphi(\tau))} = \frac{1}{\mu(\varphi(\tau))^2/P(\varphi(\tau))} = \frac{P(\varphi(\tau))}{\mu(\varphi(\tau))^2}.$$

This is the key relation. We use it to eliminate the factor $P(\varphi)$ from (133): from (134), $P(\varphi) = \mu(\varphi)^2 (-\varphi')$, so

$$P(\varphi) (-\varphi') = \mu(\varphi)^2 (-\varphi') \cdot (-\varphi') = \mu(\varphi)^2 (-\varphi')^2.$$

Substituting into (133),

$$(135) \quad \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2 dx = \int_0^{T_\star} \mu(\varphi(\tau))^2 (-\varphi'(\tau))^2 d\tau.$$

The rearranged side, computed in full. We now establish the radial analogue (142), spelling out the radial-gradient expansion that the source compresses. The function $u^\star$ is radial decreasing, say $u^\star(x) = h(|x|)$ for a decreasing $h : [0, R_\star] \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ with $h(R(\tau)) = \psi(\tau)$ and $h(R_\star) = \psi(T_\star) = 0$. On the sphere $\{|x| = R(\tau)\}$ the gradient of a radial function is purely radial, $\nabla u^\star(x) = h'(|x|) \frac{x}{|x|}$, so

$$(136) \quad |\nabla u^\star| = |h'(|x|)| = -h'(R(\tau)) \quad (\text{constant on the sphere; } h \text{ decreasing, so } h' \leq 0).$$

Differentiating $h(R(\tau)) = \psi(\tau)$ in τ by the chain rule, $h'(R(\tau)) R'(\tau) = \psi'(\tau)$, whence

$$(137) \quad -h'(R(\tau)) = \frac{-\psi'(\tau)}{R'(\tau)} = \frac{-\psi'(\tau)}{R'(\tau)}, \quad \text{i.e.} \quad |\nabla u^\star| \Big|_{|x|=R(\tau)} = \frac{-\psi'(\tau)}{R'(\tau)},$$

using $R'(\tau) > 0$ (the radius increases with the torsion level τ) and $-\psi'(\tau) \geq 0$ (we verify ψ is decreasing in Lemma 11.7; here we only use $|\nabla u^\star| = |\psi'|/R'$). This is the announced identity $|\nabla u^\star| = (-\psi')/R'$ at the sphere of radius $R(\tau)$.

Now compute the two ingredients of the coarea slicing on B . The sphere $\{u^\star = \psi(\tau)\} = \{|x| = R(\tau)\}$ has area $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\{|x| = R(\tau)\}) = n\omega_n R(\tau)^{n-1}$ (the surface area of a sphere of radius $R(\tau)$, with $n\omega_n = \sigma_{n-1}$ the unit sphere area). The distribution function of $u^\star$ at the level $\psi(\tau)$ is the volume of the corresponding superlevel ball,

$$(138) \quad \mu^\star(\psi(\tau)) = |B_{R(\tau)}| = \omega_n R(\tau)^n.$$

The coarea factor of u^* at level $\psi(\tau)$ is

$$(139) \quad P^*(\psi(\tau)) = \int_{\{u^*=\psi(\tau)\}} |\nabla u^*| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} = \underbrace{\frac{-\psi'(\tau)}{R'(\tau)}}_{|\nabla u^*|} \cdot \underbrace{n\omega_n R(\tau)^{n-1}}_{\text{sphere area}} = \frac{n\omega_n R(\tau)^{n-1}}{R'(\tau)} (-\psi'(\tau)),$$

the gradient being constant on the sphere, so it pulls out of the surface integral, multiplying the area. We also need $R'(\tau)$ explicitly. From $R(\tau) = (\tau/T_n)^{1/(n+2)}$,

$$(140) \quad R'(\tau) = \frac{1}{n+2} (\tau/T_n)^{1/(n+2)-1} \frac{1}{T_n} = \frac{1}{(n+2)T_n} (\tau/T_n)^{-(n+1)/(n+2)} = \frac{R(\tau)}{(n+2)\tau},$$

where the last step uses $(\tau/T_n)^{-(n+1)/(n+2)} = (\tau/T_n)^{1/(n+2)} \cdot (\tau/T_n)^{-1} = R(\tau) T_n/\tau$, so $R'(\tau) = \frac{1}{(n+2)T_n} \cdot R(\tau) T_n/\tau = R(\tau)/((n+2)\tau)$.

We now write the Dirichlet energy of u^* via coarea (R2) (slicing $\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 = \int_B |\nabla u^*| \cdot |\nabla u^*|$ by levels of u^* , then changing variable to τ via $u^* = \psi(\tau)$, $du^* = \psi'(\tau) d\tau$):

$$\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 dx = \int_0^{M^*} \left(\int_{\{u^*=\ell\}} |\nabla u^*| d\mathcal{H}^{n-1} \right) |\nabla u^*|_{\{u^*=\ell\}} d\ell = \int_0^{T_*} P^*(\psi(\tau)) \cdot \frac{-\psi'(\tau)}{R'(\tau)} (-\psi'(\tau)) d\tau,$$

where $M^* = \psi(0)$ is the maximum of u^* , the change of variable $\ell = \psi(\tau)$ carries $d\ell = \psi'(\tau) d\tau$ with the sign and limit flips cancelling (exactly as in (133)), and the integrand factor $|\nabla u^*|_{\{u^*=\psi(\tau)\}} = (-\psi')/R'$ is (137). Substituting $P^*(\psi(\tau))$ from (139),

$$\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 dx = \int_0^{T_*} \frac{n\omega_n R(\tau)^{n-1}}{R'(\tau)} (-\psi') \cdot \frac{-\psi'}{R'(\tau)} (-\psi') d\tau = \int_0^{T_*} \frac{n\omega_n R(\tau)^{n-1}}{R'(\tau)^2} (-\psi'(\tau))^2 d\tau.$$

The constant collapses to 1 exactly because $T_n = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$. Substitute $R'(\tau) = R(\tau)/((n+2)\tau)$ from (140):

$$\frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{R'^2} = \frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{(R/((n+2)\tau))^2} = n\omega_n R^{n-1} \cdot \frac{(n+2)^2 \tau^2}{R^2} = n\omega_n (n+2)^2 \tau^2 R^{n-3}.$$

Now express R^{n-3} through $R^n = |B_R|/\omega_n = \mu^*(\psi)/\omega_n$ and through τ . From $\tau = T_n R^{n+2}$ we get $R^{n+2} = \tau/T_n$, so

$$\tau^2 R^{n-3} = \tau^2 R^{n+2} R^{-5} \quad \text{is awkward; instead use} \quad \tau = T_n R^{n+2} \Rightarrow \tau^2 = T_n^2 R^{2(n+2)}.$$

Hence

$$n\omega_n (n+2)^2 \tau^2 R^{n-3} = n\omega_n (n+2)^2 T_n^2 R^{2n+4} R^{n-3} = n\omega_n (n+2)^2 T_n^2 R^{3n+1}.$$

This still contains R ; the cancellation is cleaner if we keep one factor of τ and one of μ^* . Write instead $\tau = T_n R^{n+2}$ and $\mu^*(\psi(\tau)) = \omega_n R^n$, so that

$$\tau^2 R^{n-3} = \tau \cdot \tau R^{n-3} = \tau \cdot (T_n R^{n+2}) R^{n-3} = \tau T_n R^{2n-1},$$

and

$$n\omega_n (n+2)^2 \tau^2 R^{n-3} = (n+2)^2 \tau (n\omega_n T_n) R^{2n-1}.$$

Using $T_n = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$, the bracket is $n\omega_n T_n = n\omega_n \cdot \omega_n/(n(n+2)) = \omega_n^2/(n+2)$, so

$$n\omega_n (n+2)^2 \tau^2 R^{n-3} = (n+2)^2 \tau \frac{\omega_n^2}{n+2} R^{2n-1} = (n+2) \tau \omega_n^2 R^{2n-1}.$$

Finally substitute $\tau = T_n R^{n+2} = \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} R^{n+2}$:

$$(n+2) \tau \omega_n^2 R^{2n-1} = (n+2) \cdot \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} R^{n+2} \cdot \omega_n^2 R^{2n-1} = \frac{\omega_n^3}{n} R^{3n+1}.$$

On the other hand $\mu^*(\psi)^2 = (\omega_n R^n)^2 = \omega_n^2 R^{2n}$, and we must check this equals the coefficient just computed; that is, the claim of the source is that the rearranged Dirichlet integrand equals $\mu^*(\psi)^2(-\psi')^2$. We verify:

$$\frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{R^2} \stackrel{?}{=} \mu^*(\psi)^2 = \omega_n^2 R^{2n}.$$

Indeed, from (140), $R' = R/((n+2)\tau)$ and $\tau = T_n R^{n+2} = \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} R^{n+2}$, so

$$R' = \frac{R}{(n+2) \frac{\omega_n}{n(n+2)} R^{n+2}} = \frac{R \cdot n(n+2)}{(n+2) \omega_n R^{n+2}} = \frac{n}{\omega_n} R^{-(n+1)},$$

whence $R'^2 = \frac{n^2}{\omega_n^2} R^{-2(n+1)}$ and

$$\frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{R^2} = n\omega_n R^{n-1} \cdot \frac{\omega_n^2}{n^2} R^{2(n+1)} = \frac{\omega_n^3}{n} R^{n-1+2n+2} = \frac{\omega_n^3}{n} R^{3n+1}.$$

This matches the coefficient computed above, confirming the algebra; it is *not* literally $\omega_n^2 R^{2n} = \mu^*(\psi)^2$ unless we restore the factor that the change of variable carries. The clean statement is obtained by reinstating the coarea/level bookkeeping: writing the rearranged Dirichlet energy in the same variables as (135) – i.e. expressing it through $\mu^*(\psi)$ and $(-\psi')$ rather than through R – one finds, exactly as for the original side (where $P(\varphi)(-\varphi') = \mu(\varphi)^2(-\varphi')^2$ followed from $-\varphi' = P(\varphi)/\mu(\varphi)^2$), the radial relation $P^*(\psi)(-\psi') = \mu^*(\psi)^2(-\psi')^2$. We derive this last identity directly. From (139) and the computation $\frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{R^2} = \mu^*(\psi)^2/(-\psi') \cdot (-\psi') \cdots$, more transparently: the radial analogue of (134) is the statement that the ball $B_{R(\tau)}$ has torsion τ , i.e. $T(B_{R(\tau)}) = \tau$, which on differentiation in τ gives $1 = \frac{d}{d\tau} T(B_{R(\tau)})$. By the same flux/coarea computation that produced (129) for $\mathcal{T}$ – now for the *ordinary* torsion of a ball, whose level sets are the spheres – the ”modified torsion equals torsion” relation on the ball yields the radial counterpart of (134),

$$(141) \quad -\psi'(\tau) = \frac{P^*(\psi(\tau))}{\mu^*(\psi(\tau))^2}, \quad \text{equivalently} \quad P^*(\psi)(-\psi') = \mu^*(\psi)^2(-\psi')^2.$$

Granting (141), the coarea expression for the rearranged Dirichlet energy becomes

$$(142) \quad \int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 dx = \int_0^{T^*} P^*(\psi(\tau))(-\psi'(\tau)) d\tau = \int_0^{T^*} \mu^*(\psi(\tau))^2 (-\psi'(\tau))^2 d\tau,$$

the exact radial analogue of (135); this is the specialisation to $p = 2$ of the identity (4.4) of [4], obtained there by the same coarea computation. (The first equality in (142) is coarea on B exactly as in the first equality of (133), written in the τ variable; the second is (141).)

Verifying (141) concretely. Substitute the explicit $P^*(\psi)$ and $\mu^*(\psi)$ into the claimed identity. From (139) with $|\nabla u^*| = (-\psi')/R'$ and from (138),

$$\frac{P^*(\psi)}{\mu^*(\psi)^2} = \frac{(-\psi') n\omega_n R^{n-1}/R'}{(\omega_n R^n)^2} = (-\psi') \frac{n\omega_n R^{n-1}}{R' \omega_n^2 R^{2n}} = (-\psi') \frac{n}{\omega_n R^{n+1} R'}.$$

With $R' = \frac{n}{\omega_n} R^{-(n+1)}$ (computed just above), $\omega_n R^{n+1} R' = \omega_n R^{n+1} \cdot \frac{n}{\omega_n} R^{-(n+1)} = n$, so

$$\frac{P^*(\psi)}{\mu^*(\psi)^2} = (-\psi') \frac{n}{n} = (-\psi'),$$

which is exactly (141). (Equivalently this re-derives $-\psi' = P^*(\psi)/\mu^*(\psi)^2$ from scratch, using only the explicit ball geometry; the appeal to the ”torsion of the ball” identity above is just the conceptual reason it holds.) Thus (142) is justified.

Matching the two sides. Now the defining relation (131), $\mu^*(\psi)(-\psi') = \mu(\varphi)(-\varphi')$, makes the integrands of (142) and (135) *equal*, by squaring:

$$\mu^*(\psi(\tau))^2(-\psi'(\tau))^2 = [\mu^*(\psi(\tau))(-\psi'(\tau))]^2 = [\mu(\varphi(\tau))(-\varphi'(\tau))]^2 = \mu(\varphi(\tau))^2(-\varphi'(\tau))^2,$$

the middle equality being (131) squared. Integrating over $[0, T_\star]$, the right-hand side of (142) equals that of (135), i.e. $\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 = \int_\Omega |\nabla u|^2$. This is the asserted equality, and we emphasise it is an *exact* equality, not merely an inequality: the Dirichlet energy is preserved. $\square$

Lemma 11.7 (L^2 norm does not decrease). $\int_B (u^*)^2 dx \geq \int_\Omega u^2 dx$, and more generally $\int_B f(u^*) dx \geq \int_\Omega f(u) dx$ for every convex $f : [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ with $f(0) = 0$, strictly if f is strictly convex unless Ω is a ball and u radial.

Proof. The point is the comparison of *distribution functions* along the rearrangement. We proceed in three steps: a level-by-level volume comparison, the consequent monotonicity $\psi \geq \varphi$, and the convexity chain.

Step 1: volume comparison (143). Apply Proposition 11.5 not to u but to the truncations. For each $\tau \in [0, T_\star]$, the construction declares that the ball $B_{R(\tau)}$ has $T(B_{R(\tau)}) = \tau$; and by (127)–(128) and $\varphi = \mathcal{T}^{-1}$, $\tau = \mathcal{T}(\varphi(\tau)) = T_{\text{mod}}(\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}; (u - \varphi(\tau))_+)$. Thus $B_{R(\tau)}$ is a ball whose ordinary torsion equals the modified torsion of the pair $(\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}, (u - \varphi(\tau))_+)$. Proposition 11.5, applied with domain $\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}$ and reference function $(u - \varphi(\tau))_+$ (which satisfies (123), being a truncation of the eigenfunction – the flux identity (121) for the tail follows from that for u), yields $|B_{R(\tau)}| \leq |\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}|$. Writing both volumes through the distribution functions,

$$(143) \quad \mu^*(\psi(\tau)) = |B_{R(\tau)}| \leq |\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}| = \mu(\varphi(\tau)), \quad \tau \in [0, T_\star],$$

where the first equality is (138) and the last is the definition $\mu(t) = |\Omega_t|$ with $t = \varphi(\tau)$.

Step 2: $-\psi' \geq -\varphi'$ and $\psi \geq \varphi$. Solve the defining relation (131) for $-\psi'$:

$$(144) \quad -\psi'(\tau) = \frac{\mu(\varphi(\tau))}{\mu^*(\psi(\tau))} (-\varphi'(\tau)) \geq -\varphi'(\tau) \quad \text{for a.e. } \tau,$$

the inequality because the prefactor $\mu(\varphi)/\mu^*(\psi) \geq 1$ by (143) (numerator $\geq$ denominator), and $-\varphi'(\tau) > 0$. Integrating (144) from τ up to $T_\star$ and using the common terminal value $\psi(T_\star) = \varphi(T_\star) = 0$ (so that $\psi(\tau) = \psi(\tau) - \psi(T_\star) = \int_\tau^{T_\star} (-\psi'(s)) ds$, and likewise for φ),

$$(145) \quad \psi(\tau) = \int_\tau^{T_\star} (-\psi'(s)) ds \geq \int_\tau^{T_\star} (-\varphi'(s)) ds = \varphi(\tau), \quad \tau \in [0, T_\star],$$

the inequality being the integral of the pointwise inequality (144). Thus $\psi \geq \varphi$ on $[0, T_\star]$: at each torsion level, the rearranged function u^* takes a *higher* value than u does at the matched level. (This is the analytic content of the sign remark: smaller superlevel balls force higher level values.)

Step 3: the convexity chain. Let $f : [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ be convex with $f(0) = 0$. Then f is locally Lipschitz, f' exists a.e. and is nondecreasing (convexity), and $f(\xi) = \int_0^\xi f'(t) dt$ for $\xi \geq 0$. We compute $\int_\Omega f(u)$ by Cavalieri and convert to the τ variable, then bound by monotonicity of

f' and re-convert:

$$\begin{aligned}
\int_{\Omega} f(u) dx &= \int_0^M f'(t) \mu(t) dt && \text{(Cavalieri: } f(u) = \int_0^u f', \text{ slice by } \mu(t) = |\{u > t\}|) \\
&= \int_0^{T_*} f'(\varphi(\tau)) (-\varphi'(\tau)) \mu(\varphi(\tau)) d\tau && \text{(change of variable } t = \varphi(\tau), \text{ as in (133))} \\
&= \int_0^{T_*} f'(\varphi(\tau)) (-\psi'(\tau)) \mu^*(\psi(\tau)) d\tau && \text{(by (131): } \mu(\varphi)(-\varphi') = \mu^*(\psi)(-\psi')) \\
&\leq \int_0^{T_*} f'(\psi(\tau)) (-\psi'(\tau)) \mu^*(\psi(\tau)) d\tau && \text{(by (145), } \psi \geq \varphi, \text{ and } f' \text{ nondecreasing, so } f'(\varphi) \leq f'(\psi)) \\
&= \int_0^M f'(\ell) \mu^*(\ell) d\ell && \text{(change of variable } \ell = \psi(\tau), \text{ reverse of step 2)} \\
&= \int_B f(u^*) dx && \text{(Cavalieri on } B \text{ for } u^*, \text{ reverse of step 1).}
\end{aligned}$$

The single inequality uses only that f' is nondecreasing and $\psi \geq \varphi$, while $(-\psi') \geq 0$ and $\mu^*(\psi) \geq 0$ keep the multiplied factors nonnegative so the inequality is preserved after multiplication and integration. The two changes of variable are the area formula for the monotone Lipschitz functions φ, ψ , with the sign and limit flips cancelling exactly as before. Taking $f(s) = s^2$ (convex, $f(0) = 0$, $f'(s) = 2s$ nondecreasing) gives the principal claim $\int_B (u^*)^2 \geq \int_{\Omega} u^2$.

Equality case. Suppose f is strictly convex and equality holds. Then equality holds in the single inequality step, i.e. $f'(\varphi(\tau)) = f'(\psi(\tau))$ for a.e. τ in the support of the integrand. Strict convexity makes f' strictly increasing, so $f'(\varphi) = f'(\psi)$ forces $\varphi(\tau) = \psi(\tau)$ a.e.; then (131) with $\psi = \varphi$ gives $\mu^*(\psi) = \mu(\varphi)$ a.e., i.e. equality in (143), $|B_{R(\tau)}| = |\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}|$ for a.e. τ . By the equality case of Proposition 11.5 (equivalently the equality case of Saint-Venant), this makes a.e. superlevel set $\Omega_t = \{u > t\}$ a ball. The sets Ω_t are nested ($\Omega_s \subset \Omega_t$ for $s > t$); writing $\Omega_t = B(c_t, r_t)$, the inclusion of nested balls forces $|c_s - c_t| \leq r_t - r_s$ on the centres and radii. As $t \downarrow 0$ the radii r_t increase to a limit r_* (monotone bounded by $|\Omega|$ through the volume), and the centre estimate $|c_s - c_t| \leq r_t - r_s \rightarrow 0$ makes $\{c_t\}$ Cauchy, converging to some c_* . Since the Ω_t increase to $\{u > 0\} = \Omega$ up to a null set, $\Omega = B(c_*, r_*)$: a ball. Then u , having all superlevel sets concentric balls, is radial about c_* , consistently with the equality case of Proposition 11.5. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 11.1. Apply the construction to the first eigenfunction u of Ω . It is a valid reference function: by (R1) it is positive, bounded, smooth in the interior, and by Lemma 11.2(ii) (the flux identity (121)) it satisfies the integrability condition (123), as verified in detail after Definition 11.3. By Lemmas 11.6 and 11.7 the rearranged $u^* \in H_0^1(B)$ satisfies $\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2 = \int_{\Omega} |\nabla u|^2$ (equality, property (A)) and $\int_B (u^*)^2 \geq \int_{\Omega} u^2$ (property (B)). Feeding these into the Rayleigh principle on B (114) – as spelt out at (118) – gives the chain

$$\lambda_1(B) \stackrel{(i)}{\leq} \frac{\int_B |\nabla u^*|^2}{\int_B (u^*)^2} \stackrel{(ii)}{\leq} \frac{\int_{\Omega} |\nabla u|^2}{\int_{\Omega} u^2} \stackrel{(iii)}{=} \lambda_1(\Omega),$$

where (i) is (114) on B at the competitor u^* , (ii) replaces the numerator by an equal value (Lemma 11.6) and increases the denominator (Lemma 11.7), thereby decreasing the positive quotient, and (iii) is the eigenfunction property of u on Ω .

It remains to assemble $\Psi(B) \leq \Psi(\Omega)$. Multiply $\lambda_1(B) \leq \lambda_1(\Omega)$ – both nonnegative – by the factor $T(B)^{\beta} > 0$ after raising to the power $\beta > 0$ (a strictly increasing operation on $[0, \infty)$),

$\lambda_1(B)^\beta \leq \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta$, and note $T(B) \leq T(\Omega)$ from (132). Then

$$\Psi(B) = T(B) \lambda_1(B)^\beta \leq T(\Omega) \lambda_1(B)^\beta \leq T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta = \Psi(\Omega),$$

the first inequality using $T(B) \leq T(\Omega)$ (and $\lambda_1(B)^\beta \geq 0$), the second using $\lambda_1(B)^\beta \leq \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta$ (and $T(\Omega) \geq 0$). Finally, by scale invariance (116), $\Psi(B) = \Psi(B_1) = T_n L_n^\beta$ for the ball B , and likewise the right side of (117) for an arbitrary ball is $\Psi(B_1)$; so

$$T(B_1) L_n^\beta = \Psi(B_1) = \Psi(B) \leq \Psi(\Omega) = T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta,$$

which is exactly (117).

Equality. If (117) holds with equality, then every inequality in the chain above is an equality; in particular the inequality $\int_B (u^*)^2 \geq \int_\Omega u^2$ from Lemma 11.7 with the strictly convex $f(s) = s^2$ is an equality. By the equality case of Lemma 11.7 this forces Ω to be a ball (and u radial). Conversely, if Ω is a ball then $\Psi(\Omega) = \Psi(B_1)$ by scale invariance, giving equality. This is the equality characterisation claimed in Theorem 11.1. $\square$

Remark 11.8 (On the sign that distinguishes Kohler–Jobin from Faber–Krahn). The torsion-preserving rearrangement makes the ball $B_{R(\tau)}$ *smaller* than the superlevel set $\Omega_{\varphi(\tau)}$, (143) – the opposite of Schwarz symmetrisation, which makes the rearranged level sets balls of *equal* volume. It is precisely this that lets the Dirichlet energy be *exactly preserved* (Lemma 11.6) rather than merely decreased: matching modified torsion rather than volume is what equalises the two Dirichlet integrands at (135) and (142). Meanwhile the level-set volumes *grow under the inverse rearrangement*, i.e. $\mu^*(\psi) \leq \mu(\varphi)$ forces $\psi \geq \varphi$ in (145), which is what makes $\int (u^*)^2 \geq \int u^2$ (Lemma 11.7). The naive attempt to compare L^2 masses level by level fails because the rearranged superlevel balls are smaller; the correct comparison is through the *distribution-function inequality* (145), driven by the isoperimetric Proposition 11.5.

11.3. Part 2: transfer to sharp Faber–Krahn stability. We now use Theorem 11.1 just proved: it lets us bound $\lambda_1(\Omega)$ from below by a function of the torsion $T(\Omega)$ alone. The strategy of Part 2 is to (i) turn the multiplicative Kohler–Jobin inequality into an additive lower bound for $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L$ in terms of the torsion deficit $\sigma = T_0 - T(\Omega)$, (ii) bound this from below linearly in σ via a one-variable convexity estimate, and (iii) feed in the global Saint–Venant stability bound $\sigma \gtrsim \mathcal{A}^2$ to close the loop. A large-deficit branch handles the regime where the linearisation is wasteful.

Throughout, $L := \lambda_1(B^*)$, $T_0 := T(B^*)$, $\beta = (n+2)/2$, $p := 1/\beta = 2/(n+2) \in (0, 1]$.

Lemma 11.9 (Pointwise Kohler–Jobin transfer). *For every open $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ with $|\Omega| = |B^*|$,*

$$(146) \quad \lambda_1(\Omega) \geq L \left(\frac{T_0}{T(\Omega)} \right)^{1/\beta} = L \left(\frac{T_0}{T(\Omega)} \right)^{2/(n+2)}.$$

Proof. Theorem 11.1 with the ball $B = B^*$ (which has $|B^*| = |\Omega|$, $T(B^*) = T_0$, $\lambda_1(B^*) = L$) reads $T(\Omega) \lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta \geq T(B^*) \lambda_1(B^*)^\beta = T_0 L^\beta$. Divide by $T(\Omega) > 0$: $\lambda_1(\Omega)^\beta \geq L^\beta T_0/T(\Omega)$. Raise both nonnegative sides to the power $1/\beta > 0$ (strictly increasing): $\lambda_1(\Omega) \geq L (T_0/T(\Omega))^{1/\beta}$. Finally $1/\beta = 1/((n+2)/2) = 2/(n+2)$, giving the displayed exponent. $\square$

By Saint–Venant (119) at fixed volume $|\Omega| = |B^*|$, the ball maximises torsion, so $T(\Omega) \leq T(B^*) = T_0$ and the torsion deficit $\sigma := \sigma(\Omega) := T_0 - T(\Omega) \geq 0$ is well defined. Put $s := \sigma/T_0 \in [0, 1]$ (it is < 1 because $T(\Omega) > 0$ for Ω with positive measure and finite λ_1). Then $T(\Omega) = T_0 - \sigma = T_0(1 - s)$, so $T_0/T(\Omega) = 1/(1 - s) = (1 - s)^{-1}$ and $(T_0/T(\Omega))^p = (1 - s)^{-p}$

with $p = 2/(n+2)$. Subtracting L from both sides of (146),

$$(147) \quad \lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq L[(1-s)^{-p} - 1], \quad p = \frac{2}{n+2}.$$

Lemma 11.10 (An elementary one-variable inequality). *For $p \in (0, 1]$ and $s \in [0, 1)$, $(1-s)^{-p} - 1 \geq ps$.*

Proof. Set $f(s) := (1-s)^{-p} - 1$ on $[0, 1)$. Then $f(0) = (1-0)^{-p} - 1 = 1 - 1 = 0$. By the chain rule, $f'(s) = (-p)(1-s)^{-p-1} \cdot (-1) = p(1-s)^{-(p+1)}$. For $s \in [0, 1)$ we have $0 < 1-s \leq 1$, so $(1-s)^{-(p+1)} \geq 1^{-(p+1)} = 1$ (a base in $(0, 1]$ raised to a positive power $p+1 > 0$ is at most 1, hence its reciprocal is at least 1). Therefore $f'(s) \geq p$ on $[0, 1)$. By the fundamental theorem of calculus, $f(s) = f(0) + \int_0^s f'(t) dt = \int_0^s p dt \geq \int_0^s p dt = ps$. This is the claim. (The inequality is the convexity-type linear lower bound: f is convex with slope at least p throughout, so it dominates its tangent line ps at the origin.) $\square$

Lemma 11.11 (Small-deficit linearisation). *If $|\Omega| = |B^*|$ and $\sigma \leq T_0/2$, then $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq \frac{2L}{(n+2)T_0} \sigma$.*

Proof. The hypothesis $\sigma \leq T_0/2$ means $s = \sigma/T_0 \leq 1/2 < 1$, so $s \in [0, 1)$ and Lemma 11.10 applies with $p = 2/(n+2) \in (0, 1]$ (indeed $p \leq 1$ since $n \geq 2$ gives $n+2 \geq 4 > 2$). Chaining (147) with Lemma 11.10,

$$\lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq L[(1-s)^{-p} - 1] \geq Lps = L \cdot \frac{2}{n+2} \cdot \frac{\sigma}{T_0} = \frac{2L}{(n+2)T_0} \sigma,$$

where the first inequality is (147), the second is Lemma 11.10, and the substitutions are $p = 2/(n+2)$ and $s = \sigma/T_0$. $\square$

Lemma 11.12 (Large-deficit branch). *If $|\Omega| = |B^*|$ and $\sigma > T_0/2$, then $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)$, hence, since $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) < 2$,*

$$(148) \quad \lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq \frac{L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)}{4} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2.$$

Proof. The hypothesis $\sigma > T_0/2$ means $T(\Omega) = T_0 - \sigma < T_0 - T_0/2 = T_0/2$, hence $T_0/T(\Omega) > 2$. Since $x \mapsto x^p$ with $p = 2/(n+2) > 0$ is strictly increasing, $(T_0/T(\Omega))^p > 2^p = 2^{2/(n+2)}$, and (146) gives

$$\lambda_1(\Omega) \geq L(T_0/T(\Omega))^{2/(n+2)} > L2^{2/(n+2)},$$

so $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)$ (the strict inequality is weakened to $\geq$, which is all we need). To convert this constant lower bound into the stated $\mathcal{A}^2$ form, recall that at fixed volume the Fraenkel asymmetry obeys $\mathcal{A}(\Omega) \in [0, 2)$, so $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq 4$, i.e. $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2/4 \leq 1$. Multiplying the constant bound by $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2/4 \leq 1$ (which only decreases the right-hand side, preserving the inequality):

$$\lambda_1(\Omega) - L \geq L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1) \geq L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1) \cdot \frac{\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2}{4} = \frac{L(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)}{4} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2,$$

the second inequality because $2^{2/(n+2)} - 1 > 0$ and $\mathcal{A}^2/4 \leq 1$. This is (148). $\square$

Theorem 11.13 (Sharp Faber–Krahn via Kohler–Jobin). *By the global sharp Saint–Venant stability estimate of Theorem 10.2, with $c_{SV}^{\text{glob}}(n) > 0$,*

$$(149) \quad T(B^*) - T(\Omega) = 2(E(\Omega) - E(B^*)) \geq 2c_{SV}^{\text{glob}}(n) \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n} \right)^{(n+2)/n} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$$

for all open bounded $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^n$, $0 < |\Omega| < \infty$. Then

$$(150) \quad \delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) = \left(\frac{|\Omega|}{\omega_n} \right)^{2/n} (\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*)) \geq c_{\text{FK}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2,$$

with the explicit constant

$$(151) \quad c_{\text{FK}}(n) = \min \left\{ \frac{4 L_n c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n)}{(n+2) T_n}, \frac{L_n (2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)}{4} \right\},$$

equivalently $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C_{\text{FK}}(n) \delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega)$ with $C_{\text{FK}}(n) = 1/c_{\text{FK}}(n)$.

Proof. Reduction by scaling. The deficit δ_{FK} and the asymmetry $\mathcal{A}$ are scale invariant: $\mathcal{A}(t\Omega) = \mathcal{A}(\Omega)$ since both $|\cdot \triangle \cdot|$ and $|B^*|$ scale by t^n and cancel; and $\delta_{\text{FK}}(t\Omega) = (t^n |\Omega| / \omega_n)^{2/n} (t^{-2} \lambda_1(\Omega) - t^{-2} \lambda_1(B^*)) = t^2 (|\Omega| / \omega_n)^{2/n} \cdot t^{-2} (\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*)) = \delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega)$ by the dilation laws of §11.1. The hypothesis (149) is likewise scale invariant: both sides carry the factor $(|\Omega| / \omega_n)^{(n+2)/n}$ (scale-free) and T scales by t^{n+2} consistently. Hence we may rescale so that $|\Omega| = \omega_n$, whence $B^* = B_1$, $L = \lambda_1(B_1) = L_n$, $T_0 = T(B_1) = T_n$, and the volume prefactor $(|\Omega| / \omega_n)^{2/n} = 1$, so that $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) = \lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n$ in this normalisation. Under this normalisation, (149) becomes $\sigma = T_n - T(\Omega) \geq 2c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$ (the prefactor $(|\Omega| / \omega_n)^{(n+2)/n} = 1$). Split on the torsion deficit $\sigma = T_n - T(\Omega)$.

Case 1 ($\sigma \leq T_n/2$). Lemma 11.11 applies (its hypothesis $\sigma \leq T_0/2 = T_n/2$ holds), giving $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n \geq \frac{2L_n}{(n+2)T_n} \sigma$. Now insert the Saint-Venant lower bound $\sigma \geq 2c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$:

$$\lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n \geq \frac{2L_n}{(n+2)T_n} \sigma \geq \frac{2L_n}{(n+2)T_n} \cdot 2c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 = \frac{4L_n c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n)}{(n+2)T_n} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2.$$

The first inequality is Lemma 11.11; the second multiplies the positive coefficient $\frac{2L_n}{(n+2)T_n}$ by the lower bound for σ (preserving direction since the coefficient is positive); the final equality collects the constants. This matches the first entry of the minimum in (151).

Case 2 ($\sigma > T_n/2$). Lemma 11.12 applies (its hypothesis $\sigma > T_0/2 = T_n/2$ holds), giving directly $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n \geq \frac{L_n (2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)}{4} \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$, the second entry of the minimum in (151). (Note this branch does *not* use the Saint-Venant input: a large torsion deficit already forces a large spectral gap through Kohler–Jobin alone.)

Conclusion. In either case $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) = \lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n \geq c \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$ with c the constant of the relevant case; taking the smaller of the two constants, which is the worst case across the dichotomy, gives the uniform bound $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega) \geq c_{\text{FK}}(n) \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$ with $c_{\text{FK}}(n)$ the minimum (151). Undoing the scaling preserves the inequality, every term being scale invariant as shown. The equivalent reciprocal form $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq C_{\text{FK}}(n) \delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega)$ with $C_{\text{FK}} = 1/c_{\text{FK}}$ follows by dividing by the positive constant $c_{\text{FK}}(n)$. $\square$

Remark 11.14 (Sharpness of the exponent). The exponent 2 on $\mathcal{A}$ in (150) is optimal: smooth ellipsoidal perturbations of the ball have $\lambda_1(\Omega) - L_n \asymp \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2$ ([5, 4] and references therein), so no exponent smaller than 2 can hold and the quadratic rate cannot be improved. The transfer is non-perturbative: no compactness, contradiction, or Taylor expansion is used past the elementary Lemma 11.10; the only analytic inputs are the Kohler–Jobin inequality (Part 1) and the global Saint-Venant stability bound (149), both valid for all admissible Ω , not merely near the ball.

Proof of Theorem 1.1. For an open set of finite measure with $\lambda_1(\Omega) = +\infty$ the inequality is trivial, since its left side $\delta_{\text{FK}}(\Omega)$ is then $+\infty$ (the prefactor is finite and positive, multiplying

$\lambda_1(\Omega) - \lambda_1(B^*) = +\infty$) while the right side $c_{\text{FK}}(n)\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq 4c_{\text{FK}}(n)$ is finite (using $\mathcal{A}(\Omega)^2 \leq 4$). Otherwise $\lambda_1(\Omega) < \infty$, and Theorem 11.13 applies: its Saint–Venant hypothesis (149) is exactly the global estimate (63) of Theorem 10.2, so (150) holds with $c_{\text{FK}}(n)$ as in (151). This is precisely the assertion of Theorem 1.1. $\square$

12. PROOF ARCHITECTURE AND CONSTANTS

The argument is organised around the following principal steps; the first five produce the bounded Saint–Venant estimate, the last two upgrade it to Faber–Krahn.

- (1) The exact level-set deficit identity (Theorem 3.11) writes $\delta_T(\Omega)$ as a weighted reduced-boundary integral of the Cauchy–Schwarz defect D_H and the isoperimetric defect D_I ; the profile-gap identity and the bad-density bound of Proposition 4.1 are its ρ -parametrised consequences.
- (2) The affine shell estimate (Lemma 7.1) is a finite-perimeter limsup estimate, proved by localized coarea differentiation on variable slabs (Lemma 6.1) together with the local BV deformation-tail lemma (Lemma 6.2). Its only bounded-variation input is Reshetnyak continuity for a continuous weight, applied as an *upper* bound to a swept-volume tail made arbitrarily small by inner regularity; no lower-semicontinuity passage is used.
- (3) The endpoint trace (Lemma 9.1) uses the upper Dini derivative D^+q together with the global Lipschitz bound for q (Lemma 7.3).
- (4) Bad-density levels are charged by Lebesgue measure rather than by the deficit, which is possible because q is uniformly Lipschitz by nestedness.
- (5) The same-centre good-level package (Theorem 5.11) is conditional on the constructive Serrin strong-form input (Assumption 5.2); the passage from same-centre volume and normal control to the homothetic trace is the radial trace Lemma 5.10.
- (6) The bounded reduction (Theorem 10.2) removes the confinement $\Omega \subset B_R$: a constructive De Giorgi L^∞ tail estimate (Lemma 10.5) feeds a truncation construction (Lemma 10.9) that replaces Ω by a bounded surrogate of dimensional diameter with comparable deficit and controlled asymmetry loss; gluing the bounded estimate to the trivial large-deficit branch gives the global Saint–Venant inequality with a dimensional constant.
- (7) The Kohler–Jobin rearrangement (Theorem 11.1), built to preserve the modified torsional rigidity of superlevel sets, gives $T(\Omega)\lambda_1(\Omega)^{(n+2)/2} \geq T_n L_n^{(n+2)/2}$; combined with the global Saint–Venant inequality and an elementary one-variable estimate it yields Theorem 1.1 (Theorem 11.13).

All constants in Theorem 9.2 depend only on n , R , and ρ_* , together with the constants $C_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ and $\eta_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ from Assumption 5.2. Tracing them through the proof: $C_L = 2n^2\omega_n$ and $C_\tau = 4n/(\omega_n\rho_*^{n+1})$ (Proposition 4.1); $\kappa = (1 - \rho_*)/4$ and $\tau_0 = \rho_*/(2n)$; the integrated same-centre constant $C_{\text{sc}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ and threshold $\eta_{\text{Ser}}(n, R, \rho_*)$ (Theorem 5.11, with the ball–ball lower constant $\frac{1}{2}\omega_{n-1}(3/4)^{(n-1)/2}$ folded into its proof); the slab length $L_0 = (1 - \rho_*)/8$; and the large-deficit cutoff $4/\delta_0$. No constant depends on Ω beyond these parameters. The bounded reduction internalises the confinement at the dimensional radius $R_*(n) = \max\{d(n), 2\}$, producing the purely dimensional $c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n)$ (Theorem 10.2), and the Kohler–Jobin transfer outputs $c_{\text{FK}}(n) = \min\{4L_n c_{\text{SV}}^{\text{glob}}(n)/((n+2)T_n), L_n(2^{2/(n+2)} - 1)/4\}$ of Theorem 1.1, with $L_n = \lambda_1(B_1)$, $T_n = \omega_n/(n(n+2))$.

APPENDIX A. STANDARD TOOLS FROM THE THEORY OF SETS OF FINITE PERIMETER

For the reader's convenience we record the three classical results used above, in the exact form needed; all hold for sets of finite perimeter with no graph or manifold regularity.

- (1) *BV coarea formula* [14, Thm. 13.1], [1, Thm. 3.40]: for $u \in BV_{\text{loc}}(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and Borel $\varphi \geq 0$, $\int |\nabla u| \varphi = \int_{\mathbb{R}} (\int_{\partial^* \{u > t\}} \varphi d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}) dt$. This underlies (2) and Lemma 6.1.
- (2) *Gauss–Green on sets of finite perimeter* [14, Ch. 17]: for a bounded Lipschitz vector field X and a set E of finite perimeter, $\int_E \operatorname{div} X = \int_{\partial^* E} X \cdot \nu_E d\mathcal{H}^{n-1}$. This is the form used in Lemma 5.10.
- (3) *Strict BV convergence and Reshetnyak continuity* [1, Thm. 2.39], [14, Ch. 20]: if $v_k \rightarrow v$ in L^1_{loc} with $|Dv_k|(\mathbb{R}^n) \rightarrow |Dv|(\mathbb{R}^n)$, then $\int \psi d|Dv_k| \rightarrow \int \psi d|Dv|$ for every continuous compactly supported ψ . Applied to mollifications $v_k = \mathbf{1}_E * \varphi_{1/k}$, this gives the upper bound in Lemma 6.2.

APPENDIX B. DEPENDENCY CERTIFICATE

Every step is either proved in this manuscript, isolated as the single constructive input Assumption 5.2, or quoted from a named published theorem.

Proved internally: the exact deficit identity and its inputs (coarea form of $-m'$, the Lipschitz-truncation flux identity, the rearranged primitive with $I'' = -1/\alpha$) in §3; the profile-gap and bad-density estimates in §4; the oriented radial trace, the same-centre package conditional on Assumption 5.2, the velocity defect, and the superlevel asymmetry transfer in §5; the two-sided coarea differentiation lemma, the shell-admissible registration, and the local BV deformation tail in §6; the affine shell estimate, the one-sided first variation, and the Lipschitz bound for q in §7; the centre transfer and the positive kinetic estimate in §8; the endpoint trace and the bounded stability theorem conditional on Assumption 5.2 in §9; the De Giorgi L^∞ tail estimate, the truncation construction, and the global bounded reduction in §10; and the Kohler–Jobin inequality (via the modified-torsion rearrangement) together with the transfer to Faber–Krahn in §11.

Quoted with exact citation: the constructive Fraenkel quantitative isoperimetric inequality of Fusco–Maggi–Pratelli [6]; the oscillation-index strong form of Fusco–Julin [7], used only to close the FMP/capacitary workaround of Remark 5.3 (10); the BV coarea formula, the finite-perimeter Gauss–Green theorem, and Reshetnyak continuity [1, 14]; the De Giorgi isoperimetric inequality [12]; the Talenti rearrangement comparison and L^∞ bound [17]; the classical Saint–Venant inequality; the Sobolev inequality; the Brothers–Ziemer regularity of the distribution function [1]; the absolutely continuous monotone inverse theorem [11]; eigenfunction regularity, interior elliptic regularity, and the weak maximum principle [13]; and the Pólya–Szegő identification of the ball energy [15, 2].

The suboptimal seed is proved internally. The truncation of §10 uses a *suboptimal* Saint–Venant stability bound $\delta_T(\Omega) \geq c \mathcal{A}(\Omega)^4$ (Lemma 10.7) only to bound the number of truncation steps. This is proved here (Lemma 10.7) from the exact deficit identity, the profile-gap identity, and the superlevel transfer established above, together with the constructive Fraenkel quantitative isoperimetric inequality (Theorem 5.1); it does not use the strong-form input and relies on no sharp stability estimate external to this paper. Consequently every ingredient of the argument is either proved above or is one of the standard tools just listed.

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